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The Sunday EXPRESS

**EYE**

POWER OF A SHARED JOKE

Laughter as a social emotion, the evolution of satire, and what makes for a healthy democracy

SCREENAs *Dil Chahta Hai* completes 25 years, Farhan Akhtar recalls the instinct and experimentation that went into it

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

Happening today

● **THE BJP** government in West Bengal will complete its first 100 days in office. The administration and the party have planned a series of events to mark the occasion.

● **VICE PRESIDENT** C P Radhakrishnan will begin a two-day visit to Tamil Nadu to participate in a series of events.

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Under fire for his blackball order, Bar Council chief says sorry to law students

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 15

FACING CRITICISM over his now-withdrawn directive, Bar Council of India (BCI) chairman Manan Kumar Mishra issued an apology to law students on Saturday, saying that "peaceful disagreement, questioning and protest are important features of a constitutional democracy" and "students must always remain free to express their views".

On Thursday, Mishra had issued a directive barring the 2026 graduating batch of NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, from enrolling with state Bar councils and seeking an inquiry to identify students behind a campaign against inviting Chief Justice of India Surya Kant for the university's convocation. The directive was rolled back within hours.

In a letter on Saturday, Mishra said: "The developments of the last few days have caused concern and anguish among a section of the student community. Whenever students feel hurt or aggrieved, their concerns deserve to be heard with patience, sensitivity and respect. If anything connected with the present controversy, any of my words, or letter, has hurt the feelings of our law students, I sincerely regret and apologise for the same. There should be no hesitation in saying so. An expression of regret is not a matter of prestige or ego. It is simply an

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

JANTAR MANTAR ECHO AT RED FORT: 80TH INDEPENDENCE DAY ADDRESS

Youth will power our journey to Viksit Bharat 2047, says PM

Modi underlines reform push along seven streams, manufacturing to soft power; free online exam coaching, AI training for 1 crore, talent hunt for 2036 Olympics

Manoj C G
New Delhi, August 15

MARKING THE 80th Independence Day in the shadow of the Jantar Mantar protests by the youth — which saw the resignation of a Union Minister and the promise of exam reform — Prime Minister Narendra Modi Saturday underlined "yuva shakti" (youth power) assuring them that the Government was committed to fulfilling their dreams. Calling them the biggest beneficiaries (*labharthi*) of India's development journey, he urged the youth to step up and become agents of change.

Addressing the nation on Independence Day, Modi announced free online coaching for those preparing for competitive exams, training for 1 crore youth in AI skills and a concerted action plan to expand and nurture sporting tal-

“When I speak of taking the country forward at a rapid pace, who is the greatest beneficiary of all these efforts? Who is the greatest force driving these efforts? If there is one, it is the youth of my country.”

PM NARENDRA MODI

ent for the 2036 Olympics. As their duty, he called upon the young to take part in the national Census and help their family digitize their household data which, he said, was key to policy-making.

Towards the end of his

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM red-flags 'dimagi Naxal', Opp says bid to curb dissent, tar rivals

Manoj C G
New Delhi, August 15

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's call Saturday to identify and isolate "dimagi Naxals" (those with a Maoist mindset) who were "looking for ways of violence and anarchy", drew sharp criticism from the Opposition parties, which accused him of using labels to target dissent and suppress his political rivals that, they said, will pave the way for "a one-party rule and eventually dictatorship".

In his Independence Day speech from the ramparts of the Red Fort, his 13th consecutive address, Modi said while armed Naxalism was nearing its end in

INSIDE PAGE 6 ROW ERUPTS AS KERALA SKIPS VANDE MATARAM

the jungles, their ideological sympathisers were seeking opportunities to create unrest in the country. He said while Maoists, who had killed more than 3,500 security personnel and left the land soaked in blood, are breathing their last after years of security operations against them, "we must not underestimate this challenge".

"We need to be even more

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Prime Minister Narendra Modi unfurls the Tricolour at the Red Fort in Delhi on Saturday. TASHI TOBGYAL

Question mark on Rahman visit as Delhi, Dhaka push to dial down chill

Hasina's extradition core issue for Dhaka, energy shortage, bilateral ties open window

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 15

INTENSE NEGOTIATIONS are on between Delhi and Dhaka over ousted Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's continued presence in India, her recent statements and their potential to adversely affect bilateral ties including a visit by

Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Rahman's visit was scheduled for August 21 and is now an issue on the diplomatic table. Indian and Bangladeshi diplomats and security officials are working towards navigating the turbulence in the relationship,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Bangladesh PM Tarique Rahman with Indian envoy Dinesh Trivedi in Dhaka on August 10. FILE

India courts will decide extradition of Hasina, talks on to change course

Request can't be decoupled from current diplomatic exchanges: Top Govt official

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, August 15

AS THE Tarique Rahman government reiterates its request for the extradition of Bangladesh's ousted Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, top government officials in India said such requests have to come before the Indian judiciary and be decided

by it, but added that intense discussions were on with Dhaka to move away from such a maximalist position.

"The decision to extradite will be finally taken by our courts, it will not be a political or diplomatic decision. And what has to be established during the court process is whether

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

A tightrope walk

The extradition question will not arise if Sheikh Hasina decides to return to Bangladesh in December as she has said. Even otherwise, while the Indian judiciary will take a call on her extradition, Delhi will be keen to resolve the issue diplomatically, and impress upon Dhaka not to take this maximalist position.

some closure from the scars they have borne during this period. "My mother used to say that all those politicians from J&K and Delhi, who visited my father for blessings and guidance, stopped coming to see us. The then governments at the Centre and in J&K made numerous promises of land, compensation and a CBI inquiry into the killings but nothing ever came of them," Sarwanand's son Rajinder, a retired government employee, says.

A Gandhian who was part of the Indian freedom movement, Koul was among the handful of Kashmiri Pandits whose families were left behind in the

THE WORLD



PAGE 10

47 KILLED AS QUAKE OF 7.7 MAGNITUDE ROCKS INDONESIA

ACCEPT HIGH OIL PRICES, TRUMP TELLS U.S. AS IRAN DEFIANT ON STRAIT

For small taxpayers, Govt opens window to declare foreign income, assets

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, August 15

THE GOVERNMENT has introduced a scheme for taxpayers to voluntarily disclose foreign income up to Rs 1 crore and assets located abroad up to Rs 5 crore before December 31.

Called the Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers — Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS), finance ministry officials said, it is for taxpayers who forgot to mention their foreign assets in their Income Tax Returns. It allows them to avoid large penalties under the Black Money Act due to a small non-compliance.

The FAST-DS rules notified by the government will be effective

August 16, and taxpayers can disclose their foreign bank accounts, immovable property, jewellery, artistic work, shares, securities or any other asset or income on payment of a specified tax or fee, until December 31.

The scheme applies to two broad categories: i) undisclosed foreign income or asset located outside India up to Rs 1 crore; ii) asset up to Rs 5 crore located outside India, which was already offered to tax or was acquired when the assessee was a non-resident, but not declared in the relevant schedule of the income tax return.

Under the first category, taxpayers have to pay 30% of fair

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● SARWANAND KOUL 'PREMI', SON VIRENDER WERE ABDUCTED AND KILLED IN 1990; J&K'S STATE INVESTIGATION AGENCY HAS REOPENED THE CASE

Nearly 4 decades after his killing, Kashmiri Pandit writer's family awaits justice

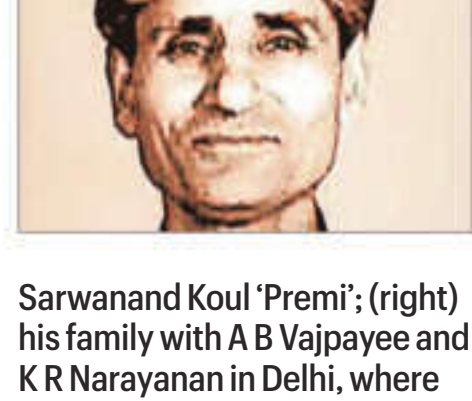
Aun Sharma
Jammu, August 15

WHEN KASHMIRI Pandit poet, journalist, and Independence activist Sarwanand Koul "Premi" was abducted and killed on the night of April 30, 1990, along with his 27-year-old son Virender Koul, his family did the only thing they could think of: move out of their beloved home in Koker-nag, Anantnag. It was a sombre procession — his wife, eldest son and his wife, a daughter, his widowed daughter-in-law, and three grandchildren — all set out to live in a single room at the

Jammu MLA Hostel under a watchful police escort.

"You can well imagine our plight," says Premi's now 70-year-old son Rajinder. "Eight people used to a palatial multi-storeyed house, sharing a single room with other relatives from Kashmir, all as frightened as pigeons."

Since then, Sarwanand's older son Rajinder has been pursuing a long legal battle connected with the killings. This week, that push appeared to have borne some fruit: the State Investigation Agency (SIA) conducted searches at nine locations across



Sarwanand Koul 'Premi'; (right) his family with A B Vajpayee and K R Narayanan in Delhi, where they moved after his killing

J&K, marking the launch of a fresh investigation into the case.

The raids were part of a wider move by the SIA to officially revive high-profile cold



cases involving the targeted killings of Kashmiri Pandits during the peak of the militancy. The two other high-profile cases are the 1989 assassination of retired

judge Neelkanth Ganjoo and the 1990 killing of a 27-year-old nurse, Sarla Bhat.

For families like the Kouls, this marks the beginning of

Valley during the militancy.

The family had been well off, owning two houses in Anantnag. Koul had three sons and four daughters.

"We had an old multi-storeyed home in Anantnag and a bungalow," Rajinder says. "Within five days of the murder, we collected the mortal remains and moved to Jammu."

Even before the killing, the family had already been discussing leaving. But Koul wouldn't hear of it.

"He thought it would be a betrayal to his people at a time of crisis," Rajinder says.

That changed on the night of April 29, when armed militants

forced their way into the family home and dragged Koul and his son Virender out of bed and into the streets, allegedly also looting the family's valuables. Two days later, their bodies were found hanging from a tree in a forest some 20 km away, allegedly bearing broken bones and marks of torture.

The family knew then that it was time to leave. Without even finishing their father's final rites, the family — including Virender's widow and toddler daughter — left Anantnag, securing a room at the MLA Hostel in Jammu with the help of then J&K Governor Jagmohan,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Smoke at Barmer refinery: Cong blames ‘haste’ to inaugurate; HPCL says no fire

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, August 15

FOR THE second time in four months, smoke was seen emanating from the Rs 80,000 crore-refinery in Barmer’s Pachpadra on Friday evening, with the Rajasthan Congress alleging that such incidents were taking place due to a “hurried inauguration” of the project by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL) officials, however, said that there was no fire but an oil spillage issue.

An HPCL spokesperson said that around 6.45 pm on August 14, “Hydrocarbon oil spillage was observed in the Crude Distillation Unit (CDU) at HRRL Refinery. As an immediate precautionary measure, the emergency response system was activated and fire-water sprays were deployed from all directions as per the safety norms. The situation was promptly brought under control by the Refinery team.

“There was no fire, no injuries to personnel and no damage to the property. The situation is fully under control, and all necessary safety measures are in place,” the spokesperson said, adding that “The information spread in the media is factually inaccurate.”

Congress MLA from

Barmer’s Baytu, Harish Choudhary, claimed that the fire was due to haste in refinery’s inauguration. “The race to take credit in the country has previously harmed the nation’s enterprises, and now again, an incident of fire has occurred in the nation’s important project, the HRRL Refinery. Due to the haste of Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji’s visit, technical flaws in this enterprise are creating new problems every day, the consequences of which the country is facing in the form of economic losses,” he said.

“The refinery management needs to take a decision in this regard soon for quality checks,” Choudhary said.

The HPCL spokesperson said, “All other Refinery process units are operational with normal production of LPG, Diesel, Petrol and Napththa. 1,200 Metric Tonnes of LPG was produced and dispatched to market today (August 14) and the production and dispatches are on.”

Earlier, on April 20, a fire broke out in the CDU section of the refinery complex, with officials saying that prima facie, it appeared that leakage of hydrocarbons through one of the valves/flanges in the heat exchanger circuit had caused it.

Subsequently, PM Modi’s scheduled April 21 inauguration was postponed. It eventually took place on July 4.

Taxpayers

market value of assets or 30% of undisclosed income as tax and 30% as additional income tax in place of penalty to get immunity from prosecution. For the second category, immunity from both penalty and prosecution is available with the fee payment of Rs 1 lakh.

Besides immunity on valid declaration and payment, the I-T department said the income or amount of investment in the asset declared under this scheme will not be included in the total income of the taxpayer under the Income-tax Act or the Black Money Act.

The scheme will not apply if any income or asset represents proceeds of crime for which proceedings under the Prevention of Money-laundering Act, 2002 are on or are pending; and when any income or asset relating to an assessment year for which assessment proceedings have already been completed under the Black Money Act, 2015.

Experts said the voluntary disclosure window is akin to a nudge to the taxpayer to disclose their foreign assets correctly, given that the tax department already has a lot of information on foreign assets through information exchange mechanisms with other countries. “Anyone with unreported RSUs (restricted stock units) or ESOPs (Employee Stock Option Plan) from an MNC employer should look at this seriously. CRS data is already with the department,” said Chirag Chauhan, founder of CA Chauhan & Co, a chartered accountancy firm in Mumbai.

The details about foreign assets and income are shared between the countries in line with international reporting frameworks such as the Common Reporting Standard and the Foreign Account Tax Compliance Act aimed to tackle tax evasion by increasing transparency and cooperation among tax authorities globally.

BCI chief

acknowledgment that the feelings and concerns of our students matter.”

“I therefore sincerely hope that the present issue will now be considered with fairness and a spirit of reconciliation. The issue should not be allowed to acquire a political or extraneous colour through outside influence,” he said in the letter.

Earlier in the day, NALSAR’s Student Bar Council, its elected student body, condemned Mishra’s now-withdrawn directive and demanded an apology for “objectionable comments” against students and faculty.

In a statement, it said the provisions of the Advocates Act

relied upon by the BCI relate to legal education and professional standards and do not empower the Council to prevent otherwise qualified graduates from enrolling as advocates. It added that peaceful dissent and protest are constitutionally protected forms of expression.

The graduating students of NLSIU (National Law School of India University) Bengaluru also issued a similar statement, describing the BCI’s actions as ultra vires (beyond the powers). It said the BCI chairman lacked the authority to unilaterally issue such directions on behalf of the Council, and termed the move to identify students and faculty members involved in the campaign as a “witch-hunt”.

Extradition

the crimes that are alleged to have been committed are also categorised as crimes under the Indian law,” a top official told *The Indian Express*.

Another official said Sheikh Hasina had herself said she planned to return to her country in December this year. Asked when she planned to return during a press conference on August 5, she referred to the 1971 Bangladesh liberation war, and said, “December is our victory month, so I want to go back in the month of December.” Hasina faces a death sentence in Bangladesh and her party, the Awami League, has been banned.

The extradition request cannot be decoupled from the current diplomatic exchanges between Delhi and Dhaka, this official said.

Responding to a question on Prime Minister Rahman’s request for extradition at a media briefing, a spokesperson of the Ministry of External Affairs

(MEA), had earlier said, “We are examining the matter in accordance with our established procedures, and whenever I have any update to share, I will inform you...”

MEA officials told *The Indian Express* that Bangladesh’s extradition request to India is annexed with all the required legal documents as per provisions of the 2013 extradition pact between the two countries.

For two years now, since the August 2024 mass uprising in Dhaka, Sheikh Hasina has been given refuge and protection in an undisclosed location in New Delhi. On August 5, she held a virtual press conference where she announced she was “determined to return home.”

Members and former Members of Parliament of the ousted Awami League party say that while in her unofficial asylum, Sheikh Hasina has been continuously in touch with her party cadre in Bangladesh. The 78-year old leader, they say, is proposing to return to Dhaka towards the end of the year.

Meanwhile, the diplomatic

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PM on youth power

address, he echoed his ideological refrain about “urban Naxals” and “*Andolanjeevis*.” He said that while Maoists, who had killed more than 3,000 security personnel and stalled development, had been effectively countered, there were “*dimagi* Naxals” (those with a Maoist mindset), who were looking for ways to unleash violence and anarchy and push society onto the wrong path.

In his 13th address from the ramps of the Red Fort, Modi went beyond the mantra of self-reliance and outlined seven vital areas — *shakti ki sapta dhara* — for reform. The goal: to ensure that India can build and scale up domestic capacity to transform itself into an exporting nation and compete globally on an equal or better footing with quality made-in-India products.

He peppered his 75-minute speech with references comparing the track record of his government with that of the previous Congress period saying speed in governance has been a defining feature of his 12-year tenure.

While this theme was a throwback to his earlier addresses, what stood out was how the PM made the youth the front and centre of his address. There were nearly 50 references to “*yuva shakti*” (youth power), “*naufawan*” (youth) and “*yuva*” (youth). “I want to tell the young people of the country: come forward with your dreams; we will ensure that there is no shortage of resources,” he said.

He said the government has “decided to build an extensive network to provide free online coaching for young people preparing for various examinations” so that poor and middle-class families are spared of the economic burden of tutorials. He said the Government has also decided to train 1 crore young people in AI skills in the next one year so that they have the capability to lead in the world in that technology.

Modi also announced the

launch of a talent hunt in villages, cities and schools across the country to spot budding sporting talent in the 5-16 age group to prepare them for the 2036 Olympics which India is bidding to host.

With job creation emerging as a major concern for the youth, Modi sought to broaden the definition of employment — projecting startups, AI, aviation, sports, drones, electric vehicles and the bio-economy, among other things, as emerging employment avenues.

“When I speak of a ‘Viksit Bharat’, when I speak of taking the country forward at a rapid pace, who is the greatest beneficiary of all these efforts? Who is the greatest force driving these efforts? If there is one, it is the youth of my country, the youth power of the country. The youth have a very important role to play in the journey towards a ‘Viksit Bharat’. Not only that, the greatest beneficiary of a ‘Viksit Bharat’ will also be the youth of my country. Therefore, we must take forward the goal of a ‘Viksit Bharat’ by connecting it with the aspirations and participation of our youth. We must move forward with our youth as our highest priority,” he said.

Modi said India could withstand global challenges and headwinds, including the “weaponization” of resources by many countries, because of his government’s thrust on self-reliance. This wasn’t defined as economic isolation. In fact, he coupled it with an aggressive export agenda. Referring to free trade agreements being negotiated or signed with around 40 countries, he urged MSMEs to use this opening to enter global markets.

He framed self-reliance as building capacities along “*sapta dhara*” — seven streams through which India can build global capabilities and become a developed country: manufacturing, agro-food production and food processing, technology and innovation, logistics and

faster connectivity, defence and security, green and blue economy; and soft power.

He called for complete manufacturing value chains, global-scale food exports, Made-in-India 6G, stronger defence exports, green hydrogen and renewable energy, and greater use of India’s cultural and creative strengths. He said India has already begun production at three semiconductor plants, and five to eight more plants are expected to come up in the coming years.

“There was a time when I used to talk about self-reliance, someone sitting in air-conditioned chambers used to tell us what will happen to globalization. But the world is seeing that in the last decade it seems the world has stopped talking about globalization... Every nation has turned its focus to addressing its own specific challenges; however, regrettably, during this period of crisis, some have engaged in the game of weaponizing resources to assert their dominance. The world is currently intent on weaponizing whatever assets it possesses. Resources such as petrol, diesel, fertilizers, medicines, and technology chips are being weaponized; indeed, even territory itself is being weaponized,” he said.

“We have to reach the world, every product of India should reach the world market. Whether it is our textile, machinery, medicines... we should not leave any opportunity, but we have to match and better the global parameters. We need to offer products that are superior in quality and more affordable than what is currently available worldwide,” he said.

“We have embarked on the ‘Reform Express’ and we are going to move towards next level reform in the coming days as well and hence the government, society, industry, producers, farmers, everyone will have to reform their traditional systems, reform their thinking, reform their goals,” he said.

Flagging free trade agreements, the PM said these unlocked countless opportunities that must be seized by all. “Our

farmers now have access to global markets. Because of FTAs, we are getting access to a very large market, and we must reach those markets. We must tap into that opportunity. We have to move from the farm to the export market,” Modi said.

“Today, the world is one of AI, quantum, space, robotics and data centres. New areas have opened up,” he said, underlining that India must respond to the challenges posed by emerging technologies by becoming a global innovation hub rather than merely a market.

He also put energy security, semiconductor manufacturing and advanced technology at the centre of India’s next phase of growth, while calling for faster reforms and challenging Indian companies to become global leaders as the country seeks to become a developed economy by 2047.

The PM touched upon two politically charged themes: women’s representation and the continuing ideological battle against the Maoist movement. Modi made a direct appeal to all political parties to support the implementation of the 33% quota for women in the Lok Sabha and state Assemblies. “You also take credit, but give our women their rights,” he said in a message directed at the Opposition while pressing for an early roll-out of the Natl Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam passed by Parliament in 2023.

This was a pointed political intervention because implementation of this constitutional amendment legislation is tied to the delimitation exercise and the subsequent allocation of seats.

The security message was also layered. Modi warned against complacency after the decline of the Maoist violence, saying that while India had defeated Maoists with guns, “*dimagi* Naxals” continued to sit in institutions and influence policy. At the same time, national security was placed within the broader Atmanirbharta framework: India, he said, must develop next-generation defence technologies and move towards becoming a global supplier.

tellectual dissent,” Tharoor said.

Senior Congress leader Sachin Pilot said the PM’s remarks showed that he and the BJP were “rattled” by the unrest among disenfranchised youth and students. “Earlier he (Modi) used the term urban Naxals when Rahul Gandhi and the Congress demanded a caste census. They called the farmers Khalistani and anti-nationals. Anyone who opposes the government or its politics are dubbed anti-nationals. The people of India are now asking right and tough questions on governance and deliverables. The Prime Minister is rattled,” Pilot said.

Attacking Modi, Congress communication head Jairam Ramesh stated: “First he called his opponents ‘urban Naxals’. Now he calls them ‘dimagi Naxals’. It is a sure sign of his desperation. It is a separate matter that he ends up doing whatever these so-called ‘urban Naxals’ or now ‘dimagi Naxals’ are demanding or advocating...”

Other Opposition leaders, too, slammed the PM. While CPI(M) general secretary M A Baby called Modi’s “*dimagi* Naxal” term a bid to target the Opposition, his CPI counterpart D Raja felt it was an attempt to suppress dissent.

“To the baseless categories repeatedly conjured up by the Right Wing: ‘anti-national’, ‘tukde tukde gang’ and others, Modi has now added another

absurd label: ‘*dimagi* Naxal’. This is nothing but an attempt to stigmatise dissent and intimidate those who question the government,” Raja said.

Raja urged the PM to address the concerns raised by students and youth regarding education and jobs. “India’s youth and students are on the streets demanding educational and employment reforms. Did you answer their questions? Why have nearly a lakh government schools been closed? Why has public education been allowed to deteriorate so badly? Why are millions of young people struggling for secure employment?” he asked.

TMC leader and ex-MP Saket Gokhale accused the PM of using the Independence Day platform to target his critics. “Shame that Modi used the occasion of Independence Day to take cheap shots calling his opponents ‘*dimagi* (mental) Naxals’. Instead of apologising to the youth for using violence and pellet guns on them, Modi is peddling his usual nonsense. Dump the ego, Mr PM. It’s not helping,” he said.

The day also saw a row over the Leaders of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha, Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge, not attending the official Independence Day event at the Red Fort. The two top Congress leaders had skipped the event last year as well.

Kashmiri writer

a friend of Koul’s. There, their first guest was BJP leader Chaman Lal Gupta. “He brought us two bedsheets, 3-4 steel plates and a two-litre bottle of mustard oil,” Rajinder says. “We thanked him but asked him to give those items to someone in need.”

From there, the family moved to Delhi, where Koul’s youngest son Ravinder worked in the Kashmir section of All India Radio as an officer selected through the UPSC.

In Delhi, a stream of leaders visited — Atal Bihari Vajpayee, who would go on to become prime minister, and other BJP leaders such as Kedar Nath Sahni, Yashwant Singh, and Madan Lal Khurana. But what the family found most hurtful was that Kashmiri leader Mufti Mohammad Sayeed — their father’s student at a school in Anantnag’s Bijbehara, who was then the Union Home Minister — was not among them.

“He didn’t come even

Delhi NGO

for comment.

The case traces back to July 23, when four poachers were arrested on the Gwalior-Agra highway with 10 leopard skins. At the time, NGO Wildlife SOS credited months of surveillance by its own Forest Watch anti-poaching unit for the bust. But because the pelts had originated in Madhya Pradesh, the STTF opened a parallel probe and that investigation is what has now turned the narrative on its head.

Field investigations in the Shivpur and Morena forests turned up multiple sites where leopard remains were buried; these have been sent to the Wildlife Institute of India in Dehradun for DNA matching against the skins seized on July 23. Investigators also recovered three leg-hold traps, and it was this trail that led them to Bhagwan Singh and, through him, to Wasim. The MP STTF picked up Bhagwan Singh on August 11 and Wasim on August 13.

“Our teams also found three leg-hold traps and made some arrests which led them to the prime accused Bhagwan Singh, a wildlife trader with a long history, who turned out to be on the payroll of this NGO for at least five years. This led to the arrest of Wasim, another Wildlife SOS employee,” a senior Madhya Pradesh forest official said.

According to sources familiar with the investigation, Singh and his accomplices scouted forest areas around Shivpur and Morena in a Wildlife SOS vehicle — now in STTF custody — and distributed leg-hold traps sourced from Haryana to handpicked local hunters. It was Singh, sources said, who arranged for four poachers to carry the 10 leopard skins to a decoy buyer near a dhaba on the Gwalior-Agra highway, where UP police made the arrests.

“This network started poaching leopards in the Shivpuri area last year. If it was indeed an undercover operation to nab poachers, why did they continue until 10 leopards had been killed? They have to explain why they created such a demand for skins and distributed leg-hold traps to be deployed in a sensitive landscape where we also have cheetahs,” a Forest department source said. Bhopal sources added that the department has not ruled out tigers also being caught in the same trapping network, despite the Shivpuri landscape’s only sporadic tiger presence.

A retired forest official suggested the alleged scheme fits a familiar trafficking playbook. “This could well follow the classical model where traffickers trade the high-value material to make profit while getting their rivals arrested with some low-value goods to earn brownie points — in this case, attract big donors and grants.” The same official pointed to Wildlife SOS’s aggressive fundraising for rescued bear cubs at Bhopal’s Van Vihar zoo, under an MoU with the state that is due to expire next month.

Singh’s arrest is also reviving scrutiny of an earlier case. A former Delhi Police officer who was dismissed from the force, Singh, with Wasim, was reportedly present in Tamil Nadu’s Sathyamangalam forest area in 2023, when a tiger skin, a leopard skin, and a tiger skeleton were seized, according to Tamil Nadu forest department sources. Wildlife SOS had claimed credit then, too, for both the seizure and the poachers’ subsequent conviction.

Satyanarayan co-founded Wildlife SOS with Geeta Seshamani in 1995. The organisation began with a bear rescue centre in Agra, later added an elephant facility in Mathura, and has since expanded across India through MoUs with states and sub-centres.

Rahman

which has re-emerged six months into Rahman’s prime ministership.

While trouble has been brewing for some time now, the latest provocation was Hasina’s statement on August 5, marking two years of the collapse of her government in the face of violent protests that forced her to flee and take refuge in India. In her first press conference since then, conducted online where she joined on audio mode from an undisclosed location in India, she announced her plans to return to Bangladesh, possibly in December, and said she may be killed on her return. She faces death sentence in Bangladesh courts.

Earlier, following India’s gesture of sending External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar to attend the funeral of his mother and former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia last December, Rahman is learnt to have told Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) leaders to refrain from targeting India during the election campaign.

After Rahman emerged as the winner of the Bangladesh elections in February, PM Narendra Modi was among the first to call and congratulate him, setting the tone for a positive bilateral relationship.

However, in the run-up to the West Bengal Assembly elections in April, the rhetoric on the Indian side regarding illegal immigrants from Bangladesh was not subtle. And after the BJP’s win, the detention and push-back of immigrants into Bangladesh’s territory did not go down well, according to sources.

In fact, Delhi and Dhaka were discussing a possible visit by Rahman in early June, but the reports of illegal Bangladeshi immigrants being detained and pushed back soured the atmosphere. Rahman went to China for his first bilateral visit, which was seen as a signal to Delhi.

In July, the two sides again tried to pick up the threads and dates for a bilateral visit between August 1 and August 10 were being explored. But that didn’t materialise, with the Monsoon Session of Parliament being cited as one of the reasons.

Parallely, the Indian side also invited Rahman to attend the BRICS leaders’ summit in September, as a guest and chair of the BIMSTEC grouping.

Then, the Indian side proposed August 21 as a possible date for Rahman’s visit.

However, soon after the date was proposed, Dhaka came to know that Hasina would address a press conference at the Foreign Correspondents’ Club of South Asia in New Delhi. While her re-

corded message was played at a press conference by Awami League leaders in exile in January, this was the first time that she was answering questions live, along with her son Saeed Wazed Joy, since fleeing Bangladesh.

Dhaka then put the discussions of Rahman’s visit to Delhi on hold, and raised this issue with the Indian government.

Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman, who was earlier the National Security Advisor, called up NSA Ajit Doval and lodged a protest. Doval is learnt to have conveyed that the interaction was only for foreign media based in Delhi. Bangladesh PM’s foreign affairs advisor Humayun Kabir also met Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi and raised the issue.

However, the interaction on August 5 was attended by foreign and Indian journalists, prompting a sharp reaction from Dhaka. Delhi maintained that it had “no role” in organising the interaction and it “did not endorse” Hasina’s statements. But the damage was done.

The fact that Hasina was given a platform on August 5 — the day which saw a memorial being opened in Dhaka for the students and protesters killed during the July-August 2024 protests — did not go down well with Bangladesh.

Later, at their first face-to-face meeting, Rahman conveyed to Trivedi that Hasina’s extradition was a core issue for his government. Dhaka is learnt to have made clear that unless Delhi gives cogent response on the next steps to be taken for her extradition, it would be difficult for Rahman to visit India.

“We are working to ascertain the intent of the Indian government on the Hasina issue,” said a Bangladeshi official. “Is India open to seeing her return to Dhaka and face due process?”

Almost simultaneously, in a carefully choreographed move, India’s R&AW chief Parag Jain visited Bangladesh and met the top intelligence and security officials there, who are learnt to have underlined that Delhi needs to be sensitive about Dhaka’s concerns over Hasina.

Earlier this week, Trivedi briefed Modi on the situation.

According to sources, though not linking the two issues directly, Indian officials were told that if they want Bangladesh to not allow anti-India activities and statements from Bangladeshi soil, they should reciprocate as well.

Delhi’s view is that Hasina is a political fugitive, and this cannot be conflated with extremists in Bangladesh who may be a security threat to India’s interests. “If she goes back on her own accord,” said an official, “then there is little we can do except appeal for due process and justice.”

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Third Floor	318	29.543	₹ 8,17,260	₹ 24,51,780	₹ 24,51,780	₹ 24,51,780	₹ 81,72,600

GST* and other charges as Applicable

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Floor	Area in (Sq. Ft.)	Area in (Sq. Mtr.)	10% Booking Amount	30% Within 45 Days	30% on Super Structure	30% On Offer of Possesion	Total Cost
Third Floor	318	29.543	₹ 8,74,500	₹ 26,23,500	₹ 26,23,500	₹ 26,23,500	87,45,000

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80TH INDEPENDENCE DAY CELEBRATIONS IN THE CAPITAL

Delhi prepared to be role model for other states: CM

Don't limit your strength to screens, social media: CM's message to youth

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 15

DELHI'S DEVELOPMENT model can become a benchmark for other cities and the Capital is fully-prepared to lead the way, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday as she delivered her second Independence Day address at the Chhatrasal Stadium.

"Delhi is the National Capital... the decisions taken here give direction to the entire country. The development model created here can become a benchmark for other cities. I say with full confidence that Delhi will take the first step towards the threshold of a developed India... because Delhi is active, Delhi is attentive, and Delhi is attractive. Delhi is fully-prepared to become a role model for other states," she said. Ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh and Manjinder Singh Sirsa, among others, were in attendance at the event.

Gupta also sent out a message to the youth in the Capital. "...My young friends, do not limit your strength only to digital screens and social media. Turn your ideas into startups, turn your creativity into innovation, turn your questions into research, and turn your sensitivity into service... use your potential in nation-building," she said.

"However, there is one thing you must certainly keep in mind. You must remain cautious against the group known as Urban Naxals, because of whom India is forced to fight a '2.5-front' war. Two fronts are outside the country and half within the country, which always keeps insulting the country and its armed forces," she said.

Gupta added, "In order to achieve the Prime Minister's goal of a developed India, Delhi should lead the rest of the country... The youth of the city will take up this special responsibility... *ye desh ki Amrit Peedi hai* (this is the immortal generation of the nation)."

She also said that Delhi's youth have the capability to provide job, not just seek employment. "Today's youth is very different — they question, know technology, are connected to the world. On issues such as mental health, climate change, gender equality, innovation and social justice, they are both sensitive and aware," Gupta said.



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during the ceremony. AMIT MEHRA

Highlighting the cooperation between the Centre and the Delhi government, Gupta said the Capital would play an important role in the PM's Viksit Bharat vision. "I thank the Central government, which has sanctioned us Rs 2,600 crore, which will help us undertake 61 new projects. And this funding will work as a strong cooperation between the Centre and the Delhi government. It is also a reflection of our shared commitment to Delhi's development."

Gupta said the people of Delhi had voted for a change and that her administration's focus was on taking development to the ground.

The CM also highlighted the formation of a Department of Capital Development by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, calling it a "game changer" and a "growth engine" that would take Delhi forward.

The CM also highlighted her government's achievements over the last one year. On the health front, Gupta said nine lakh beneficiaries had been registered under the Ayushman Bharat scheme in Delhi, while three lakh senior citizens above 70 had been covered under the Vaivandana Yojana. "Five new blocks of hospitals have been completed, and 38 government hospitals have been connected through the Hospital Information Management System. The shortage of doctors has been addressed, and the shortage of medical staff has also been addressed," she said.

The Chief Minister also highlighted the Anmol Yojana, under which 56 tests will be conducted by taking a drop of blood from every newborn child in Delhi. "These tests are not only for children born in government hospitals; they are for every child born in Delhi, so that Delhi becomes healthy and moves forward in good health," Gupta said.

The CM said environment and pollution are among the government's key priorities. "For the first time... we have decided to spend 21% of the Budget share, that is, Rs 22,000 crore, as the Green Budget." On women's welfare, she said around 7.25 lakh women had registered under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, under which women from economically weaker sections would receive monthly aid of Rs 2,500.



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and others release Tricolour balloons during the 80th Independence Day celebrations at Chhatrasal Stadium, in New Delhi on Saturday. AMIT MEHRA

Need accountability, independence from corruption: Youth speak up

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, August 15

"WE GOT Independence from the British in 1947. Now, we have to get independence from corruption, hunger and under-development."

For Anshuman (22), an NCC cadet and aspiring civil servant, this was what freedom meant.

And he was not alone. For Delhi's Gen Z, Independence Day was as much about what comes next as what happened in 1947.

Sitting inside the Red Fort on Saturday, Anshuman said his generation had not grown up experiencing the struggle for Independence.

"Our generation did not grow up to see India's enslavement in the hands of the British. There is nothing that connects the younger generation to the Independence struggle," he said.

Its battles, he felt, were different.

Speaking about CJP's Jantar Mantar protest that led to Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as the union Education Minister over NEET-UG paper leak, Anshuman voiced scepticism about the wave of hyperpolitics.

"The protests happened, a minister resigned — it was seen as a big achievement, but people quickly moved on. The same happened in Nepal, in Bangladesh and other countries. But authoritarianism and corruption returned to these countries over time. There should be a push for institutional reform, an overhaul of the system," he said.

Anshuman was part of the crowd which by sunrise had begun moving towards the Red Fort. Barricades had cut off roads to traffic since 4am. From Kashmiri Gate to Delhi Gate, and Nishad Raj Marg to



Participants take part in celebrations at Chhatrasal Stadium on Saturday. AMIT MEHRA

Chandni Chowk, people walked towards the checkpoints.

Outside the gates of Red Fort Metro station, queues poured out. Only those with a valid pass, booked through the Ministry of Defence's Aamantran portal, were allowed through.

Naveen (22), a Ramjas College student, had arrived with three friends for their first Independence Day ceremony. They had registered online but had not realised a separate pass was needed. They were stopped near the Hanuman Mandir.

"Going to see the celebration in person must feel really good — not like watching it on video," he said.

Past the checkpoints, there were multiple layers of security: frisking, ID checks, and scrutiny of passes. Only phones and wallets were allowed in, even coins had to be left behind. Outside the police booths lay small heaps of confiscated pens, Bluetooth earphones, caps and water bottles.

Inside Red Fort, the seating enclosures carried names drawn from India's lakes: Bhimtal, Chilika, Pangong Tso, Pushkar — echoing the river-themed enclosures at this year's Republic Day parade on Kartavya Path.

Ratna Kumari (21), a final-year BA student from Haryana whose brother serves in the Air Force, sought accountability.

"Politicians only tell us about their successes in their speeches," she said. "They come asking for votes with their achievement stories. It's high time they also spoke of what they haven't achieved yet, what's still pending. That's how accountability gets fixed."

But not every young voice was looking at politics.

A little further off, in the Har-rike enclosure, 49 school-children from Sarvodaya Bal Vidyalaya 01, Jama Masjid, sat in white uniforms. Nine-year-old, Asad, a Class 3 student, ducked behind a friend to escape the sun. "Bhagat Singh won us our freedom. I will one day grow up to become like him," he said.

For Neha (26), freedom means a better life for her two-year-old daughter. "This 80th Independence Day means a better life and future for my daughter," Neha said.

"I could only study until Class 12 due to family obligations. But our future generations should get the best education so they can live the best life."

For senior citizens like Basa-

varaj (82), a farmer from Gulbarga in Karnataka, the definition of freedom was simpler — "Good rain and a good harvest".

"I was two years old when the country gained Independence. I don't remember much. But even after 80 years, seeing these many people turn up (at the Red Fort) — it fills my heart," he said.

Prafull Mohanty (62), a retired government servant from Dhubri in Assam, watched his son, an Army officer, walk ahead through the crowd.

"Independence for me means good governance. My pension comes on time. People getting jobs in Assam now are getting them on merit. Better infrastructure is being built," he said.

But the floods in Sivasagar, which caused extensive destruction, were a reminder of how much remained to be done, he added.

By the time the ceremony ended, the heat had settled over Old Delhi.

The crowds began to thin and outside the barricades, people waited for the roads to open. That was when the kites appeared — one, then another, with dozens of colours flying above rooftops.



LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu during the celebrations. EXPRESS

LG: Energy of youth real strength of modern Delhi

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 15

LIEUTENANT GOVERNOR Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Saturday hoisted the Tricolour at Lok Niwas on the occasion of India's 80th Independence Day in the presence of freedom fighters and their families; RWA representatives; youth icons; students, and residents of Delhi. Emphasising upon the need for seamless coordination between the Union Government, the Delhi government, municipal bodies, neighbouring states, and citizens, he said that complex challenges can be converted into enduring opportunities with better collaboration.

The cleaning of the Yamuna river, tackling air pollution, ensuring housing for all, affordable healthcare, safety and security, particularly of women and children, traffic management, and the rejuvenation of Delhi's heritage were among the top priorities for the Capital listed by the LG in his Independence Day address.

Addressing the city's youth, Sandhu said they remain the ultimate drivers of Delhi's future. "Their energy, creative ideas, and civic sense are the real strength of a modern Delhi," he said. Further, he called upon citizens to keep

their neighbourhoods clean, protect public spaces, and follow their fundamental duties, noting that while the government can build beautiful public spaces, only citizens can sustain them.

LG Sandhu also referred to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Independence Day speech from the ramparts of the Red Fort and the PM's vision of 'Shakti Ki Saptdhara' — seven key streams of strength, spanning manufacturing, agriculture and food processing, technology and innovation, Gati Shakti, Raksha Shakti, the green and blue economy, and India's soft power. The seven streams, he said, would together power the country's growth story in the years ahead.

All these streams, the LG underlined, were extremely relevant to Delhi as he appealed to the residents of the Capital to lead the nation in its goal of achieving Viksit Bharat by 2047.

He said that Delhi's approach to public governance must be rooted in the Prime Minister's resolve of 'Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, aur Sabka Prayas'. "The goal is to build a Viksit Dilli (developed Delhi) — one that becomes a national model of excellence, safety, and civic pride," he added.

DANCERS RECALL FINDING A BUSINESS OPPORTUNITY IN THEIR PASSION

Dancepreneurs of Delhi-NCR: From an artist to business owner, one beat at a time

Swati Bhasin
New Delhi, August 15

SERENDIPITY OR a well-choreographed career move?

At 24, Kamna Arora was doing well in her career after finishing her graduation from the University of Nottingham in the UK. Yet one evening, the Delhi resident packed her bags for Mumbai and enrolled in choreographer Shiamak Davar's one-year professional programme. Until then, dance was only a hobby for her.

"I realised dance was my calling," says Kamna, now 36.

Her parents supported her decision and she ended up training as a professional for three years. But turning dance into a career — and eventually a business — required more than their approval.

Kamna's dream was to create a space to inspire others to dance.

In 2017, she co-founded South Delhi-based Yellow

Stripes Dance Company (YSDC) with Utsav Malhotra, a fellow dancer she had met at Shiamak Davar's company.

"Utsav had trained much longer at Shiamak, then with the Royal Academy of Dance in Sri Lanka and the Urban Dance Camp in Germany... He had got exposure in genres such as ballet, and hip hop," she says. "I was more of an entrepreneur; Utsav lent his artistic soul."

The early challenge was setting up a dance studio. "There were only big names like Shiamak and Ashley Lobo then," Kamna says.

She identified a market gap that gave the duo a first-mover advantage, especially in Delhi-NCR — wedding choreography.

Nearly a decade later, YSDC has a 20-member team, a studio in Saket and a wedding choreography business with clients in India and abroad. Last month, Kamna and Utsav — who got married in 2022 — added a cafe, Nukohi, to the



(From left) Kamna Arora and Utsav Malhotra; Mansi Garg and Nidhi Bhatia. EXPRESS

studio premises.

As a team, the couple has worked as choreographers in Radhika Merchant-Anant Ambani and Sidharth Malhotra-Kiara Advani weddings.

Kamna says constant scaling, monthly plans and innovation help cover costs like studio and warehouse rentals. "The wedding business is more profitable, but we hold in-house



classes too."

The corporate convert

Nidhi Bhatia (36) has had a hectic last few weeks. Her studio, Creative Detox, in Greater Kailash 1, celebrated its first anniversary in June, and the team and students are now preparing for its first stage show, CD Productions, on September 12.

Bhatia had trained young



but "dance found its way back to her" when her husband took her to a workshop three years ago. She quit her corporate job in product management and marketing and used her savings to set up Creative Detox, which hosts dance classes alongside art and crafts workshops.

"My 10-year-long corporate stint gave me invaluable experience in strategy and building

products," she says.

Her team says her laptop is her "second brain". "I have Excel sheets, documents, and checklists for practically everything. AI helps me think faster, but Excel sheets help me stay organised," she adds.

Catch them young

Mansi Garg (22) from Gurgaon had a humbler start as a solopreneur. Fresh out of college, she started teaching last year at a dance institute to fund a dream that she had nurtured since she was a teenager — opening a studio.

She founded Gurgaon-based Soul Studio last May. "It was because of my mother's love for dance that I got enrolled in Kathak classes at the age of four." But convincing other members of her family that dance can actually be a profession was not easy.

"My father and brother are chartered accountants... it was, at some level, difficult to convince the family that this could be my professional calling," she adds.

She still continues to teach at the institute.

Not far away is Qala House of Creators, set up two years ago. Co-founder Ishita Bhatnagar (25) began dancing when she was three. "I realised I wanted to build my life around dance. Dance gave me a purpose, and entrepreneurship gave me the opportunity to create a home for that purpose."

A cafe, Qalavio, was added to the studio two months ago.

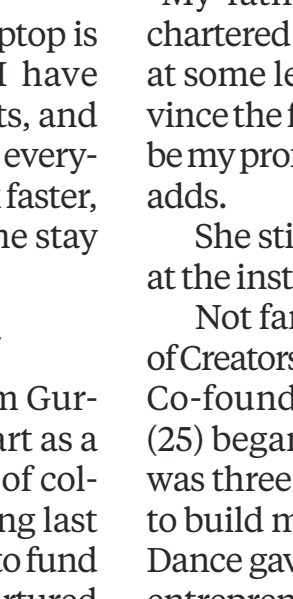
Sustaining the vision

For these founders, social media has become almost indispensable for attracting students and keeping com-

munities engaged. Canva and AI tools help with design, communication and routine tasks. But technology does not solve the fundamental problem: keeping a creative business financially sustainable.

Mansi manages this herself. Kamna relies on structure — separate teams for the studio, the wedding company and the cafe. "As the old adage goes — 'If you want to go far, you go with people. If you want to go fast, you go alone'... I don't believe in going fast. People who were beginners years ago now manage multiple departments here," she says.

Ishita agrees. "Building a strong team is as important as building a strong vision. Moreover, technology has become a big part of how we work... It doesn't replace creativity, but it gives us more time to focus on what matters. Profitability is important, but a sustainable business is even more valuable."



Land-use proposal of ground near Rashtrapati Bhavan among 34 Ridge projects under review

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 15

A PROPOSAL to use nearly 12.6 hectares of land at the President's Bodyguard (PBG) parade ground near Rashtrapati Bhavan, including 7.58 hectares of protected Ridge land, is among 34 projects being examined by the Standing Committee of the Delhi Ridge Management Board (SCDRMB), *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Minutes of the July 29 meeting of the SCDRMB, made available this month and accessed by *The Indian Express*, show that the committee has selected 10 of the 34 proposals for physical inspection.

While four of these will be inspected by the Standing Committee itself, six will be inspected by the Chief Conservator of Forests along with committee members, with the inspections to be completed before August 20. The projects

span construction, infrastructure, land use and other works.

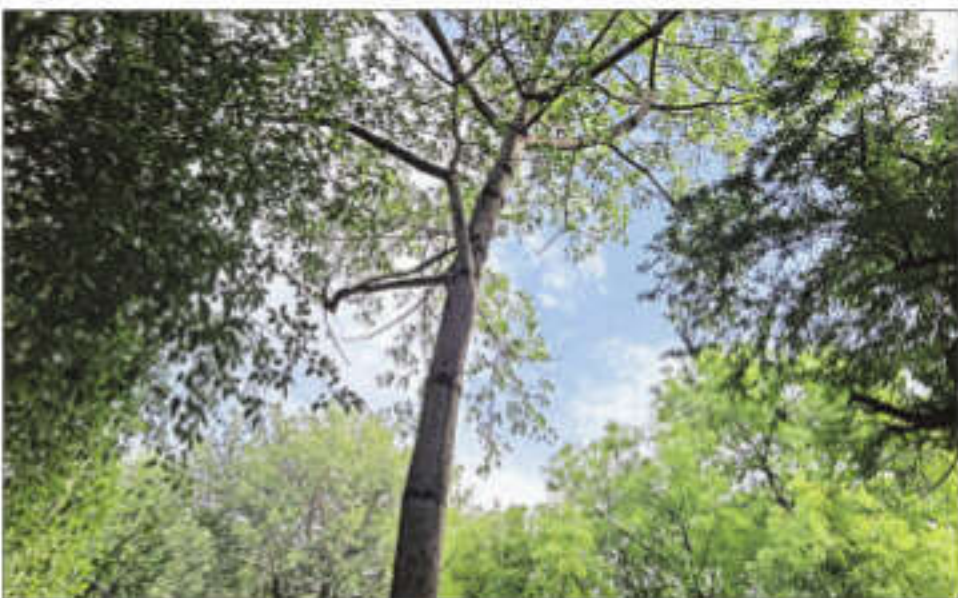
The PBG proposal seeks use of the land at the Central Ridge, opposite Gate 28 of Rashtrapati Bhavan, for training requirements. Officials said the proposal includes 7.58 hectares of additional protected Ridge land.

The Ridge is Delhi's forested and rocky green area that runs through several parts of the Capital.

The 34 proposals cover construction, infrastructure, land use and other works.

They include the Delhi-Karnataka Namo Bharat Corridor, a project at Jawaharlal Nehru University, development or redevelopment of Buddha Jayanti Park, conservation work at Sanjay Van, infrastructure projects at Army Hospital (R&R), Delhi Cantonment, and an office building for the ITBP.

JNU has sought permission for use of 2.262 hectares of land for construction of a lecture hall



The Ridge runs through several parts of the Capital. EXPRESS

complex, incubation centre and special centre for e-learning.

The list has also features proposals for a new road in Sangam Vihar, drainage work on M B Road, digging in the Central Ridge to lay an electric cable to Bhuli Bhatiyari ka Mahal, and a service road from Hanuman Mandir, Basant Gaon, to Niryat

Bhawan on the Outer Ring Road.

Several private construction and redevelopment proposals are also on the list, involving properties in Vasant Kunj, Vasant Vihar, Greater Kailash II, Okhla Industrial Area, Kailash Colony, East Patel Nagar and Malkaganj, among others.

During site inspections, the

committee will check whether the proposed work falls within the approved Morphological Ridge boundary and matches revenue records and authenticated GIS maps. It will also examine whether the proposed work is necessary and whether a feasible alternative outside the Ridge exists.

The impact of excavation, rock cutting, blasting and tree felling on slope stability, drainage, natural landforms, vegetation and the ecological integrity of the Ridge will also be assessed. It will also check compliance with the Forest (Conservation) Act, Wildlife (Protection) Act, the Master Plan for Delhi and Supreme Court and Ridge Management Board directions.

The approach was laid down at the committee's first meeting itself. It decided that proposals involving felling of more than 100 trees or diversion of more than one hectare of Ridge or

Morphological Ridge land would require a site inspection by all members of the Standing Committee before the proposal is considered. In other cases, the chairman can nominate two members to inspect the site and submit a report.

The July meeting also dealt with a separate complaint concerning alleged illegal construction and mining by R R Texknit LLP in Vasant Kunj. Separately, the Board is working on identifying encroachments in different Ridge areas.

The DDA has been asked to submit, within four weeks, status reports on demarcation and identification of encroachments in the South Central, Northern and Nankpura Ridges, while similar reports are to be submitted for the Central and Southern Ridges, officials said.

The Standing Committee's next meeting is tentatively scheduled for August 21.

• Skywatch



Forecast: August 16, 2026
Generally cloudy sky. Very light rain to light rain.

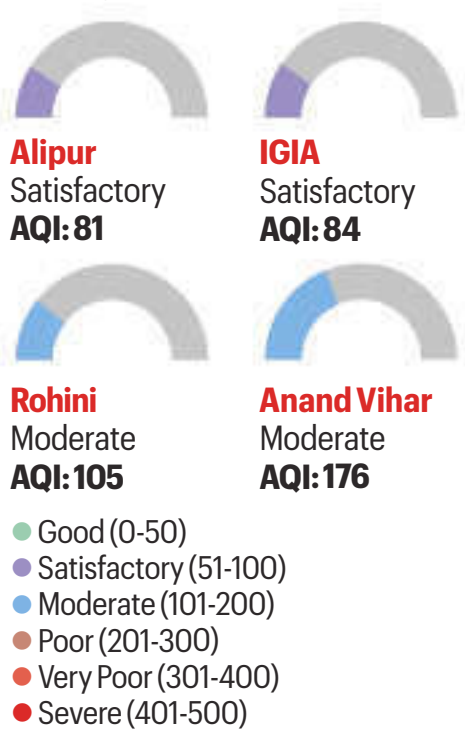
MAX: 32-34
0.2°C below normal

MIN: 23-25
3.5°C below normal

• **Sunrise:** 5:52 AM (August 17)
• **Sunset:** 7:00 PM (August 16)

• **Moonrise:** 10:17 AM (August 17)
• **Moonset:** 8:36 PM (August 16)

• AQI Tracker



Cost and deadline revised, road overhauls slowed by W Asia war set to pick up pace



Bitumen is used as a binder in road construction. FILE

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 15

EVEN AS the US-Iran conflict in West Asia slowed down the strengthening and repair of roads spanning 162 km in the Capital due to a surge in bitumen prices, the Delhi government's Public Works Department (PWD) is now aiming to finish the work before the year ends.

The Finance department's Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) has approved a revised cost for the project, which was originally targeted for completion by March 31 but the deadline was later extended to July 31. At Rs 587.95 crore, the revised cost is around Rs 194 crore higher, almost 50% more than the original estimates of about Rs 394 crore.

With the bitumen supply chain hit in the aftermath of the conflict, the EFC has approved revised preliminary estimates of Rs 215.23 crore from Rs 147.07 crore for strengthening roads spanning 58.292 km in the East Maintenance Zone and Rs 372.72 crore from Rs 247.31 crore for roads spread across 104.42 km in the North Maintenance Zone. This refers to a surge of 46% than the original cost in the East and 51% in North zones.

Sharp surge in bitumen cost

In the minutes of a recently-held meeting, the EFC gave the details: "...The price of bitumen had increased up to Rs 80,140 per metric tonne at the time of bid submission, whereas the original estimate was prepared based on Delhi Schedule of Rates (DSR) 2023 where the rate of bitumen was considered as Rs 40,831 per MT. This increase in price of bitumen stated to be due to disruption in the supply chain of bitumen due to Middle East disturbance."

Officials said that the PWD subsequently revised the estimates based on prevailing mar-

ket rates and tenders were floated. "Financial bids were also opened after justification of the tender, with the lowest bid for the East zone standing at Rs 164.55 crore and that for the North zone at Rs 290.44 crore...", said an official, adding, "Since the increase in the modified estimates was more than 10%, fresh administrative approval and expenditure sanction were required before the works could be awarded..."

Bitumen, derived from crude oil, is mainly used as a binder in road construction, where it holds together materials like sand, gravel, and crushed stone to form asphalt. It helps roads withstand traffic load and weather conditions.

Overhaul plan

Roads spread across 1,400 km in the Capital come under the purview of PWD, and the department has set a target to fix stretches spread over 1,000 km in the coming years. According to officials, several stretches were found to be in a dilapidated condition during internal reviews.

The latest target of covering 160 km could not be met due to the West Asia conflict despite a deadline revision. "Now, as the approvals have come, tendering process for repairing strengthening have been started again so that the works are completed before Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) during the winter season is implemented to tackle air pollution, which may impose a curb on construction work," one of the officials explained.

The projects are scheduled to have a 30-day planning period followed by 375 days of execution.

The Finance department has also directed PWD to ensure that the works are completed within the prescribed timelines, with stringent penalty clauses for delays and a project monitoring mechanism to track quality and progress.

MASTER PLAN FOR DELHI-2047

From Chandni Chowk to Lutyens' Delhi, heritage buildings could become hotels, offices

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 15

FROM THE havelis of Chandni Chowk in the Walled City to heritage buildings in Lutyens' Delhi and Civil Lines, the Capital's historic properties could soon get a new lease of life – as hotels, offices, museums, libraries and cultural spaces.

The draft Master Plan for Delhi (MPD)-2047 proposes incentives for owners to preserve heritage buildings while allowing them to adapt these structures for new uses, provided their architectural and historical character is protected.

The plan proposes an incentive Floor Area Ratio (FAR) of 50 for heritage properties. Incentive FAR is the extra building floor area granted by local authorities above the standard baseline limit while allowing construction on a plot of land. It is meant to make it financially worthwhile for owners to preserve their heritage properties. According to the plan, the incentive FAR will be awarded through Transferable Development Rights (TDR) certificates, subject to separate regulations that will be framed later.

But the incentive would come with conditions. According to the plan, "A TDR certificate will be issued only after the required repairs and improvements have been made and relevant certification is obtained from the concerned agency..." Owners could face penalties if



A street in Chandni Chowk. ARCHIVE/ABHINAV SAHA

they fail to carry out the repairs and promised maintenance or damage the heritage value of a building, it added.

New role for old buildings
The plan proposes adaptive reuse, allowing part or all of a heritage building to be converted for "commercial, office, hotel or socio-cultural uses". This could include performance spaces, museums, libraries, craft centres and similar activities, subject to approval by statutory authorities and a heritage impact assessment.

The basic condition – the building's heritage significance must be preserved. "Such conversion shall be allowed only where the character and heritage significance of the building are preserved," the plan stated.

It also proposes to relax space standards in heritage buildings

where necessary to make adaptive reuse practical. Fire and life-safety measures will have to be provided.

Heritage zones

Chandni Chowk in Walled City – Old Delhi, which is also known as Shahjahanabad – has been identified as one of three heritage zones because of its concentration of historic assets. The other two are Lutyens' Bungalow Zone and the Civil Lines Bungalow Area.

The plan also lists five archaeological parks – Mehrauli, Tughlaqabad Biodiversity Park, Sultan Garhi, Indraprastha and Northern Ridge.

The plan extends the conservation provisions to heritage buildings and structures that are "protected or unprotected, listed or non-listed", allowing conservation, restoration, re-

pair, reconstruction and adaptive reuse, subject to conditions.

Push for Walled City

For the revitalisation of the Walled City, the plan proposes a coordinated, multi-agency initiative for redevelopment. According to the plan, the concerned local body/agency will identify cultural precincts, prepare and implement conservation and area improvement plans for these precincts in coordination with concerned agencies.

"Support may be provided to the owners of heritage buildings for conservation, restoration and adaptive reuse...", it said.

Polluting industries

Further, the plan seeks to move out polluting industries from the Walled City. "...polluting industries and hazardous trades shall be removed from the Walled City. Godowns and wholesale activity shall be discouraged and shifted to compatible areas in the city. Storage of hazardous/inflammable commodities shall not be permitted and storage of bulky commodities shall be restricted," it said.

At the same time, the Walled City would be promoted as a cultural and commercial destination with an "active 24x7 economy". Performance spaces, small museums, libraries, reading rooms, craft centres and guest houses are

proposed to encourage the development of the area as a cultural hub.

Walkable streets

The plan also seeks to make the Walled City more pedestrian-friendly. It proposes mandatory setting up of public plazas around major transit stations in areas with high-rises.

Besides, shops, cafes and retail; walkable and barrier-free public spaces with shades; seating and other amenities are also on the cards.

Further, the plan proposes "zero tolerance" for encroachment and unauthorised occupation of public spaces, including illegal parking, extension of shops and vending non-designated areas. Heavy penalties have been proposed in the plan.

"Parks and open spaces within the Walled City shall not be used for creation of multi-level parking... Area improvement plans for katras, bazaars... shall be prepared in consultation with residents and stakeholders," the plan stated.

Once the policy is notified, the local bodies and concerned agencies will be directed to set up heritage cells to monitor and manage assets, identify landmark modern and industrial heritage, delineate cultural precincts and facilitate adaptive-reuse projects.

The plan also proposes setting up a Heritage Fund to support such initiatives.

Minor girl sexually assaulted, father arrested

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 15

A man in his thirties has been arrested in Northeast Delhi after his minor daughter alleged that he had repeatedly sexually assaulted her, police said on Saturday.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Northeast) Rahool Alwal said the accused was arrested on Thursday. He works for a private company.

The alleged abuse, said officers, took place when her mother was away at work. She said her father would sexually assault her and threaten her with consequences if she spoke of the abuse.

Police said the alleged sexual assault came to light last week when the girl told her mother about what had happened. Her mother then took her to the police station, and an FIR was subsequently registered.

The girl was then taken for a medical examination and investigators recorded her statement. Police said the accused was booked under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

Pink ticket facility extended until end of August

New Delhi: The Delhi government has again extended the pink ticket facility for women passengers in Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) buses till August 31, an official order said on Saturday. In an earlier direction issued by the Transport department, 'Pink Saheli' smart card was supposed to be made mandatory from August 16. "Accordingly, during this extended period, eligible women passengers may continue to be issued paper-based pink tickets for availing the free bus travel facility in DTC/DoT (Cluster) buses," the order said. So far, around 18 lakh cards have been distributed across the city. **PTI**

• FINDINGS SHOULD PROMPT RETHINK OF PREVENTIVE HEALTHCARE, PARTICULARLY FOR ADULTS OVER 40, ARGUES STUDY

1 in 20 adults from Delhi-NCR have both high sugar and blood pressure, reveals study

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, August 15

NEARLY 1 in 20 adults in the national capital region have both diabetes and hypertension – almost twice as often as would be expected if the two conditions occurred independently, according to a study of health records of more than 56,000 people.

The study, conducted by the Department of Clinical Research and Preventive Health Programme at Max Healthcare, analysed health records collected between January 2021 and December 2024 from select Max Healthcare Network hospitals in Delhi-NCR.

The hospitals included Max Hospital Saket, BLK-Max Hospital, Max Hospital Vaishali, Max Multi Speciality Centre Panchsheel Park, Max Hospital Noida and Max Hospital Dwarka.

Risk rises sharply after 40

The co-occurrence of diabetes and hypertension rose sharply from around age 40, continued increasing until about age 58 and then gradually levelled off. By around age 70, nearly 17% of people in the study had both conditions.

According to the study, the association between the two diseases was also strong. People

with diabetes were nearly four times more likely to have hypertension than those without diabetes. Conversely, people with hypertension were about 2.5 times more likely to have diabetes than those without hypertension.

'People take it lightly'

Dr Rommel Tickoo, Senior Director of Internal Medicine at Max Healthcare, said the pattern is not unique to Delhi.

"This is not a Delhi-specific phenomenon. It's an Asian, South Asian, nation phenomenon," he told *The Indian Express*, pointing to a combination of genetic and lifestyle factors. "There is some phenotype in our genes that causes it, as well as it being a lifestyle disease."

The clustering of cardiometabolic diseases has also been documented globally. A 2026 analysis of nearly 3.4 million adults screened across 105 countries found that hypertension was present in 56.1% of participants who had two or more cardiometabolic conditions. The prevalence rose with the number of conditions, reaching 63.3% among those with diabetes, a previous heart attack and a previous stroke. The findings of this study have a practical implication: people with diabetes, heart disease or a history of stroke should not

• What numbers reveal

METRIC	VALUE
Combined Rate	1 in 20 (5%) adults have both conditions
Rate at Age 70	~17% of individuals
Diabetes Impact	4x more likely to have high blood pressure
Hypertension Impact	2.5x more likely to have diabetes
Sample Size	56,000+ health records



have their blood pressure overlooked. The researchers had called for greater efforts to improve blood-pressure control in these high-risk groups.

But in his practice, Tickoo said, the bigger problem is often not a lack of awareness that these diseases exist, but the casual way people treat them.

"I see patients every day, from young to old, suffering from this. The issue is that there is a lack of understanding of the nuances of non-communicable diseases like diabetes and hypertension," he said. Even among educated and affluent patients, he added, many remain reluctant to take medication or undergo regular check-ups.

Misinformation on social media further complicates the problem, particularly around quick-fix treatments and fad diets.

"There is a lot of misinformation about hypertension

and diabetes cures. People follow social media influencers, fad diets," Tickoo said, citing weight-loss drugs such as Ozempic as an example.

"The people who are taking Ozempic don't need it, and the people who actually need it, those suffering from obesity, aren't taking it."

The concern comes against a backdrop of a growing obesity burden. Recent ICMR-INDIA studies estimate that more than 250 million people in India have generalised obesity, while over 350 million have abdominal obesity.

Tickoo warned that untreated diabetes and hypertension can eventually affect multiple organs. "These conditions need to be treated aggressively, with proper medication and lifestyle changes," he said.

In his practice, he said, poorly controlled diabetes can be followed by fatty liver and high blood pressure, with

80th Independence Day Celebrations



(Clockwise, from top) Union ministers Amit Shah, Rajnath Singh, Nirmala Sitharaman, S Jaishankar, Nitin Gadkari, Ashwini Vaishnaw, Shivraj Singh Chouhan and others during the Independence Day celebrations at the Red Fort; President Droupadi Murmu with Vice President C P Radhakrishnan, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla at the At Home hosted by Rashtrapati Bhavan; J&K CM Omar Abdullah in Srinagar; Armed Forces personnel at the Red Fort; Karnataka CM D K Shivakumar; and Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath in Lucknow on Saturday. PHOTOS: PRAVEEN KHANNA, SHUAIB MASOODI, GAJENDRA YADAV, ANI & AP



Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge, along with senior party leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi, during the Independence Day programme at AICC headquarters in Delhi on Saturday. GAJENDRA YADAV

BJP accuses Sonia of objecting to Vande Mataram recitation, Congress denies

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 15

THE BJP on Saturday accused Congress leader Sonia Gandhi of objecting to the recitation of the full version of Vande Mataram at the Congress party's Independence Day event. Congress denied the allegation, asserting that Sonia Gandhi was asking for a chair for party chief Mallikarjun Kharge, who had been standing for some time.

BJP national general secretary (organisation) B L Santhosh, sharing a video of the recitation on X, said: "Mother, son and national president seem to be upset by the rendering of the full Vande Mataram. Certain mindsets never change from pre-1947 to post-1947."

Former Union minister and BJP MP Anurag Thakur said Congress had once again demonstrated how uncomfortable its leaders were with Vande Mataram. "This is not a question of any party's protocol; it is a matter of respect for the entire nation." Accusing Congress of "petty and

appeasement politics", he demanded an apology from its leaders to the people of India.

Meanwhile, Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh cited a CWC meeting held in Calcutta on October 28, 1937, where on the advice of Rabindranath Tagore, it was decided that only the opening stanzas of Vande Mataram would be sung at Congress sessions.

"We have been singing those lines at every session since then. Our Seva Dal sings it, our workers sing it, there is no controversy over that," Ramesh said, adding that the full version of the national song was sung on Saturday. Categorically denying any attempt to stop the singing, he said, "As the Congress president had been standing for a long time, Sonia ji was asking for a chair for him."

BJP spokesperson C R Kesavan termed Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi "unpatriotic" and accused them of "blatantly insulting our glorious Vande Mataram on Independence Day".

"The Congress first family

has demeaned the sacrifices of freedom fighters who gave their lives for the country's Independence, chanting Vande Mataram. Nehru's Congress truncated Vande Mataram in 1937 for appeasement politics; Rahul's Congress, driven by the same agenda, has gravely insulted it today. Shame on the Congress leadership," he said.

Former Kerala CM and senior CPM leader Pinarayi Vijayan, however, criticised Congress from the opposite direction, accusing it of abandoning its legacy of secular democracy. "The full version of Vande Mataram was sung at Independence Day functions, including at the AICC headquarters and in Congress-ruled states, despite there being no legal obligation to do so. This ideological convergence weakens the united struggle of secular forces against communalism. At a time when defending India's secular and democratic character demands greater unity, Congress's capitulation to the Sangh Parivar only serves to undermine it," he said.

Kerala govt skips Vande Mataram on I-Day despite Cong-led states complying

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram,
August 15

KERALA'S CONGRESS-LED United Democratic Alliance decided to skip Vande Mataram at the state's official Independence Day function on Saturday, defying the central government's directive to sing the full six-stanza version of the national song.

This came despite Congress headquarters in Delhi and official functions in the party-ruled states of Karnataka and Himachal Pradesh complying with the directive. Chief Secretary Bishwanath Sinha had forwarded a central government communication to the state's general education and local self-government departments to have the full version of Vande Mataram sung as part of its "Har Ghar Tiranga" campaign.

The communication led to a backlash, with the Opposition accusing the UDF of "toeing the Sangh Parivar line". In response, the state's V D Satheesan government had said that its own stand "will be made clear at Independence Day celebrations". Despite the government skipping the song at the state function, Vande Mataram was sung at events at the Lok Bhavan and in the BJP-ruled Thiruvananthapuram municipal corporation.

Meanwhile, the difference in the stance of the state's political parties became stark at Independence Day celebrations at the Kozhikode Municipal Corporation, where BJP councillors recited Vande Mataram at the same time that the civic body's ruling CPI(M) sang the national anthem. After the communication, several schools in Kerala listed Vande Mataram as part of their Inde-



Kerala CM V D Satheesan at an Independence Day event on Saturday. X/ @VDSATHEESAN

pendence Day events. But a circular from the general education department to all educational institutions on August 11 directed all schools to hoist the national flag and recite the national anthem at the I-Day function without mentioning Vande Mataram.

The last two weeks have been rife with suspense over whether the V D Satheesan government will allow the recital of Vande Mataram at the official function in Kerala. The BJP seized upon the issue, claiming that Congress was acting at the behest of ally Indian Union Muslim League, which has the ministries of education and local self-government in the state government.

The Vande Mataram controversy has been haunting the Congress government in Kerala since the day it assumed office in May this year. The song was sung in its entirety during the Cabinet's swearing-in on May 18. For his part, Satheesan had justified the decision, saying Lok Bhavan had held the ceremony. With that controversy in mind, the government did not play the full version of Vande Mataram during the first session of the Assembly.

‘Pradhan Sevak’ to Viksit Bharat: Arc of PM’s I-Day speeches

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 15

IN HIS 2026 Independence Day speech, Prime Minister Narendra Modi put India's youth, energy security and the speed of governance at the centre of his pitch, combining immediate economic concerns with the larger goal of making India a developed and strategically autonomous power.

The speech marked another stage in an evolution visible across his 12 previous addresses: from the early emphasis on a more responsive government and everyday delivery, Modi's speeches gradually expanded into a larger project of economic transformation, national security and self-reliance, before acquiring an increasingly explicit civilisational and political vocabulary.

The 2047 goal of Viksit Bharat now provides the umbrella under which these strands — welfare, technology, jobs, energy, security and governance — are brought together.

2014: New style of governance

Modi's first Independence Day speech was a declaration of how he intended to govern. Presenting himself as the "Pradhan Sevak", he promised a government that would serve citizens, cut through bureaucratic silos and make development participatory. Cleanliness, financial inclusion, skills and manufacturing became early markers of the new government's agenda.

He announced Jan Dhan, Swachh Bharat, Sansad Adarsh Gram Yojana and Make in India push. Emphasis was on visible delivery and economic opportunity, establishing the vocabulary of the early Modi government: an accessible state, citizen participation, manufacturing-led growth and a break from a slow, distant administrative culture.

2015: Expanding development coalition

A year into office, Modi broadened the development pitch, placing greater emphasis on social cohesion and inclusion amid criticism over social tensions. "The strength of India lies in the simplicity of Indians and the unity in every corner of India," he said. Technology, transparency and delivery were presented as tools to fight corruption and welfare leakages.

The major announcements included Startup India and Stand Up India, the latter aimed at Scheduled Caste, Scheduled Tribe and women entrepreneurs, alongside One Rank, One Pension. Rural electrification, soil-health cards, insurance and irrigation rounded out the agenda, expanding the government's development coalition beyond its initial governance and manufacturing pitch.

2016: Harder national-security pitch

Modi's speech shifted from establishing a new governance style to claiming its results. Framing the journey as one from "Swaraj to Surajya", he cited faster services, administrative simplification, infrastructure and financial inclusion as evidence of a more responsive state. "There was a time when governments used to be surrounded by allegations. Today, they are surrounded by aspirations."

The speech, however, came amid the Kashmir unrest following militant Burhan Wani's killing and gave national security a much larger role. Modi combined an outreach to Kashmir — "Neither by bullets nor by abuses, but by embracing the people of Kashmir" — with references to Balochistan, Gilgit and PoK. The address fused delivery with a more assertive security posture.

2017: 'New India'

Three years into office, Modi turned the development agenda into a five-year national mission: building a "New India" by 2022. Delivered after the implementation of GST and amid criticism over demonetisation, unemployment, agrarian distress and

EXPRESS special



PM Narendra Modi at the Red Fort on Saturday. TASHI TOBGYAL

social tensions, the speech called for an end to the "chalta hai" attitude. "We have to think of 'badal sakta hai'," he said.

The speech combined anti-corruption measures and formalisation with a promise to double farmers' incomes and develop eastern India. National security was broadened to include terrorism, Kashmir, Maoism, cyberspace and outer space. The political pitch was increasingly about changing the national mindset — replacing resignation with aspiration.

2018: Welfare, women & more assertive India

With the 2019 Lok Sabha election approaching, Modi's speech was more explicitly a report card on four years of government. It highlighted sanitation, infrastructure, manufacturing and digitalisation, with Ayushman Bharat as the major new welfare promise. Women's empowerment featured through maternity benefits, military participation and the government's push against instant triple talaq.

National security received equal political weight. Modi invoked the surgical strikes in response to the Uri terror attack as evidence India would no longer respond passively to cross-border terror, while Gaganyaan spaceflight programme symbolised technological ambition.

2019: Decisive action, new national agenda

Delivered after the BJP's return to power with a larger majority and the removal of J&K's special status, the speech reflected the confidence of a government with a renewed mandate. Article 370 and Article 35A dominated the political message. Modi presented their removal as the completion of national integration: "The work which could not be done in the last 70 years has been completed within 70 days."

The forward agenda centred on water, with the Jal Shakti Ministry and Jal Jeevan Mission. Modi also announced the creation of a Chief of Defence Staff role, called for a national debate on population growth and pushed infrastructure, economic reform and border development. The government was now presenting itself as one willing to take decisions on longstanding national questions.

2020: Atmanirbharta

Delivered amid the Covid-19 pandemic, economic contraction and the Ladakh standoff with China, Modi framed Atmanirbhara Bharat as the route out of extraordinary vulnerability. "Atmanirbhara Bharat has become a mantra for 130 crore Indians," he said, linking health, manufacturing, defence, technology and supply chains. "Vocal for local" became both an economic and patriotic imperative.

The principal announcement was the National Digital Health Mission, with digital health IDs and integrated records. He also spoke of vaccines, stronger health infrastructure, domestic defence production, border infrastructure and agricultural reform.

2021: Crisis management to 2047 project

As India emerged from the devastating second Covid-19 wave, Modi shifted from immediate crisis management to a longer-term national project. "Sabka Prayas" was added to "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas", while the hor-

izon moved decisively towards 2047, the centenary of Independence. The major announcements included the National Hydrogen Mission and Gati Shakti, alongside an emphasis on small farmers, women's self-help groups, digital connectivity, semiconductors and 5G. Atmanirbhara Bharat was recast as a "mass movement", a framework for India's long-term economic, tech, energy ambitions.

2022: Development gets civilisational frame

The 2022 address gave the 2047 project an explicit ideological and civilisational framework. Modi laid out the "Panch Pran": a developed India, removal of the colonial mindset, pride in India's roots, unity, and a sense of duty. "Viksit Bharat" was thus presented as more than an economic goal, tied instead to national identity and cultural confidence.

The political contrast with the Opposition also sharpened, with Modi identifying corruption and dynastic politics as major challenges.

2023: Viksit Bharat becomes poll project

In the final year before the 2024 Lok Sabha election, Modi presented the previous nine years as a period of national transformation and growing global stature. Viksit Bharat by 2047 remained central, but the address had a distinctly political edge, with corruption, dynastic politics and appeasement identified as the principal obstacles to progress.

The speech expanded the welfare pitch, particularly for women and the middle class. Housing support, semiconductors, green energy, defence and border infrastructure rounded out the agenda. Continuity was presented as necessary to complete the 2047 transformation.

2024: Reform, renewal

Modi's first Independence Day speech of his third term combined continuity with an attempt to respond to concerns over jobs, governance and political renewal. Viksit Bharat remained the overarching goal, but emphasis shifted towards "ease of living", technology, education and reducing everyday burdens of government.

Two proposals carried particular political weight: One Nation, One Election and a Uniform Civil Code, which Modi recast as a "secular civil code". He also called for a lakh young people without political family backgrounds to enter politics. The economic pitch moved beyond Make in India towards "Design in India, Design for the World", semiconductors, AI and gaming. It was a reformist response to a more competitive political environment.

2025: Viksit Bharat

The speech gave self-reliance its most expansive meaning yet, linking it directly to national security, energy, technology, employment and strategic autonomy. Coming after the Pahalgam attack and Operation Sindoor, security was particularly prominent. Modi presented indigenous defence capabilities as proof that India could respond more assertively, declaring "no nuclear blackmail" would be accepted.

It brought together strands developed over the previous decade: Viksit Bharat as the destination, Atmanirbhara Bharat as the means, and strategic autonomy as the rationale.

Rahul Gandhi gets privilege notice for allegations against Shah

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 15

LEADER OF Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, has been served a breach of privilege notice for allegedly using “unparliamentary and derogatory language” and for levelling “grave allegations” against Union Home Minister Amit Shah, it is learnt.

The senior Congress leader is learnt to have been asked to furnish his reply by August 28 for consideration by Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla after he received two notices in this regard from Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) Chief Whip Sanjay Jaiswal and party MP Anurag Thakur.

Thakur is said to have given a notice of “question of breach of privilege” and “contempt of the House” on July 30, accusing Gandhi of “using unparliamentary and derogatory language and for levelling grave allegations against” Shah without adequate advance notice under Rule 353 during the debate on Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026.

Meanwhile, Jaiswal, in a letter on July 29, is learnt to have asked Birla to take cognisance of the alleged use of “unparliamentary expressions” by Gandhi during the debate on the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, and to take appropriate action under the Rules of Procedure.

He is said to have submitted that while strong criticism of government policy is a legitimate and essential feature of parliamentary democracy, personal attacks and the use of language that is insulting, defamatory or otherwise unparliamentary cannot be permitted within the proceedings of the House of the People.

It is learnt that Jaiswal has asked the Chair to appropriately caution and warn Gandhi to maintain the standards of dignity, restraint and decorum .

Hunting in social media comments

Over two years, agencies in multiple states have traced dozens of young men recruited online by Pakistan-based gangster Shehzad Bhatti and his aides, allegedly at the ISI's behest. MOHAMED THAVER reports on a network that scans Instagram comments for the broke and the addicted

ASHRAF DANIYAL, 23, a handloom worker from Barabanki in Uttar Pradesh, living in Bhiwandi, Maharashtra; Sajid Mehboob Shaikh, 21, a garbage collector from Kurla, Mumbai; Krishna Mishra, 20, of Gorakhpur, UP; Amarjit Singh and Karanjit Singh (both 19) and Satnam Singh, 22, friends from Gurdaspur, Punjab — these are a few of the many youngsters identified in the past two years by law enforcement agencies across the country as having been lured via social media by Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI), and nurtured as sleeper cells to carry out activities at its behest.

At the heart of the alleged operations, as per officials, is Pakistani gangster Shehzad Bhatti and his associates. Daniyal was allegedly befriended in January this year on Instagram by Hamad Memon, Bhatti's aide.

After he had been suitably impressed by Memon, Daniyal was reportedly invited to another messaging group where one of the main topics of discussion was state of minorities in India and how to change it. Soon, Daniyal was allotted a seemingly harmless “task” in exchange for money: he was to take a video of the local Narpoli police station in Bhiwandi and send it to Memon.

After Daniyal sent a 17-second video he was assigned another “task”, officials said. He was to put up 50 printouts of a photo of Pakistani gangster Abid Jatt, sending a video as proof.

In the first week of May, the UP Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) picked Daniyal up from Gorakhpur. They claimed to have recovered a firearm from his residence, and alleged he had been roped in to target key institutions in UP and other cities.

Unlike the above plot that was foiled, the grenade attack at Gurdaspur police station on November 25, 2025 — for which Amarjit, Karanjit and Satnam Singh were held — was an example of a successful hit, say

officials. They also see a similar plot in the mysterious killing of three policemen along the India-Pakistan border in Gurdaspur and Amritsar earlier this year.

In July, ATS teams conducted raids in over 20 cities of Rajasthan and 28 youngsters “linked to Bhatti” were detained, for allegedly planning activities that would have disturbed the law and order situation. As per ATS officials in UP and Maharashtra, in several cases, firearms were dropped across the border using drones, and youngsters from border areas like Punjab and Rajasthan were lured to move these. Bhatti posting on Instagram has denied the allegations and threatened police officials who blame him.

Incidentally, Indian gangster Lawrence Bishnoi, who has been imprisoned in Sabarmati Jail in Ahmedabad since August 2023 and was recently charged by US authorities with the killing of Sikh separatist leader Hardeep Singh Nijjar, is believed to use similar social media modus operandi to recruit for his gang. Lately positioning himself as a rival of Bhatti, Bishnoi has started using patriotism and religion as his USP. Bishnoi and Bhatti have claimed they were friends in the past, who fell out over deteriorating relations between India and Pakistan.

Troubled youngsters

Officials who have profiled the youngsters say a majority have not finished schooling, are from troubled families, face drug or alcohol addiction, and are working in low-paying odd jobs. Some are lured by talk of attacks on minorities while some are unhappy with the “system”. As per officials, the biggest incentive, is money, paid up front.

In the most recent arrests, a Delhi Police Special Cell in coordination with Maharashtra ATS, on May 28 held eight youngsters from across the country, including Sajid, who collects garbage for a living.



Delhi Special Cell officers with the arrested accused . EXPRESS

Cases registered

2026

FEBRUARY: Double murder of assistant sub-inspector Gurnam Singh and Home Guard jawan Ashok Kumar at a joint checkpoint in Adhian village, barely 2 km from the Pakistan border, by three youngsters, on alleged instructions from overseas. One of the youths killed in a police encounter.

APRIL: Delhi Police Special Cell arrests Rajveer (21) and Vivek Banjara (19) from Madhya Pradesh, for being “in touch with” Pakistani gangster Rana Hunain.

MAY: Uttar Pradesh ATS arrests 17 youngsters in connection with “links to Bhatti”; Delhi Special Cell arrests eight youngsters from several states on the same charges.

JULY: ATS teams conduct raids in more than 20 cities of Rajasthan and 28 youngsters “linked to Shahzad Bhatti” detained.

2025

OCTOBER: Three youngsters, two 19 and one 22, arrested for hurling a grenade at a Gurdaspur police station. Police say their mobile phones contain incriminating chats with Bhatti.

As per agencies, Sajid responded to a reel posted by two aides of Bhatti, Runa Hunain and Yawar Khan, on Instagram, following which the latter got in touch with him. He was given Rs 25,000 and told his “task” was to attack security personnel and government buildings in Delhi, officials say. His uncle Iqbal Shaikh says Sajid struggled with substance abuse, due to which he was thrown out of the house.

Tauqeer Shaikh, 26, arrested along with Sajid, told the officials he received Rs 21,000 from the same source. Sher Bano, Tauqeer's aunt, says he was addicted to intoxicants. “He told

me he had got Rs 21,000 in his bank account after he was introduced to an online contact.”

“In the UP ATS case, which saw 17 persons arrested, Mohammad Umar and Faizan were instructed to paste posters carrying photographs and messages glorifying Abid Jatt at public places. Umar and Faizan, who have only studied till Class 5, were promised Rs 12,000 each,” an officer says.

Anil Shukla, Special Commissioner, Delhi Police Special Cell, who has been part of a crackdown on Bhatti, says: “Usually, youngsters who are from low-income groups and...



Two of the three policemen killed earlier this year in Punjab

IN THE DRAGNET



(From left) Abid Jatt; Rana Hunain; Shahzad Bhatti's account on Instagram blocked in India



desperate for money and purpose, are the kind of people who fall prey to these traps... They are promised they will be relocated to Dubai or other countries, and told they would be heroes for the community.”

Amitabh Yash, UP ADG (Law & Order), says, age of those targeted is a factor and that, “once a youngster is lured .. they will ask for references of other...”.

A UP ATS officer says Mishra was angry about police not helping him against a relative, who had reportedly denied his family a share of the land, after his father passed away. He was allegedly lured by Bhatti's gang with the promise of “avenging the injustice”, and was told that in exchange, he would be given firearms to attack an officer of the local police station. Mishra was to make a video of the attack and send it to them. The ATS claims to have recovered a pistol and cartridges from Mishra.

So far, the agencies have found no instances of women

being lured by these accounts.

The comments section

It is the comments section of social media platforms like Instagram that has become a hunting ground, officers say, with Bhatti and others putting up flashy social media posts positioning themselves as saviours of the disgruntled. Bhatti's gang starts going through the comments to identify the targets.

An officer says: “Once the person has successfully completed the small tasks, they are used for the bigger ones. In some of the cases, they are also asked to travel to Delhi or other places to receive arms and ammunition.”

UP ADG Yash says: “It is graded work, where one task leads to another. Like, first they will be told to put up posters, then to set things on fire, and so on and so forth.”

A Maharashtra ATS officer says some of the targets are youngsters who belong to minority community as they post

reels from Muslim localities.

Law enforcement

Officials say that in most cases, they counsel the youngsters concerned and, if they are not involved in any incident leading to harm, an FIR is registered and they are let off after counselling.

Agencies have also started actively following some of the suspect overseas names on social media to keep a watch. In many cases, they approach youngsters who appear to have been identified as targets and warn them, an officer says. In most cases, social media platforms are approached to get accounts blocked in India.

However, the official underlines the difficult battle: “The accused keep creating new accounts from which they post reels, usually with figures 333, 666 or 999 in their handles.”

An officer says “Earlier terror networks would either send their own people or arrange for people from India to get training and then send them back. There is a lot that could go wrong in this. Using ill-guided, vulnerable youngsters of the same country proves much more effective and easier. Even if they fail, there is nothing to lose.”

Who are Shehzad Bhatti, others

Bhatti, who is believed to shuttle between Dubai and Pakistan, faces charges of bomb-making and the supply of illegal arms and ammunition to India, Dubai, the US, and Canada. He is known to be close to Balochistan-based gangster Farooq Khokhar.

Apart from allegations of luring youngsters on social media, Bhatti is accused of being involved in the March 2024 grenade attack at YouTuber Rozer Sandhu's residence in Jalandhar, Punjab, and threat to actor Mithun Chakraborty in November 2024 over his purported remarks against Muslims.

25 नई अटल कैंटीन के उद्घाटन के साथ
दिल्ली में 100 अटल कैंटीन की ऐतिहासिक उपलब्धि

उद्घाटन कार्यक्रम

मुख्य अतिथि

श्री एम. वैकैया नायडू

माननीय पूर्व उपराष्ट्रपति

विशिष्ट अतिथि

श्रीमती रेखा गुप्ता

माननीय मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

श्री आशीष सूद

माननीय शहरी विकास मंत्री, दिल्ली सरकार

श्री मनोज कुमार तिवारी

माननीय सांसद, उत्तर-पूर्वी दिल्ली

श्री सूर्य प्रकाश खत्री

माननीय विधायक, तिमारपुर



16 अगस्त 2026



सुबह 11:00 बजे



विश्वविद्यालय मेट्रो स्टेशन गेट नं 3, तिमारपुर, दिल्ली

नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री

दिल्ली शहरी आश्रय सुधार बोर्ड, राष्ट्रीय राजधानी क्षेत्र, दिल्ली सरकार

रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

FDA notices to SRK, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff over Vimal Elaichi ad

Heena Khandelwal
Mumbai, August 15

THE MAHARASHTRA Food and Drug Administration (FDA) is learned to have issued show-cause notices to Bollywood actors Ajay Devgn, Shah Rukh Khan and Tiger Shroff, alleging that their advertisement for Vimal Elaichi amounts to surrogate advertising for Vimal Pan Masala, a product prohibited in the state.

The three actors are the latest to come under the FDA's scrutiny as the regulator steps up its crackdown on gutkha and pan masala containing tobacco or nicotine, coordinating with police to invoke the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA) against eligible cases involving organised networks dealing in banned products.

"Upon examination of the said advertisement, it prima facie appears that the advertisement promotes the Vimal brand, which is mainly associated with Pan Masala, a product prohibited for manufacture,

storage, transportation, distribution and sale in the State of Maharashtra for a period of one year, with effect from the date specified in the Prohibition Order dated the 13th July, 2026, issued by the Commissioner of Food Safety, Maharashtra State, under Section 30(2)(a) of the FSS Act, 2006," the notice states.

The regulator has also invoked Section 24 of the Food Safety and Standards (FSS) Act, 2006, which restricts misleading and deceptive food advertisements, and Section 53, which provides for a penalty of up to Rs 10 lakh for anyone who is "party to the publication" of a misleading food advertisement. The three actors have been asked to respond.

The Vimal Elaichi campaign had faced regulatory scrutiny earlier too. In 2018, the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) issued show-cause notices to Vishnu Pouch Packaging Pvt Ltd, which promotes, advertises Vimal Elaichi under the Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act (COTPA), 2003.

Uttarakhand tunnel flooding: 8 dead, search on for two missing

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, August 15

WITH WATER and debris flooding an under-construction tunnel at the Vishnugad-Pipalkoti Hydroelectric Project, making rescue challenging, rescuers are turning to an unlikely method — blue polymer drums. This comes as rescuers recovered one more body, taking the death toll to eight.

A landslide caused water and debris to gush into an under-construction Tail Race Tunnel (TRT) — an underground passage for water discharge at hydroelectric power plants — at the Tehri Hydro Development Corporation India Limited's (THDCIL) Vishnugad-Pipalkoti Hydroelectric Project on Thursday, trapping several workers. According to officials, the blue drums are being used for rescue because the mix of debris and heavy machinery is making the operations challenging.

The death toll stands at eight. Twelve people are ad-



Rescue operation underway at the under-construction tunnel in Uttarakhand's Chamoli district. SOURCE: SDRF

mitted to hospitals while two people remain missing.

"Twelve workers saw the water rising and managed to escape. Others got trapped. Bodies of eight trapped people have been found while two workers are still missing."

The NDRF, the SDRF, the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), the Army, the Central Industrial Security Force and

the Uttarakhand Police are part of the rescue operations. Underwater cameras and dog squads are also being used.

According to officials, at the time of the incident, workers deployed by the principal executing agency — Hindustan Construction Company (HCC) — were concreting the tunnel lining.

Officials say the heavy rain

and the water and debris in the tunnel have made the rescue challenging. "Water and debris have entered the tunnel. Cement, metallic equipment and heavy machines are submerged in the mud," one rescuer said. "Our feet keep getting caught. Also, since heavy machinery is trapped under the debris, it could potentially hurt rescuers, so we have to move carefully."

Then there is the race against time — seepage from the tunnel roof and walls is causing water levels to rise inside. According to officials, water levels inside the tunnel rose from 2.5 feet on Friday to four feet on Saturday. For rescuers, this means they cannot use conventional rescue methods such as rafts. "Rafts can get damaged and burst due to obstruction caused by the submerged machines," one senior official said.

Rescuers then hit upon the solution: improvised rafts made of blue drums that can float easily. For this, the SDRF would assemble four drums to

make a raft, then place wooden boards on top for seating.

Each such raft can seat four people. One such raft has also been given to the NDRF.

But the incessant rain and continued seepage remain a challenge. "Water is being drained out continuously from the affected area inside the tunnel," Uttarakhand SDRF Commandant Arpan Yaduvanshi told The Indian Express. "There is heavy seepage inside, and the construction company is fixing the problem. Even after draining the water, the search would still be a task because of the size of the area."

On Saturday, rescuers recovered the body of yet another worker, identified as Devnath from Chhattisgarh. The body was found 400 metres inside the tunnel.

In its statement, THDCIL has announced an ex-gratia of Rs 5 lakh for the families of the deceased and Rs 1 lakh for the injured. Calls and texts to HCC went unanswered.

19-yr-old delivery boy assaulted in Meerut; probe on

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 15

A 19-YEAR-OLD gigworker was allegedly assaulted and verbally abused by a customer at whose residence he had gone to deliver grocery items in Meerut on Friday evening. The victim also alleged that the accused threatened to falsely implicate him in a sexual assault case if he spoke about the incident.

The incident came to light after a video of the assault circulated on social media, drawing the attention of local authorities. The victim, Amit Yadav, subsequently approached Bhawanpur police station and got a case registered against the customer, identified as Yaman, a resident of Bhawanpur area in Meerut.

The case has been registered on charges of intentional insult with intent to provoke a breach of peace, criminal intimidation and voluntarily causing hurt. No arrests have been made so far. Amit Yadav, a Class 12 student and resident of Ganganagar, works part-time as a delivery agent to supplement his family's income.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable /Radio Mechanic Ugrasen Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants in Gulshan Nagar area, Srinagar (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

CONSTABLE CHANDAN RAY
135 BN BSF 26.10.1982 – 16.08.2012
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Chandan Ray on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in Counter-part firing in area of BOP Abdullian, Jammu and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

ASI/RM RUDAL YADAV
165 BN BSF 07.07.1987 – 16.08.2014
HC SUBEDAR YADAV
165 BN BSF 01.07.1967 – 16.08.2014
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Subordinate officer Assistant Sub Inspector/ Radio Mechanic Rudal Yadav and Head Constable Subedar Yadav on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants in Awantipura area, Srinagar (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

CONSTABLE DAVANRA SINGH, PMG
76 BN BSF 18.03.1969 – 16.08.1991
CONSTABLE YOGESH KUMAR YADAV, PMG
76 BN BSF 11.12.1969 – 16.08.1991
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Constable Davanra Singh and Yogesh Kumar Yadav on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants Awantipura area, Srinagar (J&K). They fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. Their sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding them with PMG (Posthumously).

CONSTABLE DEVENDER SINGH
62 BN BSF 30.11.1968 – 16.08.1995
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Devender Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in an IED blast in area of Lolab valley, Kupwara (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

Central Reserve Police Force
Veer Balidani Naik Harnam Singh 1 Bn 14-4-1927 To 16-8-1967
DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Naik Harnam Singh of 1 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured in a fierce encounter with insurgents on 16 August 1967. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Ramniwas Sharma 76 Bn 2-6-1947 To 16-8-1988
DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Ramniwas Sharma of 76 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in an encounter with terrorists in Tarn Taran district, Punjab, on 16 August 1988. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable M. A. Deshmukh 73 Bn 1-6-1963 To 16-8-1991
DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable M. A. Deshmukh of 73 Bn, who attained the martyrdom on 16 August 1991 after succumbing to injuries sustained during an exchange of fire with terrorists on 15 August 1991 in Punjab. For his bravery, he was awarded Police Medal for Gallantry posthumously. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Ramphal Yadav 23 Bn 8-10-1970 To 16-8-2002
DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Ramphal Yadav of 23 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured in a cowardly attack by a militant when he was performing sentry duty at one of the posts of Raghunath Mandir, Baramulla, Jammu & Kashmir, on 16 August 2002. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Head Constable Riyaz Ahmad Rather 181 Bn 1-12-1975 To 16-8-2017
DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Riyaz Ahmad Rather of 181 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 16 August 2017 after succumbing to grievous injuries sustained in a grenade attack while performing law and order duties in Budgam district, Jammu & Kashmir. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)
Head Constable Dula Singh
Constable Sandeep Kumar
Constable Subhash Chand Berwal
Constable Dinesh Singh Bohra
ITBP salutes its bravehearts Head Constable Dula Singh of 54th Battalion, Constable Sandeep Kumar of 4th Battalion, Constable Subhash Chand Berwal of 54th Battalion, Constable Dinesh Singh Bohra of 4th Battalion, Constable Abhiraj of 54th Battalion and Constable Amit Kumar of 54th Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Jammu & Kashmir in 2022.

Setback for Antrix as US appeals court upholds \$565m award to Devas

Express News Service
Bengaluru, August 15

A US appeals court has upheld a district court order confirming a \$562.5 million compensation award to Indian startup Devas Multimedia over a failed 2005 satellite deal with ISRO's commercial arm, Antrix Corp. The award is now \$1.2 billion with interest.

In an opinion provided on August 12, the US Court of Appeals for the Ninth Circuit stated that the US federal court for the Western District of Washington had jurisdiction to confirm an International Chamber of Commerce (ICC) arbitration award against Antrix Corp, as the latter did not enjoy arbitration immunity as a foreign sovereign entity. "The FSIA's (Foreign Sovereign Immunities Act) arbitration exception withdraws immunity from Antrix because this case concerns an award governed by a treaty in force for the United States," the court ruled.

The court, however, granted some relief to Antrix, ruling that the district court had erred in allowing Mauritius-based shareholders of the now-liquidated Devas Multimedia to seize Antrix properties in the US.

The dispute between Bengaluru-based, foreign-funded Devas Multimedia and Antrix

Corp dates back to a 2005 satellite deal. Under the failed deal, ISRO was to lease two communication satellites for 12 years at a cost of Rs 167 crore to Devas. The startup was to provide multi-media services to mobile platforms in India using the space band or S-band transponders on ISRO's GSAT 6 and 6A satellites, built at a cost of Rs 766 crore.

In February 2011, the UPA government annulled the Devas-Antrix satellite deal, citing the need to reserve space spectrum allocated for Devas's services for security purposes. The deal, signed during its tenure, was cancelled after it was cited as a 'sweetheart deal' and flagged as an instance of corruption after the 2G telecom scam. After the NDA government came to power in 2014, central agencies began investigating the deal even as Devas Multimedia and its foreign investors approached various international tribunals seeking compensation for the failed deal.

Devas Multimedia was awarded \$565.2 million by ICC on September 14, 2015. The National Company Law Tribunal in India ordered the liquidation of Devas Multimedia on May 25, 2021, citing fraudulence in its creation. The Supreme Court upheld the order on January 17, 2022.



The office of the Deputy Range Forest Officer in Shagya that was vandalised allegedly by villagers. PTI

Karnataka CM orders magisterial probe into deaths of 3 'poachers'

Express News Service
Bengaluru, August 15

KARNATAKA CHIEF Minister D K Shivakumar on Saturday ordered a magisterial inquiry into the death of three alleged poachers in the Chamarajanagar region of Cauvery wildlife reserve on Saturday morning following firing by Forest personnel.

"The truth will be known after the investigation. The shootout took place in a forest area. Several witnesses have been questioned, and items, including guns, have been seized. Some people have been arrested, and the bodies are being taken for post-mortem," Shivakumar said.

The three who died in the shoot-out have been identified as Antony Swamy, 50, John Rose Peter, 42, and Kumar alias Savariyappan, 33. They are residents of a local

village on the fringe of the reserve. A fourth person, Mahimadan, 45, was admitted to a private hospital on account of the injuries.

The Forest authorities said they chanced upon the alleged poachers when they were carrying deer meat after a hunt in the forest, and stressed that they resorted to the use of firearms only after they themselves came under fire.

Nonetheless, the deaths have heightened tensions in the region. Locals allegedly vandalised the office of a Deputy Range Forest Officer in retaliation, and claimed that the men who were killed were indeed innocent and not involved in poaching.

Incidentally, the region where the incident happened is part of the territory once dominated by the notorious forest brigand Veerappan, who was killed over two decades ago.

Dairy operator's murder: Locals, cops clash at I-day function

Express News Service
Chandigarh, August 15

SEVERAL VILLAGERS and policemen were injured in clashes in Haryana's Hansi town on Friday after hundreds of protesters converged on the town to demand the arrest of the main accused in the murder of a dairy operator.

The protest was timed to coincide with the Independence Day function at which Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini was to hoist the Tricolour.

Tension escalated when protesters insisted on marching towards the venue. Police resorted to a lathicharge to disperse the crowd, who allegedly responded with stone-pelting. Hansi Superintendent of Police Vinod Kumar and a DSP sustained injuries.

The SP said five to six police personnel were injured in the clashes. Despite the violence, the Independence Day function concluded without disruption, with Saini hoisting the flag as scheduled.

The police have registered an FIR against nearly 200 persons, including women and farmer leaders Suresh Koth and Shamsher Nambardar.

The protesters were demanding the arrest of the main accused in the murder of Jeevan, who was allegedly attacked by nearly a dozen youths in neighbouring Hisar on August 4. Police have arrested nine accused, but the main accused, allegedly close to an influential MLA, remains absconding.

MP govt halts fertiliser sales for stock check; farmers fear a crisis

Express News Service
Bhopal, August 15

BARELY TWO weeks after a farmers' agitation over mooning procurement and fertiliser distribution forced the Madhya Pradesh government to suspend its newly introduced e-token system, the state has now halted the sale of subsidised fertilisers altogether.

The government has now ordered a statewide stock reconciliation exercise.

The Department of Farmers Welfare and Agriculture Development ordered all sales of subsidised fertilisers to be stopped from 7 pm on August 14 "until further orders", saying the actual physical stocks held by fertiliser sellers would have to be matched with the quantities recorded on the Centre's Integrated Fertilizer Management System (iFMS) portal.

The order, issued by department secretary Nishant Barwade on August 14 and sent to all district collectors, does not state how large the discrepancy between the digital and physical stocks is, where the discrepancies have been detected or how long the verification will take. It also does not announce a date for resumption of sales.

In unusually sweeping directions, the government has instructed that no subsidised fertiliser be sold during the closure period through the state's Marketing Federation sales centres, Primary Agricultural Credit Cooperative Societies, MP Agro sales centres, or private fertiliser sales centres," it says, directing the administration to "ensure" compliance.

The government's decision comes at a particularly sensitive point in the agricultural calendar. Kharif sowing has already taken place across much of the state and farmers require urea and other fertilisers at different



The move comes weeks after thousands of farmers marched from Narmadapuram to Bhopal in support of MSP for mooning crop. FILE

ent supply of fertilisers to farmers, the actual stock of fertilisers available with fertiliser sellers in the state is to be reconciled (matched) with the Government of India's iFMS portal," the orders say. "In view of this, fertiliser sales centres in the state are hereby ordered to remain closed from 7:00 PM on 14.08.2026 until further orders."

The order goes on to make clear that the exercise is not confined to one category of sellers. "During the period of closure of sales, no sale of subsidised fertilisers of any kind shall be made through the sales centres of the Marketing Federation, Primary Agricultural Credit Cooperative Societies, MP Agro sales centres, or private fertiliser sales centres," it says, directing the administration to "ensure" compliance.

The government's decision comes at a particularly sensitive point in the agricultural calendar. Kharif sowing has already taken place across much of the state and farmers require urea and other fertilisers at different

stages of crop growth. Paddy growers are among those particularly dependent on timely fertiliser applications. Bharatiya Kisan Sangh leader Rahul Doot told *The Indian Express* that the government's decision could leave farmers who have already exhausted their stocks exposed to serious crop losses. "Around 80 lakh farmers will be impacted. How will the stock exercise be done? Those who don't have fertilizer will be at risk. This is the first time such an order has been passed," Doot said.

The Congress party has threatened an agitation. Congress Madhya Pradesh president Jitu Patwari accused the Mohan Yadav government of worsening the fertiliser crisis in the state by halting subsidised fertiliser sales indefinitely in the name of stock verification.

"If the MP government does not lift this ban right away, the Congress will hit the streets in a fierce agitation for farmers' rights," Patwari said.

Memories of Partition from a railway station in Delhi



HISTORY HEADLINE

BY VIVEK SHUKLA

THE QUIET world of Lodhi Colony Railway Station sits far from the busy Lodhi Road. Silence hangs over the station. A deep sadness seems to be the permanent mood. One cannot help but wonder whether this melancholy comes from the cries it heard during Partition. The station witnessed thousands of Muslims saying goodbye forever to their homeland and their loved ones. From here, trains used to leave regularly for Lahore.

The family of the former Pakistani fast bowler and now well-known cricket commentator Sikander Bakht also took the train to Pakistan from Lodhi Colony Railway Station. His father, Jawan Bakht (referred to as J Bakht), lived in Karol Bagh and had studied at St Stephen's College for some time. The cricket world came to know Sikander Bakht when he took eight Indian wickets for sixty-nine runs in a test match at Feroz Shah Kotla stadium during the 1979-80 series. On that visit, he also went to Karol Bagh to see the old family house and touched its every wall. Sikander Bakht recalls that his family was not completely sure about shifting to Pakistan. There were differences of opinion. In the end, they decided to move. By then, riots had broken out in Delhi.

Trains between Delhi and Lahore began running from the second week of August 1947 and continued until 22 November 1947. From Lodhi Colony Railway Station, two or three trains would leave for Lahore every day. One departed at 7 am and another at 9 am. If a third train ran, it left by 12 noon. The tim-



ings were fixed so that the trains would reach Lahore in daylight. In those terrible days, trains were special targets for rioters.

Historian-professor Gyanendra Pandey explains that people going to Pakistan had to collect their tickets and other papers from a temporary office of the Pakistan government located in the L Block of Connaught Place. Pandey's research on Delhi confirms the existence of this 'Pakistan Transfer Office', which handled the movement of officials and property and, for a time, also became a gathering point for refugees.

The trains leaving were packed. Some passengers even sat on the roofs. Former Railway Board member Dr Ravindra Kumar says that after leaving Lodhi Colony Railway Station, the train reached New Delhi Railway Station within a few minutes. There, extra coaches were attached for government em-

Trains between Delhi and Lahore began running from the second week of August 1947 and continued until 22 November 1947

ployees who were also going to Pakistan. Most were with the railways. In the capital's largest railway colony at Kishanganj, nearly 25 per cent of the houses fell empty at the time. Dozens of Muslim railway workers, *khalasis*, linemen, guards and others, left for Pakistan. Several railway families from the Sabzi Mandi railway colony also migrated.

It is possible that the family of former Pakistani President Pervez Musharraf also crossed the border by train. His father, Syed Musharrafuddin, was a government servant and lived with his family on Minto Road. RP Puri, later the owner of the famous Central News Agency bookshop in Connaught Place, used to deliver newspapers to Syed Musharrafuddin's government quarters. On 14 August 1947, Pakistan appeared on the world map. One morning around that time, Syed Musharrafuddin was waiting for Puri. He

had news. After Puri had delivered the paper and started to ride away on his bicycle, Syed Sahib called him back. "Puri Bhai, we have had a very good relationship. From now on, please stop delivering the newspaper. We are leaving for Pakistan." Puri could hardly believe what he was hearing. Later, he opened Central News Agency. He used to say that the Musharraf family was highly educated.

Sajjad Muneer, a Pakistani international squash player who now lives in Toronto, Canada, recalls that in the third week of August 1947, his maternal grandfather, Khan Mohammad Tufail Mohammad, and his paternal grandfather, Allah Ditta, both civil engineers, left their respective homes. The families started living in the Purana Qila camp. Muslims going to Pakistan were housed in Purana Qila and Humayun's Tomb.

An eight-year-old Mamnoon Fatima was living in a flat on Babar Road near Bengali Market with her mother. The flat had been allotted to her father, Ghulam Sabir Kazmi, a government servant. Just before Partition, Kazmi had received a transfer order to Karachi and left, but the family was still in Delhi. Before they could also leave, riots had started to spread. Hindu neighbours on Babar Road hid the family in their prayer room to keep them safe. Mamnoon Fatima, who later became the sister-in-law of historian-professor Irfan Habib, would later tell her son, Hamza Farooq Habib, a well-known journalist with Pakistan's ARY News channel.

At Lodhi Colony Railway Station itself, senior Congress leaders such as Lala Deshbandhu Gupta, Mir Mushtaq Ahmed, Lala Roop Narayan, Chaudhary Brahm Prakash and Sarla Sharma stood with folded hands and begged the departing Muslims to change their minds and stay in India. After listening to them, some people at the station turned back and went home. Most, however, continued their journey.

The writer is Ex-Advisor (History), Indira Gandhi Centre for Arts and Culture

Kudos, cockroaches



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

ON INDIA'S eightieth birthday, all our political leaders need to hang their heads in shame. Or to use the inimitable Hindi expression, drown themselves in a handful of water. It should mortify them that it is young people who have come forward on this day that we celebrate Independence Day, to tell them what their priorities should be. These young people have reminded them, and us, that the money and time wasted on building a new parliament house and a new residence for the prime minister could have been better spent in repairing rural schools.

The Cockroach Janta Party has announced that this August 15, they will begin a campaign to repair rural schools. To make their case, they have spent the past week posting pictures of village schools on social media. In these pictures, we see classrooms with crumbling walls and bare floors. We also see school toilets so filthy that it is hard to believe that little children, and especially little girls, will be made to use these sickening hell-holes. The pictures surprised me not at all because I have seen schools exactly like these in states across India. But especially in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

In an odd coincidence, I was brooding over these things while gathering my thoughts for this column, when the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh popped up on my television to make an ugly, divisive, dangerous speech. Since Pakistan's Independence Day is now Partition Day in India, Yogi Adityanath thought it appropriate to remind young Indians about those trains that came from Pakistan filled with dead bodies. As if rehearsing for next year's election, he said that it was the Congress Party that was responsible for Partition and that if Narendra Modi had been prime minister, this would never have happened.

In making this speech, he accidentally revealed why, in 12 years of being the prime minister, Modi has failed to improve the appalling state of government schools or end corruption in national examinations. He and his chief ministers have been too busy doing other things like reminding young Indians about the horrors of the past in which the villains were always Muslims and the victims always Hindus. No country that wallows in the wounds of history ever succeeds in building a better future. Very sad that it has taken the cockroaches to remind us of this. So, kudos to you cockroaches.

Is there anything then that can be truly celebrated on India's eightieth birthday? When I asked my new best friend Claude this question, it trawled through its artificial intelligence and concluded that democracy and the peaceful transfer of power were some of the things to celebrate. Not needing to import foodgrain, as we once used to, is another thing we should celebrate, and the reduction in extreme poverty from 45% in 1990 to less than 15% today is also an achievement unless we compare this with our old enemy China. Until 1980, we were growing pretty much at the same rate, but the Chinese economy is five times India's now, and 800 million Chinese are out of poverty. Literacy is 97% compared to our 70%.

It is shameful that when we talk about 70% of our population being literate, we mean literally that. When average Indian children complete their education in a government school, they can count in a basic sort of way and read in a basic sort of way. That is all. This is why I agree totally with the Cockroach Janta Party's new campaign. Nothing is more important than fixing the serious defects in government schools. There are those who like to romanticise about how wonderful these schools were once and how they deteriorated since Modi became prime minister. This is not true. They were always schools only in name. But Modi can certainly be blamed for not getting his chief ministers to make changes on a war footing.

Every Independence Day the thing that saddens me most is the sight of small children, barefoot and in rags, standing at streetlights in Delhi and Mumbai selling limp, sodden national flags. Sometimes the children are so small that their hands barely reach the windows of passing cars and sometimes their clothes and flags are so soaked that they look as if they have spent hours in the rain. I always pay extra for the flags, hoping that if the money is not stolen by older children, the little ones will be able to celebrate India's birthday with a hot meal.

Every year I have waited for our political leaders to notice these desperately poor children and try and do something for them. It has never happened. This year the leader of the Cockroach Janta Party not only noticed them but declared angrily that these children should be in school, not on the streets. It warmed my heart to hear him say this, and although I am not in a celebratory mood on India's 80th birthday, I continue to hope that there will come an Independence Day when instead of empty patriotic slogans from our political leaders we will have younger leaders who know what India's priorities should really be.

What tops my list is the miserable state of our children. May an Independence Day come when on the streets of our cities we no longer see little children selling Indian flags just to make enough for a celebratory hot meal.

The writer is a researcher based in New Delhi

Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly 'She Said' column

Zhu's economic legacy is Xi's crisis to solve



ANUSHKA SAXENA

WHEN ZHU RONGJI became China's fifth premier in March 1998, he famously declared at his inaugural press conference, "Whether it is a minefield or an abyss that lies ahead, I will go forth without hesitation and serve with all my energy until my dying breath." With his passing on August 12, one cannot help but notice the similarities in his practice of demolition economics, and what China is both creating and experiencing today.

Firstly, what is interesting to note is that the obituary Xinhua released that evening — issued jointly by the Party Centre, the NPC Standing Committee, the State Council and the CPPCC — singled out three of his economic achievements. These are the 1994 tax-sharing fiscal system, the overhaul of the central bank and commercial banking, and the reorganisation of State-Owned Enterprises (SOEs). It then closed, as these documents have always done for the past decade, by urging party cadres to rally closely around the Party Centre with Xi Jinping at its core.

But beyond the unwavering politics of such events, each reform the obituary lists has now translated into an economic crisis for Beijing to handle. The 1994 fiscal reform is a classic example. It famously gave the centre greater control over finances, even as it left expenditure obligations with local governments. How local governments subsequently generated money has now translated into Beijing's most controversial bubble — through the property sector. But since its unravelling after the introduction of the "three red lines" policy in 2020 and Evergrande's loan default in 2021, the fissures have become all the more apparent. Real estate investment fell 17.2% in 2025, while fixed-asset investment fell by 3.8%, its first annual decline in decades, and Beijing has allocated a whopping 4.4 trillion yuan (over US\$ 610 billion) in local special-purpose bonds just this year to relieve local government debt stress, and, to some extent, stabilise the property market.

Then there is the 1990s reform co-authored by Zhu and Jiang Zemin — "grasp the large, release the small". It revolved around maintaining party control over large SOEs, while privatising or shutting down smaller ones. It made Zhu the architect of mass layoffs of roughly 30 million state workers, articulated at the time as 'Xiangang' (or 'stepping down from the post'). At the same time, it normalised massive CPC subsidy programmes for big SOEs, as well as mergers into major conglomerates.

But the rationale behind the policy reflects similar concerns in contemporary China. Partly, the policy aimed to grapple with excess capacity, and partly with deflation and bureaucratic inefficiency. Beijing is fighting the same enemies today, although the same toolkits and instincts as Zhu are no longer effective. Not only are the big players in these sectors private, "shutting them down" means destroying the investments of industrial policy.

The most consequential unravelling has happened in China's global economic image. Zhu's wrangling with the World Trade Organisation (WTO) granted China a global market big enough to absorb whatever the domestic market could not. And to this day, China remains an export-oriented economy. Even as Zhu's legacy has left indelible footprints on China's economic model, from Beijing's perspective, global market sentiment has worsened. And so, the economy Xi is managing today, with a target of 4.5-5% in 2026, is starkly different from the one that clawed back to 9% soon after the Asian Financial Crisis.

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Power of the name: Why 'Mecca' matters in new defence pact



RAHANA SHERIN K V

ON 7 AUGUST 2026, Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Türkiye signed a landmark defence agreement. On paper, the agreement is about hard-power realpolitik. Yet, instead of giving this pact an administrative or technical name, such as the Riyadh-Islamabad-Ankara Joint Defence Agreement, the signatories chose the title Mecca Joint Defence Agreement. The choice matters because Mecca holds a sacred place in the Muslim community as the birthplace of Prophet Muhammad, giving the agreement a meaning that goes beyond its military purpose.

So, why do governments spend time choosing highly symbolic titles for their treaties? The answer lies in how shared ideas and symbols shape our political world. A treaty title is not just a label. It is a deliberate "frame" designed to guide how the public, regional rivals, and the global community perceive a deal. By choosing a symbolic name, leaders can elevate a cold, transactional military deal to something sacred.

We have seen this before. Consider the 2020 Abraham Accords between Israel, the United Arab Emirates, and Bahrain. The agreements focused on issues such as trade,

Why do governments spend time choosing highly symbolic titles for their treaties? The answer lies in how shared ideas and symbols shape our political world

direct flights, and security cooperation. However, the choice of the name carried a broader symbolic meaning. In his keynote address at the Abraham Accords dinner in Abu Dhabi on October 20, 2020, the then-US Treasury Secretary Steven T Mnuchin explained that the accords were named after Abraham, a figure revered in Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. By invoking a figure shared by the three Abrahamic faiths, the name emphasised their common religious heritage. It therefore presented a strategic geopolitical realignment not only as a security and diplomatic arrangement, but also as a symbol of shared identity and interfaith reconciliation.

The 2026 Mecca Agreement offers a similar example, but through the symbolism of place rather than a shared religious figure. By invoking Mecca, a deeply respected sacred city and the spiritual heart of the Islamic world, the agreement draws upon an existing source of religious legitimacy.

For Saudi Arabia, hosting the pact in Mecca and associating it with the city's name offers an opportunity to reassert its regional leadership at a time when that position has come under pressure from questions over Riyadh's response to regional crises, and growing public criticism of its perceived re-

straint. By wrapping a hard-power military pact in the sacred symbolism of the holy city, Riyadh signals that the Saudi leadership is not just driven by its own national interests, but by a sacred duty to protect the spiritual core of the Muslim world.

For Pakistan and Turkey, the 'Mecca' frame serves as a powerful shield against domestic political pushback. For Pakistan, being part of a defence pact named after a holy city gives the agreement a stronger ideological meaning. By associating itself with Mecca, Pakistan can present its participation not simply as a strategic military alignment, but as part of a "holy alliance" rooted in the defence and solidarity of the Muslim world. In Turkey, the civilisational framing appeals directly to nationalist pride, presenting Turkish defence exports not as mere business transactions, but as a noble, protective alliance.

This strategy works because of a clever division between the symbolic frame and the legal text. By keeping the sacred name in the title and the strategic limits in the text, these three states can project a grand narrative of pan-Islamic solidarity to their domestic bases. Meanwhile, their actual legal liabilities remain strictly technical and limited.

Ultimately, the Mecca Agreement reminds us that names are active tools of statecraft. Long after the ink dries on the technical protocols, the name 'Mecca' is what will live on in the public mind.

The writer is a research scholar at the Academy of International Studies, Jamia Millia Islamia

Stop expecting women to be perfect victims

THERE IS a peculiar figure summoned repeatedly in sexual violence cases — the "perfect victim".

She should be frightened but not hysterical, traumatised but coherent, angry but not vindictive. She reports promptly, remembers everything, cuts off contact with the accused, and, at every turn, behaves in ways that confirm what institutions already believe a victim should look like. Real women, inconveniently, rarely oblige this crass imaginary.

The Tarun Tejpal case has once again brought this contradiction into sharp focus. In 2021, a Goa sessions court acquitted Tejpal, who had been accused of raping a young colleague in a hotel elevator in 2013. The judgment scrutinised the complainant's conduct before and after the alleged assault, including her messages and behaviour, and observed that she had not demonstrated "any kind of normative behaviour" that a victim of sexual assault might plausibly display. The court also reasoned that her messages showed she was neither "traumatised nor terrified".

On August 6, the Bombay High Court overturned that acquittal, convicted Tejpal

of rape and sentenced him to 10 years' rigorous imprisonment. In doing so, the court rejected the premise that a woman's credibility can be measured against a prescribed script of victimhood. But the "perfect victim" is not merely a legal problem. She is a social construction.

We have built a cultural grammar of sexual violence in which a "real" victim is expected to behave in recognisable ways. The problem is not only that these assumptions are nonsense. It is that they turn a woman's attempts to survive, process or make sense of violence into evidence against her. And women are angry about this.

In 2014, *Newslandry* published Nirupama Sekhri's 'Letter to Ms Tehelka-Assault-Victim', a piece so steeped in victim-blaming that it is difficult to read even now. Sekhri wrote that she did not see the complainant as a victim, questioned why she had not kicked or punched Tejpal, called her a "bubblegum feminist" and described the alleged assault as a "small occurrence" that had been turned into an "ultimate felony". What is enraging about that disgusting letter is not only its utter cruelty. It is the audacity of the demand it makes of the



SHE SAID
BY ANJALI CHAUHAN

woman, shamelessly so, to explain why you did not behave correctly while you were being violated.

We have heard these questions in too many rooms, directed at too many women, for too many years. In courts, in newsrooms, in universities, in workplaces, in families. They often arrive disguised as questions of fact. But underneath them is another scrutiny to find a victim whose behaviour makes the violence easy for us to chew and digest.

The perfect victim, after all, is part of a larger obsession with female perfectness. The perfect daughter knows when to be quiet. The perfect wife knows when to forgive. And the perfect victim knows how to suffer in ways that leave nobody uncomfortable. As hard as it might be for you to believe, we women are complex and messy humans, too. And there is no single psychology of trauma. Yet institutions and society at large, repeatedly, desperately, search for one.

That is the utmost cruelty at the heart of the perfect-victim demand. A woman is denied her humanity twice. First, through the violence itself and then through the endless interrogation of what she did, said,

drank, remembered, forgot, felt or failed to feel afterwards. The violence happens to her and, still, somehow, the burden of making sense of it is handed back to her.

And perhaps this is what should make us furious. We have spent years teaching women how to avoid violence, how to dress, where to go, when to leave, whom not to trust. When violence happens anyway, we again turn to them, teaching them something else now — how to explain themselves in a manner which is digestible. How to make their pain coherent. How to be believable. How to become the kind of woman whose suffering will not inconvenience anyone. Enough!

Women do not owe anyone the performance of devastation. They do not owe anyone the right reaction, the right memory, the right amount of anger, the right amount of fear. A just society would not ask a woman to first become a perfect victim before it is willing to confront the violence done to her.

The writer is a researcher based in New Delhi

Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly 'She Said' column



A Ukrainian HIMARS crew fires rockets at Russian positions, from the front lines in eastern Ukraine, on Saturday. REUTERS

Ukraine says drone strikes hit Russian airfield, rocket center

Reuters
Kyiv, August 15

UKRAINE SAID on Saturday its long-range strikes had hit a Russian military airfield and a rocket centre that Kyiv says supports Russia's nascent Starlink-style satellite internet network. President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Flamingo cruise missiles struck the rocket facility, about 900 km from Ukraine's border, as part of Kyiv's campaign to pressure Moscow to end more than four-year war by targeting sites deep inside Russia. "It is important that Russia's war potential be reduced. Peace is needed, and this must be evident in Russia – through concrete damage to specific facilities," he said in a post on X. He said the airfield hosted aircraft used to attack Ukraine. Ukraine's General Staff said direct hits were recorded at both the airfield in Russia's Nizhny Novgorod region and

the Progress rocket and space centre in Samara region. It said the strikes had sparked fires at both sites. The General Staff said the Samara plant produces rockets used to launch satellites for the Rassvet broadband network, which Russia is developing as an alternative to SpaceX's Starlink. Starlink operates in Ukraine, but not in Russia, and has given Kyiv a major advantage in drone operations and battlefield communications. There was no confirmation of the airfield strike from authorities in Nizhny Novgorod. In Samara region, local officials said air defences had repelled a "massive missile attack". "Samara's industrial infrastructure sustained localised damage," Ivan Noskov, head of the regional capital, said in an online post, without specifying which site was affected. Emergency services were working at the scene, he said.

Israeli strikes on South Lebanon kill 11, including three children



People and rescuers gather at the site of an Israeli airstrike in south Lebanon on Saturday. AP

Associated Press
Beirut, August 15

ISRAELI AIRSTRIKES on southern Lebanon killed at least 11 people Saturday, in the deadliest attacks since a truce between Israel and Hezbollah went into effect on June 20. Lebanon's Health Ministry and state news agency said an airstrike that targeted a home on the edge of the village of Ansar killed seven people, including three children, and wounded two. The second, on the village of Deir al-Zahrani, killed four and wounded 17. Israel and the Lebanese government announced a "framework agreement" on June 26, laying out a plan for Israeli forces to withdraw from southern Lebanon in exchange for the disarmament of the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group. It envisions steps toward an eventual peace agreement between the two countries – which remain technically at war nearly 80 years after Israel's establishment. Hezbollah has refused direct talks and wasn't party to the deal.

OIL TANKER TRAFFIC THROUGH HORMUZ HALTED

Iran defiant on Strait, Trump to Americans: Accept high oil prices

Paying more for oil is the cost of restraining Iran, says US President

Reuters
Dubai, Cairo, New York, August 15

IRAN CALLED on the US to accept defeat on Saturday, while President Donald Trump blasted Tehran as "very evil" and told Americans to prepare for continued high fuel prices as a result of the war. Progress towards peace talks and oil tanker traffic through the strategic Strait of Hormuz remained halted, with no sign the warring parties were moving toward ending the conflict that the US and Israel launched on February 28. "This strait will be opened and closed only under Iran's command, and so long as you do not accept the reality of defeat and stop indulging in fantasies, Iran will continue to enforce the blockade," Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi posted on X. Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said Iran had not decided to resume talks with the US. He told Iranian news outlet *Shahrara News* in an interview published on Saturday that Washington must meet condi-



President Donald Trump departs after speaking at the David Mack Center for Training and Intelligence, in New York on Friday. AP

tions on the strait in order for shipping to resume in the waterway that handled one-fifth of the world's oil before the war. Trump urged Americans to accept slightly higher gasoline prices while the conflict continues. He told a political rally in Garden City, New York, on Friday that paying "a tiny little bit more for your gasoline" is worth the cost of ensuring "a very evil country" could not have a nuclear weapon, one of his stated rationales for the war. "After we finish defeating Iran ... pretty soon I'll be declaring the Hormuz Strait a territory of the US," said Trump. Tehran, too, has stepped up its rhetoric in recent days as attempts to bring a permanent end to the war appear deadlocked. "The Strait of Hormuz cannot be seized by a tweet or an aircraft carrier, by issuing an

order or by delivering an election speech," Gharibabadi said. Despite Iran's defiant tone, though, there were also signs of an economic toll there. President Masoud Pezeshkian, in remarks on state television, blamed high inflation on a US blockade of Iranian ports and sanctions on Iran's oil exports. Trump and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent each pledged to inflict more financial damage on Iran. Tehran calls its enforcement of strait traffic a blockade – the term Washington uses for its threat against Iranian vessels leaving their ports. "What we're doing is a great service for the world, not only for ourselves ... and we're really doing a great job," Trump said. Only two vessels passed through the Strait Friday with no crude oil shipments visible, as per to ship-tracking firm Kpler.

5 hurt in shooting at Virginia state varsity; cops hunt multiple suspects

Associated Press
Virginia, August 15

FIVE PEOPLE were wounded in a shooting involving multiple suspects at Virginia State University early Saturday, prompting a campus lockdown and police investigation just as students get ready for a new school year. It happened near the university's Quad Annexes, where campus police and Chesterfield County officers discovered five people suffering from gunshot wounds outside campus dormitories. Officers responded just before 1:30 am and the lockdown was lifted at about 9 am, county police said. The shooting happened as Virginia State's academic year begins. According to university's website, residence halls opened for students a week ago, and classes resume Monday. Many students had just completed the university's "New Trojans Experience" for incoming students. Police and university officials have not identified any of the victims nor said if they are connected to the university. The five were transported to hospitals, and one initially listed as having life-threatening injuries has been upgraded to critical condition, county police said. The university said in a statement that the shooting involves "multiple suspects." The statement asked people to avoid the area on Saturday morning.

47 killed as 7.7 magnitude quake strikes off Indonesia

Reuters
Jakarta, August 15

AT LEAST 47 people were killed after a magnitude 7.7 earthquake and dozens of aftershocks struck off eastern Indonesia on Saturday, the National Disaster Mitigation Agency (BNPB) said in its latest statement. Rescue teams have yet to reach Nagekeo, the region closest to the epicentre, after landslides blocked roads and disrupted communications, officials said. "The quake was massive, the shock was so strong," said Nona, a 51-year-old resident of Talibura, a village in East Nusa Tenggara. "There were 13 of us inside the house and we all ran to save ourselves." Tsunami waves of less than 1 metre (3 feet) were recorded in

Two Earthquakes Strike in Quick Succession



several areas of the Southeast Asian nation after the early-morning quake. Authorities lifted a tsunami warning about three hours later. Earlier, rescuers in port town of Maumere found 20 dead, six injured and two people trapped under rubble, said Fathur Rah-

man, head of the city's rescue agency. Maumere is the main town in Sikka Regency on Flores Island in eastern Indonesia. Suharyanto, head of BNPB, earlier said residents remained trapped in several buildings across the affected area, while there were reports of landslides

blocking a number of roads. Teams have yet to reach Nagekeo and mobile communications in the region were affected, Fathur told Reuters earlier. Attempts to reach the area by road were thwarted by landslides, while another team was trying to reach it by ferry, he said.

6.4-magnitude earthquake hits North Sumatra

Jakarta: A magnitude 6.4 earthquake struck Indonesia's North Sumatra province on Saturday, but there was no tsunami threat and no immediate reports of aftershocks and damages, the country's meteorology agency BMKG said. The quake occurred at a depth of 168 kilometres with its epicentre located about 11 km southeast of Simalungun, according to agency's statement. BMKG said the quake was felt in Tebing Tinggi, Kabanjahe and Limapuluh areas. REUTERS

Hungary to sink two barges in Danube to ensure n-plant cooling

Budapest: Hungarian authorities will sink two barges in the Danube Saturday to raise water level at the Paks nuclear plant to avert a shutdown of one of its last two remaining turbines, as water levels are dropping, Prime Minister Peter Magyar said. The plant currently operates at around 25% of its capacity due to a historic drought and record low water levels on the Danube river, from which the nuclear plant draws its coolant. Magyar said that current forecasts indicated the water level would drop to the critical

level at which point one of the two operating turbines would have to be shut down. "The Danube is receding...The controlled sinking of the barges will begin shortly," he said. Hungary's government said on Wednesday that it would build a riverbed "sill", a submerged, dam-like structure built crosswise on the bottom of a river channel, to manage water flow. That will take weeks. It also said two 260-foot barges would be submerged near the nuclear plant to raise the water level. REUTERS

Xi calls for stronger disaster response as floods and landslides batter China

Reuters
Beijing, August 15

CHINESE PRESIDENT Xi Jinping called for improving the country's ability to prevent, mitigate and respond to natural disasters, after a string of deadly floods and landslides. Xi's remarks, published on Saturday in Qiushi, a journal central to Communist Party messaging, follow China's strongest typhoon this year and a series of landslides that killed dozens, underscoring growing

toll of extreme weather on the world's second-largest economy. "As global warming continues, extreme weather events and disasters such as torrential rains, floods, typhoons, and droughts are increasing significantly, exacerbating their destructive impact," Xi said, according to the article. Xi urged a shift towards pre-disaster prevention, stronger monitoring and early-warning systems, and efforts to close gaps in flood-control and drainage infrastructure in northern China,

the article said. His remarks were drawn from a speech delivered at a Politburo study session on April 28. China's strongest typhoon this year battered the capital with bouts of intense rain that flooded key roads and stranded vehicles, while lashing wide swathes of the country. China will "continuously improve our ability and level of prevention and response to various natural disasters, and effectively safeguard the lives and property of people," Xi said.

● AZAD, A POPULAR ONLINE DEBATE PROGRAMME, HAS TACKLED TOPICS THAT PUSH THE LIMITS OF TEHRAN'S AUTHORITARIAN SYSTEM AS SOME QUESTION HOW IT HAS REMAINED ON AIR

‘Court of ideas’: The Iranian YouTube show posing questions few dare ask

Yeganeh Torbati
August 15

WHEN THE conservative American commentator Tucker Carlson sat down last year for a buzzy interview with Iran's president, Masoud Pezeshkian, unlikely encounter would most likely never have happened without the involvement of a tiny, independent Iranian outlet. Mahdi Ahmadi, the founder of Azad, a six-person team that hosts debates in Tehran and publishes them on YouTube, pitched Carlson on the idea, he said, and then connected him with the president's team. This mediating role is a tightrope that Ahmadi and his team

have become adept at walking over the past few years. Their YouTube channel has aired views that are deeply critical of Iran's government, alongside those of people close to the authorities, attracting a large and growing online audience, as well as scrutiny and criticism. Carlson did not respond to a request for comment for this article, but his channel did thank Ahmadi for his help at the end of the Pezeshkian interview. Ahmadi, 35, said in an interview with *The New York Times* that he saw Azad's role as sitting between two opposing sides and creating a chance for mutual understanding – and allowing viewers to judge each side's ar-

guments for themselves. "We believe that, for future of Iranian society, this is essential," he said. Crucial to Azad's approach is Ahmadi's studious impartiality as a moderator. He has described the channel as a neutral "court of ideas" where viewers could be exposed to, and assess, ideologically diverse set of perspectives. This year, Azad hosted a debate in which one scholar advocated an end to Iran's Islamic government via a constitutional referendum. Another went further – arguing for the return of the country's exiled monarchy. Weeks earlier, Iranian security forces had killed thousands



Mahdi Ahmadi (second from left), the founder of Azad, speaking with guests during popular debate series. NYT

of antigovernment protesters, some of whom were calling for the return of the former crown prince, Reza Pahlavi.

Critics of the channel question how Azad has been allowed to continue working inside Iran, given the censorship and con-

trol that the state exerts over the media. Many assert that it must have protection from a powerful patron, which Ahmadi denies. For the Iranian government, having a programme like Azad inside Iran presents some benefits. State television, which has a monopoly on domestic airwaves, is controlled by hardliners, and millions of Iranians instead get their news and entertainment from overseas Persian-language outlets, which can be stridently antigovernment. By allowing some discourse within Iran, the government can attempt to dilute the influence of diaspora outlets while it also tries to shape those

● BRIEFLY

POLAND

Europe's tallest statue of the Virgin Mary inaugurated in Polish village



The statue of Virgin Mary during inauguration in Konotopie, Poland. AP

AN ENORMOUS statue of the Virgin Mary that is believed to be Europe's tallest was inaugurated on Saturday in a small Polish village. Hundreds of people took part in the consecration of the monument, which towers 55.6 meters (182 feet) over Konotopie in central Poland, the home of fewer than 150 people. The Polish statue is taller – if less dramatically located – than the Christ the Redeemer statue in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, which measures some 38 meters (125 feet).

EUROPEAN UNION

EU sends aircraft as Belgium fights record wildfire

THE EUROPEAN Union deployed three helicopters and two water bomber aircraft to tackle a wildfire raging in eastern Belgium on Saturday after Belgium requested emergency reinforcements to control its biggest blaze in decades. The wildfire in the High Fens, Belgium's largest nature reserve, has been burning since Friday. REUTERS

UNITED STATES

Man found dead after shooting five in Michigan

A MAN suspected of shooting and killing five people in northern Michigan on Friday was found dead after a man-hunt, Michigan State Police said in a statement on social media. Troopers were dispatched around 11:40 am to a home in Michigan, after a report of a shooting. Officers found three people dead and a fourth person wounded, the state police said. REUTERS

● NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

Five teens killed after speeding car loses control

FIVE TEENAGERS were killed on Saturday after a car, reportedly involved in a race, went out of control and crashed into a tree in Lahore, the capital city of Pakistan's Punjab province, police said. Three car passengers and two pedestrians were killed in the incident, while another was injured. PTI

NEPAL

Gandaki province legalises medical cannabis farming

THE PROVINCIAL government of Gandaki in Nepal has legalised farming and use of marijuana for medical use despite a national ban. The bill came into effect on August 3, and requires the farmers to get official permission from the provincial authority for the cultivation. PTI

Ex-Cambridge professor Jason Arday found dead amid plagiarism scandal

Reuters
August 15

JASON ARDAY, a former University of Cambridge professor who was at centre of a plagiarism scandal, has died aged 41. Arday had resigned earlier this month as a professor of sociology of education following the accusations, which caused a furor in the world of academia. He was the university's youngest ever Black professor.

He was found unresponsive by the ambulance service at a property in Battersea, south London. "Sadly, a 41-year-old man was pronounced dead at the scene. His next-of-kin have been informed and are being supported by officers," the Metropolitan Police said. "At this time his death is being treated as unexpected, but is not believed to be suspicious. The case is being probed by officers from Met's Central South Command Unit," police said. The University of Cambridge announced an investigation earlier this week into the circumstances of Arday's appointment



Jason Arday

to the Faculty of Education in 2022 and his time there since. A high-profile professor who appeared frequently in the media, Arday faced accusations this year that parts of his 2015 PhD thesis were plagiarised, which he denied. The allegations expanded to include apparent inconsistencies in Arday's other academic work, and questions over his claims about his career, personal life and medical conditions. "We are desperately saddened to hear this tragic news. Our heartfelt sympathies go to Jason Arday's family and friends at this incredibly difficult time," Cambridge's Vice-Chancellor Deborah Prentice said.

PM MODI ASKS INDIAN COMPANIES TO ASPIRE TO BE COUNTED AMONG THE LARGEST IN THE WORLD

PM puts self-reliance, energy, tech at centre of Viksit Bharat push

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 15

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Saturday underscored the need for self-reliance, particularly in sectors like energy, semiconductors, and critical minerals, to avoid being vulnerable to the “weaponisation” of resources and even territory by some countries.

PM Modi also called for accelerating the pace of reforms to make India a developed country by 2047. The roadmap he laid out centred around energy security, advanced technology, semiconductors, manufacturing, and exports.

The PM identified energy security as the “need of the hour”, emphasising that a world powered by chips, artificial intelligence (AI), and data centres requires massive and reliable energy supply.

He also asked Indian companies to aspire to be counted among the largest in the world, and micro, medium, and small enterprises to make greater use of the market access provided by various free-trade agreements to reach global markets.

Modi also outlined a seven-point growth framework for the next five-seven years, with focus on manufacturing, agriculture and food production, technology and innovation, infrastructure and connectivity, defence, green and blue economy, and India’s soft power.

Self-reliance, with a focus on domestic manufacturing and production to cut import-dependence, has been an enduring theme for the Modi government as the world went

through multiple crises — like the Covid, Russia-Ukraine war, global trade tensions, and the West Asia conflict — that adversely impacted global trade and supply chains.

Modi said that while there may be many things available in the world that are cheaper, relying on imports doesn’t help build India’s own capabilities. He also said that over the last decade, it seems as if the world has stopped talking about globalisation altogether.

“The voices of globalisation...cannot be heard. Every nation has turned its focus to addressing its own challenges. However, regrettably, during this period of crisis, some have engaged in the game of weaponising resources to assert their dominance...Resources such as petrol, diesel, fertilisers, medicines, and technology chips are being weaponised; indeed, even territory itself is being weaponised,” he said.

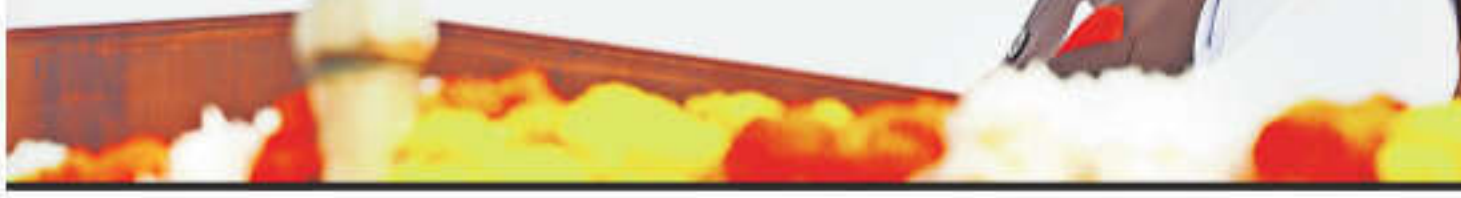
Although Modi didn’t name any country, his comments appeared indicative of the US-Israel conflict with Iran, which has stifled merchant vessel movements through the Strait of Hormuz.

The trade artery is important for India, as about 40% of its oil imports, over 50% of its natural gas imports, and 90% of its liquefied petroleum gas imports came through it. India depends on the waterway to receive significant volumes of some other commodities also.

Talking about the need for energy security, Modi said, “It is now difficult to run the new world without energy, and therefore, whether it is chips, AI

CHARTING PATH FOR SELF-RELIANCE

- PM Modi outlined a seven-point growth framework for the next five-seven years, with focus on manufacturing, agriculture and food production, technology and innovation, infrastructure and connectivity, defence, green and blue economy
- He said that while there may be many things available in the world that are cheaper, relying on imports doesn’t help build India’s own capabilities. Over the last decade, it seems as if the world has stopped talking about globalisation altogether, the PM said
- On self-reliance in semiconductors space, PM Modi said that three major semiconductor plants have already been started. And that production from these facilities has already begun to be exported... Over the coming seven to eight years, another five, seven, or even eight semiconductor plants are expected to begin operations



or data centres, we will need electricity in very large quantities. Energy security is the need of the hour, and therefore, we have already taken a series of strong steps in this direction. One major means of ensuring energy security is nuclear energy. By passing the SHANTI Act in Parliament, we have paved the way towards a new goal.”

He also said that India is now focussed on offshore oil and gas exploration, after opening up 99% of its coastline — previously designated as “no-go” areas — to upstream activities. India depends on imports to meet over 88% of its oil requirement and half of its natural gas needs.

On self-reliance in semiconductors space, PM Modi said that in today’s digital world and technology-driven era, the chip’s importance is clear.

“Whether it is electronic goods, medical equipment, or transportation systems, chips are indispensable everywhere. The world has reached a point where the entire system could come to a standstill without chips,” he said.

“Three major semiconductor plants have already been started. I have been informed that production from these facilities has already begun to be exported...over the coming seven to eight years, another five, seven, or even eight semiconductor plants are expected to begin operations,” PM Modi added. As the entire technology sector is dependent on critical minerals, India is working to secure itself in this area too, Modi said, listing measures and initiatives taken on critical minerals in recent years, including pacts with several countries. According to him, India must become

a global innovation hub in the age of AI, quantum technology, space, robotics and data centres, and not merely be a market for the world. The Prime Minister said that India has already demonstrated its capabilities through UPI and digital public infrastructure, and should now take its public technologies “to every corner of the world”.

He said that India needs to develop deeper manufacturing capabilities and capture the entire value chain. From design to manufacturing, India must emerge as a trusted hub in the global supply chain by meeting global standards on cost, quality, and scale. “Our identity in the global market should be based on credibility and quality. No compromise regarding quality and hence our mantra should be quality, quality, quality,” he said.

Govt seeks to ease entry norms for domestic consulting firms in tenders

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, August 15

IN A measure that paves the way for domestic consultancies to be on an equal footing with multinational consulting firms, the Department of Expenditure has issued an advisory to all central government departments and ministries for easing eligibility criteria in government consultancy tenders.

The department, which comes under the Ministry of Finance, has issued the advisory against prescribing high turnover requirements, higher weightage to consulting firm’s experience and minimum staff strength on the payroll of the bidder as criteria for consultancy tenders.

A sample study of consultancy procurement tenders floated by central government procuring entities on GeM (Government e-Marketplace) — a digital platform for procurement of goods & services by central/state ministries/departments and public sector units — in the last three financial years revealed issues with the eligibility and qualification criteria for consultancy

tenders, it said. In an office memorandum dated July 22, it listed three key issues: comparatively high turnover requirements, higher weightage to the consulting firm’s experience than to the qualifications and experience of the proposed key personnel, and minimum staff strength on the payroll of the bidder, far exceeding the actual manpower required for the project.

“The above findings indicate that such eligibility and qualification criteria may unduly restrict competition in the procurement of consultancy services,” it said.

Additionally, the department said the minimum staff strength requirement should align with the necessary manpower needed to execute the consultancy assignment, as “disproportionately high staff strength requirements, without adequate justification, may unnecessarily restrict competition”.

The multinational consulting firms, primarily the Big Four, have played a major role in consulting government departments. *The Indian Express* had reported in January 2024

that 44 central departments hired 1,499 consultants from external agencies, including the Big Four i.e., Ernst & Young, PwC, Deloitte and KPMG, incurring an annual expenditure of Rs 302 crore.

This office memorandum is a pivotal, pro-competition reform in the way the Government of India engages with advisors, said Suraj Nangia, Founder and Head, Government & Public Sector Advisory, Nangia Global.

“For years, government tenders had conditions such as high turnover multiples, rigid staff strength requirements and an excessive focus on firm level credentials, tilting the field towards only the largest players...for home-grown Indian firms, this is more than a procedural change; it is a strategic opening.

“When turnover thresholds are reasonable, staff requirements are linked to real manpower needs of the project, and shortlisting focuses on relevant experience and genuine financial capability, specialised Indian firms can qualify and compete for complex mandates on merit,” he said.

100 GWe NUCLEAR ENERGY TARGET

Why India needs more power for AI, chips and data centres

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 15

Small modular reactor push

INDIA IS betting on nuclear power to meet the rapidly rising electricity demand from emerging sectors such as semiconductors, artificial intelligence (AI) and data centres, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi setting a target of commissioning five new nuclear reactors in the current decade and expanding nuclear capacity to 100 gigawatt-electric (GWe) by 2047.

In his Independence Day address, Modi said the growing adoption of future technologies would drive a sharp increase in electricity demand.

“It will be difficult to run this new world without energy, and therefore, whether it is chips, AI or data centres, we will need very large amounts of electricity,” he said.

“We are working towards a target of 100 GWe of nuclear power by 2047. In this decade itself, we have set a target of commissioning five new nuclear reactors,” he added.

The Parliament passed the SHANTI Act last year, paving the way for wider private participation in India’s tightly regulated civil nuclear power sector and drawing interest from global nuclear technology suppliers from Russia, the US and France.

On Friday, the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE) also released the draft rules under the Act, laying out the regulatory framework for a broader nuclear power ecosystem, including private participation, captive generation, licensing, safety oversight and nuclear liability. But can the government achieve this ambitious target? Where does India’s nuclear power sector stand today, and how has the country’s civil nuclear programme evolved?

As the Centre targets expanding India’s nuclear energy capacity to 100 GWe by 2047, the government is pursuing a two-pronged approach: the deployment of large-capacity reactors as well as the use of small modular reactors (SMRs) to ensure faster deployment of units.

Even though India’s indigenous pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWR) will continue to form the backbone of the country’s nuclear expansion plans, SMRs are increasingly viewed as a promising technology that could help in industrial decarbonisation. These are also seen as important in offering baseload power that could give grid operators a degree of flexibility, especially given the imperative of inducting large-scale

renewables into the grid that comes with the challenge of ramping up base-load generation to balance out the vagaries of renewable power output.

While thermal generation is seen as important in this regard, nuclear energy offers a more carbon-neutral baseload generation option.

SMRs are also becoming the focal point in India’s international outreach for nuclear collaborations, with the high project costs of large light water reactors (LWRs) triggering questions about the feasibility of their large-scale deployment in the country. In May, a high-level American nuclear delegation was informed during meetings with top government functionaries about India’s goals to progressively enter the manufacturing value chain of SMRs.

It is learnt that India is actively seeking foreign expertise and investment to support the development of a domestic SMR ecosystem. For now, any foreign collaboration is likely to be centred on SMRs rather than

large conventional reactors due to cost concerns linked to LWRs.

Five indigenous SMRs by 2033

On the domestic front, India is pursuing an indigenous small reactor programme, with three types of SMR being designed and developed by the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre for demonstration: the 200 megawatt-electric (MWe) Bharat Small Modular Reactor (BSMR-200), a 55 MWe small modular reactor (SMR), and a 5 megawatt-thermal (MWt) high-temperature gas-cooled reactor for hydrogen production by coupling with a suitable thermochemical process for hydrogen production. The government has set a target of having at least five indigenously designed and operational SMRs by 2033.

India has announced the Nuclear Energy Mission to research, design, development, and deployment of SMRs with a total budgetary outlay of Rs 20,000 crore. Meanwhile, the government is also conducting studies to repurpose old thermal power plant sites for nuclear sites. Such repurposed sites may ultimately be more suitable for SMRs and smaller-capacity nuclear projects rather than large conventional reactors, an official familiar with the development had earlier told *The Indian Express*.

On the large-reactor front, India currently has 25 operational nuclear reactors totalling 8.7 GWe of capacity, with 10 reactors — with around 8 GWe of capacity — under construction. Another 10 units — with some 6.6 GWe of capacity — are in the pre-project stage. India has already developed and mastered indigenous PHWR technology and is following a three-stage nuclear power programme aimed at achieving long-term fuel self-reliance.

FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Data centres top segment in real estate investments by PEs: Report

Sakhi Trehan
New Delhi, August 15

DATA CENTRES have emerged as a key destination for private equity (PE) investors channeling their funds into the real estate sector, with inflows for the sector garnering over one-third of the total investment pie in the April-June quarter.

PE investment inflows in India’s real estate sector rose 25% year-on-year (y-o-y) to \$2 billion in this quarter, of which data centres received a 38% share — surpassing the traditional front-runner segment of office-led investments, as per a report released in July by the global real estate consulting firm Savills India.

Overall, PE investments in India’s real estate sector recorded a 33% surge to \$3.2 billion in the first half (H1) of the calendar year 2026, the report stated. The increased demand for digital infrastructure has resulted in a change in the prefer-

ences of investors, who are now expanding beyond office assets to invest in spaces that could yield better returns.

The rise in investment in data centres was also seen last year, with investments in India’s data centres rising 27% y-o-y to \$0.48 billion in 2025, according to real estate services and investment firm CBRE’s Real Estate Investment Market Outlook released in March 2026.

Growth in data centres

With a sharp increase seen in data centre capacity additions in India, investors are eyeing the emerging space for investments in this sector. According to the Savills report, 69% of foreign-based investments were directed solely into data centres and the hospitality segment during H1 2026.

A data centre — a physical facility that houses IT infrastructure and stores data in servers — is seeing growing demand, with another fresh wave

owing to AI and use across multiple sectors such as streaming, cloud computing, digital payments, and e-commerce. New data centre capacity additions in India rose 59.3% on year to 258 MW IT (stands for megawatt IT, which refers to the maximum amount of electricity available to run server equipment inside a data centre) in H1 2026 from 162 MW IT in H1 2025, taking the country’s total operational stock to 1.8 GW IT, as per Savills India data.

This growth momentum is expected to continue through the rest of 2026. The CBRE report said that around 500 MW of new data centre capacity is expected to be added in India during 2026, whereas the country’s total operational data centre stock (total installed operational capacity) is projected to grow by around 30% this year, supported by an estimated 500 MW of new capacity additions. *(The writer is an intern with The Indian Express)*

IT CEMENTS THE IDEA THAT THE US WILL SEEK A CLAUSE IN THE UPCOMING TRADE DEAL THAT COMMITS INDIA TO TAKE ACTION ON TRANSHIPMENT

How US is building a case for ‘transhipment’ crackdown & why India may be at risk

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, August 15

AFTER SIGNIFICANTLY reducing its direct dependency on Chinese products, the Trump administration, in a report titled “The Great Transhipment Scam: Global Evasion and Economic Costs” on Friday, said that more than 40 countries, including India, are part of a ‘shadow transhipment network’ designed to hide the true economic origin of goods produced in China.

The White House, as per the report, categorised the ‘shadow network’ into three tiers, with countries such as India, Mexico, Canada, and the European Union forming tier 1 where illegal transhipment risk is “embedded” within massive legitimate trade flows.

While “closely integrated” countries with China such as Vietnam, Malaysia, and Thailand were categorised as tier 2,

smaller economies such as Cambodia, Panama, and the UAE with “weak customs enforcement” were classified as tier 3. “On that strict standard, the Department of Commerce’s Office of Trade and Economic Analysis (OTEA) estimates that approximately \$67 billion in US-bound goods were transhipped from China through the top hubs—Mexico, India, and Vietnam—in 2025, producing an estimated \$28 billion in lost tariff revenue,” the White House report said.

The report claimed that tariff revenue is the most obvious loss from illegal transhipment and that when China-linked goods enter the US through third countries, they widen the effective trade deficit, displace domestic production, reduce GDP growth, and lower associated federal tax receipts. Calling for stronger curbs and Congressional action, the report said that current stan-

dards for determining country of origin are complex and cumbersome, and the rules are made from components manufactured in multiple countries.

Groundwork for new curbs

International trade experts said that the Trump administration could be laying the groundwork for another set of curbs through the Congressional route after reciprocal tariffs were deemed illegal by the US Supreme Court in February last year. Trade lawyers also said India being categorised in the first tier could indicate that the US would push India to shift away from Chinese dependency under the trade agreement being negotiated.

“India’s categorisation in ‘tier-1’ transhipment network country is notable and indicative of two things at least. First, it cements the idea that the US will



What the US report claims

TARIFF REVENUE is the most obvious loss from ‘illegal transhipment’. When China-linked goods enter the US through third countries, they widen the effective trade deficit, displace domestic production, reduce GDP growth

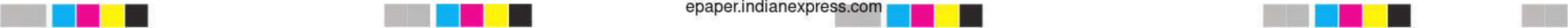
CURRENT STANDARDS for determining country-of-origin are complex and cumbersome, and the rules are made from components manufactured in multiple countries. And it calls for stronger curbs and Congressional action

seek a clause in the upcoming trade deal that commits India to take action on transhipment

and other practices that help exporters evade US tariffs. Second, it suggests that imports of cer-

FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM



BRIDGE

One of the ways of reducing the losers is to make the defenders' winners crash on the same trick. Have an "Honourable Settlement" as it were. This is exactly what you need in succeeding in your part score contract in last week's problem.

Dealer: West Vulnerable: East/West

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ J10 9 5		♠ 8 6 3 2	
♥ A 6		♥ 9 7	
♦ A 8 6 2		♦ 7 4 3	
♣ A K J		♣ Q 7 4 2	
SOUTH		NORTH	
-	1♥	dbl	2♥
pass	pass	dbl	pass
2♠	pass	pass	pass

West leads the king of hearts. Plan the play. The way to succeed is to crash the trumps for the defenders. South has six losing tricks in sight: three spades, two diamonds and one heart. The only chance to land the contract is to find the clubs divided three-three, with one of the opponents holding two trump honours doubleton. Declarer should win the opening lead, cash three club tricks ending with the lead in the closed hand, then lead a fourth club and discard the losing heart from dummy.

THE NORTH HAND: ♠AQ ♥KQJ42 ♦QJ9 ♣85
THE SOUTH HAND: ♠K74 ♥10853 ♦K105 ♣963

As the cards lie, this line of play eliminates the losing heart trick, while the opponents can still win only three spade tricks. If East trumps the fourth club lead with an honor, the defenders have only two more trump tricks; and if West trumps the fourth club lead with a low trump, South can hold subsequent spade losers to two tricks by crashing the trumps -leading them twice and forcing the opponents to play two top honours on one trick. What a nice and "honourable" settlement for the declarer! Your problem for the week: Dealer: North Vulnerable: None

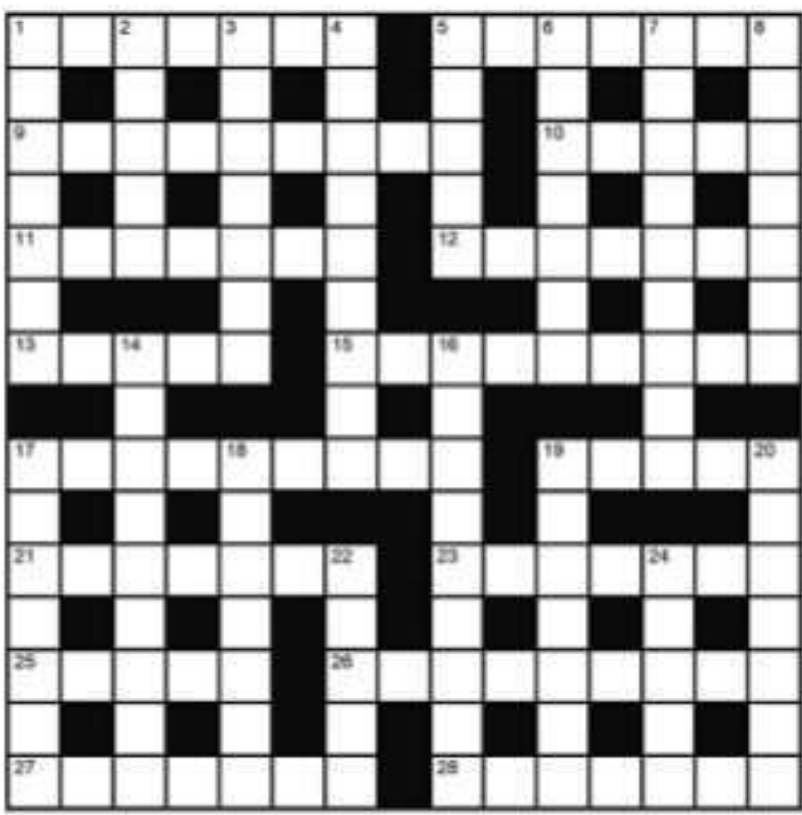
NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ A 4 3		♠ K Q J 8	
♥ 10 3 2		♥ A K 8 5 4	
♦ 8 7 4 2		♦ A 6 5	
♣ A 8 2		♣ 5	
SOUTH		NORTH	
—	—	pass	pass
1♥	pass	1NT	pass
2♠	pass	4♥	pass
pass	pass	—	—

West leads the queen of clubs. Plan the play.

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

- QUICK CLUES ACROSS**
- 1. Fall like a waterfall ? (7)
 - 5. Gatekeeper (7)
 - 9. Cross-shaped (9)
 - 10. To put it briefly (2,3)
 - 11. Not at any place (7)
 - 12. Ice cream (7)
 - 13. Pulled along (5)
 - 15. Owning up or confessing (9)
 - 17. German city (9)
 - 19. Caribbean republic (5)
 - 21. Mr Kipling (7)
 - 23. Yearbooks (7)
 - 25. Novelist Brookner (5)
 - 26. 2024, 2028, etc (4,5)
 - 27. Never growing old (7)
 - 28. Speak to (7)

- DOWN**
- 1. Kind of palm tree (7)
 - 2. Red Indian's woman or lady (5)
 - 3. Liquorice flavour (7)
 - 4. Clear of blame (9)
 - 5. Depressed state of mind (5)
 - 6. A tube through which ova travels from an ovary (7)
 - 7. Italian dictator (9)
 - 8. Stupefying (7)
 - 14. Global (9)
 - 16. Shillong's state (9)
 - 17. Indian river - "and a mar" anagram ? (7)
 - 18. Capital of Eswatini (7)
 - 19. Pleasing to the ear



- (7) 20. Demands or maintains emphatically (7)
- 22. Blunts (5)
- 24. Cognisant (5)

- CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS**
- 1. Cook a bit for Rob to pour into the bucket (7)
 - 5. Happens to change the bed site (7)
 - 9. Doesn't her work need to be condensed? (9)
 - 10. A green and mountainous part of France (5)
 - 11. Youngster in uniform seen to devour mostly sugar? (4,3)
 - 12. Trip and fall after a

SOLUTIONS TO 2594 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 1 Clobber, 5 Noisier, 8 Patsy, 9 Postulate, 11 Overstatement, 13 Show up, 16 Egoistic, 18 Befogged, 19 Petrol, 24 Equestrianism, 26 Ahmedabad, 27 Dabba, 28 Artiste, 29 Endowed **DOWN:** 1 Copious, 2 On the go, 3 Boyds, 4 Repeat, 5 Nest eggs, 6 I can't, 7 Reeks, 10 Uterine, 12 Tito, 14 Heed, 15 Unglued, 17 Feasible, 20 Rainbow, 21 Lampard, 22 Bridge, 23 Ghana, 24 Emmet, 25 Added **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Peddler, 5 Scoffed, 8 A snip, 9 Brusquest, 11 Balance in hand, 13 Goring, 16 Test twin, 18 Deputies, 19 Iragis, 24 Short-changing, 26 Dividends, 27 Drear, 28 Rescued, 29 Raymond **DOWN:** 1 Peat-bog, 2 Dangler, 3 Le pen, 4 Ribbed, 5 Squander, 6 Fjeld, 7 Ditty, 10 Quarter, 12 Fifi, 14 Omer, 15 Net-cord, 17 Destined, 20 Quite so, 21 Sugared, 22 Chaser, 23 Cedar, 24 Saves, 25 Neddy

2595

cider's ordered (7)

- DOWN**
- 1. Mail conflict of the late 1940s, etc. (7)
 - 2. Frenchman posing as an artist with not so loud bird (5)
 - 3. Gemstone displayed without a twitch of an eye (7)
 - 4. Coastal resort - Chesil Bank (4,5)
 - 5. Predicts houses will lose their roofs (5)
 - 6. Capital cover for Roman soldiers (7)
 - 7. Swoops on seedy joint with old cars (4-5)
 - 8. Legume that boys barf is meant to be peeled (7)
 - 14. You can build on this brainless mob! (6,3)
 - 16. Fish fingers designed to protect crown jewels? (9)
 - 17. Not successful in bringing misfortune (7)
 - 18. Islam no problem in this empire (7)
 - 19. A roof may be tarred (7)
 - 20. English poet writes about head of Scottish queen (7)
 - 22. Indian ruler returns in an amazing way (5)
 - 24. Architectural order for icon I shattered (5)

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY AUGUST 16: This is a year of learning and teaching. Take time to renew your spiritual beliefs. Explore philosophies that give you a better self-awareness.

MONDAY AUGUST 17: This year you reap the benefits of your hard work. Expect power and leadership in your activities and relationships. It's a time for major decisions and accomplishments. Seize opportunities and act.

TUESDAY AUGUST 18: This is the last year of a nine-year cycle. Take inventory of your life. Let go of people, places and things that held you back. Do some internal and external housecleaning.

WEDNESDAY AUGUST 19: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes. Grab new opportunities and be ready to act. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future.

THURSDAY AUGUST 20: This is a slower paced year. Take time to rejuvenate your energies and your outlook. Focus on business and personal relationships.

FRIDAY AUGUST 21: This is the perfect year to kick back and relax. Enjoy socializing and relating to others. Let your guard down. Old friends might reappear to rekindle relationships.

SATURDAY AUGUST 22: This is a year of creating structures, both internally and externally. Simplicity is key. Explore martial arts or yoga. Physical exercise plays an important role.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD

♈ ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today is a mixed bag. For the most part, it's romantic, friendly and congenial. It's a great time to socialise and enjoy playful activities with kids. This Week: A playful time. Be patient at home.

♉ TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Work colleagues will be supportive today. However, for those of you who are not working, this is a great day to relax at home and do minor repairs. Focus on the glass half-full today instead of half-empty. This Week: Home and family are favoured.

♊ GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a laid-back, feel-good, romantic day. Kick back and relax. You'll also enjoy socialising, short trips, visits with siblings and relatives, as well as sports events and kids' activities. This Week: Fast pace. Learn new things and socialise.

♋ CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Be courteous when dealing with authority figures today, because tension might arise. Some of you will enjoy shopping for beautiful things today. This Week: Redecorate and entertain at home.

♌ LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Enjoy relaxing behind the scenes today. You might see ways to boost your income. You also might spend money on beautiful things. Some of you might be involved with competitive sports and athletic events.

♍ VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): It's all too easy to jump to conclusions. Have you considered the possibility that you have got someone all wrong? It may be that you have interpreted a partner's behaviour more in line with what you would like to be the case, rather than in terms. This Week: Enjoy privacy and competitive sports.

♎ LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today the Moon is lined up with Venus in your sign. You will radiate warmth and friendliness to others. It's a wonderful day to socialise. This Week: Shop for wardrobe items.

♏ SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Even though you make an excellent impression on others today, you might choose to hide behind the scenes and relax somewhere in private. Some will dabble in secret love affairs. This Week: Explore opportunities in medicine, the law, publishing and travel.

♐ SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): If you can travel or do something different to change your routine, this will please you. For some of you, a platonic friendship could turn romantic. This Week: Expand your horizons.

♑ CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): In one way, it's an excellent day for financial discussions about how to share something. This is also a passionate, romantic day. Nevertheless, relations with authority figures might be strained. This Week: Discussions about shared property. Patience with partners and friends. You're admired.

♒ AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Steer clear of controversial subjects; the news might bring you down. Sometimes it's good to take a news fast for your mental health. Do something different today. Romantic relationships are blessed. This Week: You're keen to work and travel.

♓ PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Although this is the perfect day to relax and enjoy the company of loved ones, some of you are energetic and might try to get some work done. Don't push yourself too hard. This Week: A work hard/party hard week.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

A national debt, if it is not ____, will be to us a national blessing - Alexander Hamilton (9)

PTEEE

ACDSS

RRSUCI

CENOVX

ANSWER: A national debt, if it is not excessive, will be to us a national blessing - Alexander Hamilton

SOLUTIONS: Teppe, Scads, Cirrus, Convex

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6412

	2							
9	8		7					
1			5	9				
		6		3			5	
	9		2	1		3		
8		9			7			
			1	2			8	
				3			6	4
						5		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6411

2	1	4	5	9	8	7	6	3
7	3	9	6	1	4	8	5	2
5	6	8	2	7	3	9	4	1
9	7	1	3	5	2	6	8	4
4	8	5	1	6	9	3	2	7
6	2	3	4	8	7	5	1	9
1	4	6	7	3	5	2	9	8
8	5	7	9	2	1	4	3	6
3	9	2	8	4	6	1	7	5

Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Ltd.

Notice Inviting Tenders (E-Tendering Process)

Specification No.	Tender Inviting Authority	Name of the Work
M 243	CE / MM	Procurement of 7/4.09 mm ACSR Raccoon Conductor
M 244	CE / MM	Procurement of ACSR DOG Conductor

For details of works / Procurement / Due date of submission / Opening, viewing and downloading of e-tenders, please visit the websites www.tnpdcl.org, www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tntenders.gov.in

DIPR/2586/Tender/2026

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, KISHOR KUMAR S/O SHRI KAILASH CHANDER R/O 31/1, SECOND FLOOR, WEST PATEL NAGAR, DELHI-110008, do hereby confirm that my name mentioned as KISHOR KUMAR in his Class-X Certificate No: Regn.No.D99/0649/129127/30 issued by Central board of Secondary Education on 07-06-1999 is correct, also confirm my Aadhaar Card, PAN (BALPK7196M) & Voter ID have the same name KISHOR KUMAR. I also confirm that name appearing KISHORE KUMAR bearing Passport No.G19413626 in wrong due to spelling error, my correct name is KISHOR KUMAR. Henceforth I shall be known as KISHOR KUMAR for all purposes.

0071054546-1

0040872461-1

My name has mistakenly been recorded as Nilesh and my date of birth as 18-02-1980 in my husband 's Army records . However, my correct name is Neelesh Devi , date of birth 15-06-1983. Neelesh Devi , wife of Shri Surendra Singh , Kachora , Kiraoli , Agra .

0040872681-1

I, AYUSH BHATIA S/O SANJAY BHATIA,R/O F-19/53 THIRD FLOOR, SECTOR-8 ROHINI, DELHI-110085 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO AYUSH KUMAR

0130068120-1

SERVICES

ARE YOU NGO WITH FCRA? CONTACT FOR PROJECT PROPOSALS : 9584355072

0050294545-1

I, SAMER JAHAN MOHAMMED RAFIQUE W/o Zamirullah, H-357, GF, Jaitpur Extn-2, Mithe Pur, Delhi-44, have changed my name to SAMER JAHAN MOHAMMED RAFIQUE SIDDIQUI.

0071054546-1

I,VISHNU DAYAL,S/O RAM SUMER SHARMA,R/O-693 T-HUTS UDYOG NAGAR-WATER TANK.NO.2 JWALA PURI DELHI-110087.HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO VISHUN DAYAL SHARMA.

0040872480-7

I,Kiran Dhingra,w/o-Jai Prakash Dhingra /r/o-B01/601,Rps savana sec-88,Faridabad HAVE ADD SURNAME HER MINOR CHILD Vanshika to Vanshika Dhingra,for all purpose

0040872481-5

I Sailendra Verma / Shailendra Verma s/o Shatrughan Prasad Verma r/o D-117/2, Shyam Park, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad-201005 have changed my name to SHAILENDRA PRATAP VERMA.

0040872299-1

I,Mohd Luqman S/o-Mohd Sayeed, R/o-10005, Gali Nal Wali, Nawab Ganj, Azad Market, Delhi-6, declares that my name is changed as MOHAMMAD LUQMAN for all purpose.

0040872426-1

I,VIMLA DEVI mother of JC-603792N NB-Sub Prakash Thapa residing at -52,Satto Wali Ghati,Chandra Shekhar Azad Colony, Kanwali, Dehradun, Uttarakhand-248001,have changed my name from BIMLA THAPA to VIMLA DEVI and Date-of-Birth from 01-Jul-1958 to 10-May-1955 as per my Aadhaar-card.That I shall be known as VIMLA DEVI and date-of-birth is 10.05.1955 for all future purposes.

0040872491-4

It is for general information,that I,BALJEET KAUR,D/O-JASWANT SINGH,W/O-RAKESH DHEERAN,R/O-147,UNITY APARTMENT,POCKET-23, SECTOR-24,ROHINI, DELHI-110085,declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as BALJIT KAUR in my 10th,and 12th-class educational documents. The actual name of mine is BALJEET KAUR, which may be amended accordingly.

0040872101-7

I,SHIVANI MATTOO BHAN W/o SHWAIT BHAN,R/O Flat No-292 Green View Apartment, Pocket-2,Dwarka Sector-19,Delhi-110075,have changed my name to SHIVANI MATTOO.

0040872480-4

I,hitherto known as Harjeet Kaur,W/O-Harjinder Singh Batra,R/o-K-18, 2nd-Floor,Pratap Nagar,Padam Nagar,North Delhi-110007, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Harjeet Kaur Batra.

0040872481-2

I Pradeep Chopra S/o Sh. Bal Krishan Chopra R/o B-86, Patel Nagar II nd, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Pradeep Kumar Chopra for all purposes.

0040872289-2

I, Anil Kumar Shandil, S/o Trilok Chand Shandil, R/o H.No. RZ-J-19-20, Kh.No. 231-232, Third Floor Front Side, J-Block, West Sagarpur, New Delhi-110046, have changed my name from Anil to Anil Kumar Shandil, for all purposes.

0040872297-1

I, HEMLATA, W/O SHRI SANJAY KUMAR R/O OF F-19/ 53, THIRD FLOOR, SECTOR-8, ROHINI, DELHI - 110085, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME FROM 'HEMLATA' TO 'HEM LATA' AND SHALL HEREAFTER BE KNOWN AS 'HEM LATA' FOR ALL PURPOSES

0130068023-1

I,Renu Shukla,W/o-Indresh Shukla,R/o-E-3/451A,G/F,Gali.No.12,4th Pushta,Sonia Vihar,Karawal Nagar,North East Delhi,Delhi-110094,declare that Renu & Renu Shukla are one & same person.Here after I,will be known as Renu Shukla,for all,future purposes.

0040872491-1

I, Prem Kumar Munjal S/O Chander Bhan R/O 24, Chawla Colony, Sonipat, have changed my name to Prem Munjal.

0050295196-1

I, PRASHANT S/O Anand Parkash born on 17-07-1982 residing at E-19, First Floor, Gurunanak Road, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033, have changed my name to PRASHANT BANSAL vide affidavit dated 09th Aug. 2026 at Delhi.

0050295304-1

I, AKSHAY MORAL S/O SHRI AJAY KUMAR MORAL R/O FLAT NO.301, DCP OFFICE COMPLEX, I.P. EXTENSION, DELHI-110092, have changed my name AKSHAY MORAL to ABHISHEK MORAL for all future Purposes.

0040872501-1

I Alimuddin S/O, Abdul Ghani Khan R/o C-138 Gali No 10 Near Noorani Maszid Madanpur Khadar Extn. Sarita Vihar New Delhi-110076 have changed my name to Alimuddin Khan.

0040872286-1

I, KM. KHUSHBU D/O PRAVEEN SHARMA W/o RISHABH GOSWAMI R/o R 117/1, STREET NO-6, RAMESH PARK, LAXMI NAGAR, EAST DELHI, DELHI, 110092 have changed my name to KHUSHBU GOSWAMI for all purposes.

0071054426-1

I, hitherto known as RISHABH GUPTA S/o RAMAN KUMAR GUPTA R/o 381, Deepali Enclave, Pitampura, Delhi, Pin : 110034, Delhi, India, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as RISHABH MAHAJAN.

0071054565-1

I,Alaka D/o Indarsingh,R/o B-587,Sushant Lok-1,Block-B,Sector-27,Gurugram (Haryana)-122001,have changed my name to Alka Rathore for all Purposes.

0040872481-8

I, Shailja Singhal W/o Arun Singhal R/o-230/9, Scheme-7, Shastri Nagar, Meerut have changed my name to Shalja Singhal.

0071054479-1

I,Mohd.Sajid S/o Nasir Ali,R/o D-97,4th floor,Abul Faghal Enclave Part-2 Shaheen Bagh,New Delhi-110025,Have changed my name to Mohd.Sazid,for all purposes

0040872481-1

I,Mamta Choudhary,W/o-Vipin Chaudhary,R/o-Flat No.2044,Joy-Apartment plot no-2,Dwarka sector-2,Delhi-110075.Changed my name to Mamta Choudhary

0040872480-3

It is for general information,that I,BALJEET KAUR,D/O-JASWANT SINGH,W/O-RAKESH DHEERAN,R/O-147,UNITY APARTMENT,POCKET-23, SECTOR-24,ROHINI, DELHI-110085,declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as BALJIT KAUR in my 10th,and 12th-class educational documents. The actual name of mine is BALJEET KAUR, which may be amended accordingly.

0040872101-7

I Jagdish Joshi S/o Chelaji Bhanaji Joshi R/o B-23, Derawal Nagar, Model Town, Delhi-110009, have changed my name to Jagdish Chelaji Joshi for all future purposes

0071054427-1

I,Manjit Kaur Ahuja W/O.Daljeet Singh R/O. 37/16,Block-37,Ashok Nagar, Tilak-Nagar,West Delhi-110018,have changed my name to Manjeet Kaur for all Purposes.

0040872480-9

I,Pinki D/o Gordhan Ram,W/o Sunil,R/o H.No.43,Near-Pani Ki Tanki, Nakanpur,Ward No.6,Punhana,Mewat,Haryana -122508,have changed my name to Pinky for all Purposes.

0040872481-7

I,Sheelendra Kumar S/o Devendra Kumar Dixit R/o Flat-No.P406, Amrapali Silicon City, Sector-76, Noida(U.P) have changed my name to Sheelendra Kumar Dixit for all purposes.

0040872296-1

I,GAURAV YADAV @ GOURAV YADAV S/o-Sube Singh Yadav R/o-BG6/125-A, Paschim Vihar New Delhi-63,both names belong to same person i.e.myself

0040872480-2

I,PAWAN BHARDWAJ, S/o RAMESH CHANDER R/o House No-329,Nangal Thakran, Bawana Delhi-110039,have changed my minor son name HARSHIT to HARSHIT BHARDWAJ.

0040872501-2

False ceiling falls at NIS Patiala during I-Day event



The NIS Patiala campus holds national camps for boxing and weightlifting. EXPRESS

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, August 15

A PORTION of the false ceiling of the multipurpose hall-cum wrestling hall collapsed during the Independence Day celebrations being held at Netaji Subhash National Institute of Sports, Patiala. Many elite campers, including the boxing team as well as the weightlifting team train at the venue but the function was attended only by diploma students and players from NCOE camps at the campus. Some of the students and players suffered minor injuries with a video of the incident showing the portion of the false ceiling collapsing just as one of the students was set to perform on the stage. “While the Independence Day function was held outside, the cultural performance for the celebrations was being held at the multipurpose hall-cum wrestling hall. It seems due to the incessant rain yesterday, water might have seeped in the roof and the false ceiling panel collapsed. There were minor injuries to the students and players and they were given treatment from the medical team present at NIS. Some students and players were sent for CT Scan and the medical reports of them have come and everyone is fine. I am currently on medical leave but our NIS director Sumit Miglani is coordinating the efforts,” said NIS Senior Executive Director Vineet Kumar while speaking to *The Indian Express*. The NIS Patiala campus holds national camps for boxing, weightlifting as well some athletics camps, apart from running the national Centre of Excellence (NZCOE) centres in athletics, cycling, fencing, weightlifting and tennis. The centre also conducts workshops and diploma courses in sports coaching. The institute complex was established in 1961 followed by the renaming of the institute as Netaji Subhas National Institute of Sports in 1973. The complex, which covers a total area of 268 acres, currently has nine hostels and with 432 rooms which house offices, a library, a museum, staff clubs and classrooms, as well as a guest house. Kumar also spoke about taking measures to stop such mishaps. “We will do the structural audit and see whether the maintenance protocols have been followed or not,” Kumar said. An eye witness who did not wish to be named said, “We were preparing to watch the cultural performance when one portion of the false ceiling fell. Suddenly there was panic and the students and players rushed out of the hall. Some of them were injured and attended to by the medical staff at NIS, and some were taken for a CT scan and other medical procedures.”

INDIA VS SRI LANKA, FIRST TEST

Padikkal answers No. 3 question

7 batsmen had tried the position since Pujara left; none had scored a hundred there

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 15

IN RECENT years, Devdutt Padikkal may have been hogging the limelight for his batting in limited-overs cricket, where he has excelled out of his comfort zone. But deep down a fire has been burning in the left-hander. “I’ve grown up wanting to play Test cricket. My game is moulded for the format. I want to be a permanent member of the Indian Test team. That hasn’t changed in me,” he had told *The Indian Express* at the start of this year, when he was in the middle of a purple patch in white-ball cricket. The moment arrived eight months later, at Galle. With first-choice batsman B Sai Sudharsan missing the series, an opportunity opened up for Padikkal to bat at No. 3 and show why he is best suited to the role. Since Cheteshwar Pujara left the spot in June 2023, India have tried 11 different batsmen there, without finding one who could own the position for long. In three years, no Indian batsman had scored a century from that spot. On Saturday, Padikkal changed that, with a century entirely his own: caution blended with aggression. When he hit one to mid-off and took off for a quick single on the 134th delivery he faced, it brought up three figures. There were relieved faces in the Indian dressing room too. For No. 3, they finally seem to have found a batsman who could hold the spot for the long run. That India had taken this long to give Padikkal his chance has been puzzling. With competition for places so high, the 26-year-old had been waiting patiently. That’s all he could do. In the middle, going through the domestic grind, he had done everything he could. Be it for Karnataka or India A. At home or overseas, he had runs



Devdutt Padikkal, out in the middle within the first hour of the morning, hit an unbeaten 131 runs off 178 balls on Day 1. CREIMAS

in red-ball cricket. Even in the middle of the IPL, whenever the chance presented itself, he had been picking Andy Flower’s brains about improving his red-ball game. Yet, when a spot opened up at No. 3, Padikkal wasn’t the first choice. The promise shown by Sai Sudharsan meant India invested in him, even while he remained at a developmental stage with flaws still to cover. Had Sudharsan been fit for the series, Padikkal would have warmed the bench here too. Instead, he was out in the middle within the first hour of the morning, after Yashasvi Jaiswal’s dismissal. The intent was clear from the start. His first boundary came off the back foot, against debutant off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha. Through the day, Padikkal relied often on back-foot shots to find boundaries. By the sixth ball he faced, he already had a six against his name, this one off left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya, who gave a touch more flight than usual; Padikkal was already down the track,

With Karnataka team-mate KL Rahul retreating into his shell at the other end, it was Padikkal who led India’s charge

and lofted him straight.

Assured footwork

With his Karnataka team-mate KL Rahul retreating into his shell at the other end, it was Padikkal who led India’s charge. Confident in his footwork, whether pressing forward to defend, playing off the back foot, or coming down the track, he did it all with clarity. Using his feet let the left-hander open up more angles to score, and, just as importantly, never let the Sri Lankan spinners settle into a sustained spell at him. Every tight single on offer was taken. Twos were pushed. Boundaries never dried up. For Padikkal, all of it looked

routine. It is, after all, what he has been doing consistently on the domestic circuit, where he averages 43.18 in first-class cricket. The conversion rate has been an issue, but among all the options India have tried at No. 3, he looks a natural fit, at least in subcontinental conditions. Like Sudharsan, he too prefers to play the spinners off the back foot, but where Padikkal differs is in how he chooses his lengths. Whenever he intended to defend, he made sure to take a big stride forward. When the length gave him options, he picked the safest one. Even if that meant coming down the track and defending, he did. In the post-lunch session, there was a passage against the spinners where the game seemed to tighten. But despite the dot balls piling up, Padikkal showed no sign of giving it away. He got to his fifty, and from there it was a different Padikkal, one who took command. The moment the spinners erred even slightly in length, they were punished, Padikkal using the depth of the

crease well. Anything in line with the stumps, he whipped through mid-wicket with minimal fuss. There wasn’t much vicious turn on offer, but the majority of his runs against spin came through the square on either side, as he held India’s fort in front of the Galle Fort.

Scorecard

INDIA vs SRI LANKA	
GALLE	
TOSS: India won, chose to bat	
INDIA	
Yashasvi Jaiswal run out (Jayasuriya/Dickwella)	32 (37b, 5x4)
KL Rahul retired hurt	77 (162b, 9x4, 1x6)
Devdutt Padikkal not out	131 (178b, 12x4, 1x6)
Shubman Gill c Igalagamage b Jayasuriya	16 (28b, 2x4)
Rishabh Pant not out	27 (36b, 3x4, 1x6)
EXTRAS (lb 2, nb 3)	5
TOTAL (73 overs)	288/2
FOW: 1-47 (Yashasvi Jaiswal, 10.6 ov), 2-236 (Shubman Gill, 61.5 ov)	
BOWLING: Asitha Fernando 10-1-28-0 (1nb); Lahiru Kumara 10-1-51-0; Keshara Nuwantha 21-0-98-0 (2nb); Prabath Jayasuriya 24-4-77-1; Dhananjaya de Silva 4-0-15-0; Sonal Dinusha 4-0-17-0	

India leave two years of spin trouble behind them on dominant Day 1



KL Rahul anchored a composed 77 before retiring hurt. CREIMAS

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 15

DAY ONE at Galle belonged to India. While it was Devdutt Padikkal’s unbeaten maiden century that stood at the forefront of India’s domination, after they elected to bat first on a pitch expected to wear down and bring spinners more into play as the game progressed, more than the total of 288 for 2 they ended on, what would give India more comfort is the approach their batsmen took. Against spinners, a tribe that has caused them all sorts of problems over the last two years, they showed they can find a way to dominate. Coming into the Test against a Sri Lanka side depleted in batting, the only real challenge for India was how their own batsmen would handle the questions posed by the hosts’ spinners. In Prabath Jayasuriya, they faced a left-arm spinner relentless in the questions he asks. On a day he sent down 24 overs, he had just one wicket to show for it, that of captain Shubman Gill, who again showed the willingness to use his feet and come down the track, but was undone by Jayasuriya’s change of pace and dip, which left him nowhere close to the pitch of the ball. That dismissal was the only one Sri Lanka’s attack could manage after Yashasvi Jaiswal was run out in the first hour, in a mix-up with KL Rahul. Rahul went on to anchor a composed, unbeaten 77 before retiring hurt. Until that run-out, it was Jaiswal who had given India a steady start, the pair scoring at over four runs an over in the first hour.

Weak SL link

That dismissal had the potential to trigger a slide. It came at the exact moment Dhananjaya de Silva turned to his spinners to call the shots. Jayasuriya against a new, inexperienced batsman fighting for his spot, alongside a tentative Rahul, made for a riveting contest. But this Sri Lanka attack has one major hole. Alongside Jayasuriya’s unerring accuracy, they had only debutant offspinner Keshara Nuwantha, whom Padikkal had already seen plenty of during last week’s warm-up fixture, where he scored an unbeaten 142, and Sonal Dinusha, with just three caps to his name. The situation demanded India be proactive. It isn’t beyond them, but they have seldom shown it

when spinners have had their noses in front in the past. Even here, Jayasuriya was in no mood to make it easy. While Padikkal straightaway got down to rotating strike, using his footwork well, it was Rahul who faced the testing spell. Ahead of the series, he had practised on wet and dry pitches in Mumbai, where the ball turns square, working on his back-foot game. Here, Jayasuriya gave him little of that space. Instead, varying his pace, he kept his line at the stumps, but it was the length that made Rahul retreat into a shell. He could neither commit fully forward nor go back and defend the way Padikkal did. Instead, ball after ball, he had to half-press and play with soft hands, with close-in fielders crowding around him. To his credit, Rahul sensed the threat and even jumped down the track to loft Jayasuriya down the ground, but that was a rare instance. With deliveries on the fuller length, there was the option of the sweep, but it isn’t a shot that comes naturally to him. So to get the job done, he suffered. That he ended up with cramps in his arms said everything about the work behind all that dead-batting. As Rahul battled, Padikkal endured none of it. If anything, his innings was free-flowing. A century arriving off 134 deliveries showed the gap between the two: he did everything Rahul couldn’t, or didn’t get to. Unlike Rahul, he was bold with his feet, particularly playing off the back foot. Trusting the bounce on the red-soil track, he whipped, cut and pulled whenever the chance came. If there was flight on the ball, he came down the track, and even then didn’t reach for the aerial shot, a defensive push was often enough to force the spinners to alter their lengths. When he did, both Karnataka batsmen found runs, their stand of 150 putting India steadily in control. Once Rahul couldn’t continue batting at the start of the third session, delayed by a two-hour rain break that pushed the post-lunch phase back to 2 pm, Sri Lanka sensed an opportunity. But Gill arrived and played a breezy innings before Jayasuriya had him out too, bringing Rishabh Pant to the middle. Pant, true to his usual approach, added some quick runs that deflated Sri Lanka further, as India set their sights on batting big at Galle.

Bangladesh close in on historic win over Australia

Associated Press
Darwin, August 15

BANGLADESH MOVED to within sight of one of the biggest wins in its test cricket history after Australia stumbled to 161-4 and remained 67 runs behind at stumps on Day 3 of the first Test on Saturday. Cameron Green (43 not out) and Alex Carey (19 not out) dug in to keep Australia afloat, but the hosts face a huge task to first erase the deficit and then build a competitive total to defend in the final innings. Bangladesh needs six wickets to secure its first test victory in Australia and arguably the biggest win in its history in the format. Resuming at 351-6, Mehidy Hasan Miraz calmly shepherded Bangladesh’s tail to another 75 runs, taking the visitors to 426 and extending their first-innings lead beyond 200

before returning to make the crucial breakthrough with the ball, removing Steve Smith late in the day. Mehidy shared partnerships of 46 with Hasan Mahmud, 18 with Taijul Islam and then a handy 46-run partnership with Taskin Ahmed before eventually falling for 65 from 154 balls. Australia were at times its own enemy with another three dropped catches Saturday, including an inexplicable drop by Smith in the deep, making it five for the battered hosts across the match.

Hazlewood’s 300

Josh Hazlewood claimed all four wickets to fall on Saturday and returned 6-89 off 28 overs for the innings. His fifth wicket of Mehidy was also his 300th test wicket, making him the fourth of Australia’s Big Four



Australia trailed Bangladesh by 67 runs at stumps on Day 3. AP

bowling attack to reach the milestone, and the ninth Australian to do so. Hazlewood then removed Ebadot Hossein caught behind for 7 to end the innings at 426 to mark a strong return after 12 months out of the test team

through injuries. “I bowled four out of six good balls a lot of the time and let things off in those other two,” Hazlewood said. “I am still standing. That’s good. It was a pretty tough slog straight-up. Obviously the

more matches you play the better you get through those longer spells.”

Top-order woes repeat

Australia lost both openers cheaply before tea as Bangladesh strengthened its grip at Marrara Stadium. Jake Weatherald (0) and Travis Head (17) both chopped on to pacerman Hasan Mahmud attempting cut shots too close to their stumps as Australia slid to 37-2. It took Mahmud’s (2-33) match wicket tally to eight after his return of 6-55 in the first innings limited the hosts to 198 and set the tone for the tourists’ upper hand for the following two days.

BRIEF SCORES: Australia 198 & 161/4 in 53 overs (Cameron Green 43 not out, Steve Smith 44; Hasan Mahmud 2/33) vs **Bangladesh** 426 all out.

ESPORTS WORLD CUP

‘Happy with my chances, confident against him’: Erigaisi on future Carlsen duels

Mayank Chaudhary
Paris, August 15

ARJUN ERIGAISI is the kind of player on whom placing your hopes doesn’t really feel like a gamble. He has been among India’s brightest prospects for years now, standstill shoulder to shoulder with D Gukesh and R Praggnanandhaa. He has an uncanny ability to disrupt the natural flow of a position and conjure advantages out of thin air. His peers and rivals have always rated him highly. He has touched the 2800 Elo rating, becoming only the second Indian after Viswanathan Anand to do so. And yet, for all his brilliance, one thing has consistently eluded him: the finish line. Arjun admitted that the weight of those near-misses has

been heavy. “Mentally there have been some tough times. Missing out on titles and such experiences were very tough on me,” he told *The Indian Express* during the Esports World Cup 2026 in Paris. But for a player who has been called a “madman” by Magnus Carlsen, resilience is part of the package. The tough phases, he insists, have only sharpened his resolve. “It’s a long journey for everyone, for my generation pretty much. I know these misses are tough, but there are a lot of years left. If I fix these things, like fumbling under pressure, then I’m confident that with my level of play, I’ll be able to win a lot of titles. All I’m doing right now is trying to fix these small things. Even though it’s tough, it’s helping me become

stronger mentally,” he said. While he believes these tough times have fortified him mentally, Arjun also pointed out that he is not the only one going through a low phase. He said, “If we see individually, everyone is having their phases, not just me, Gukesh, or Praggnanandhaa, but also Nodirbek and Alireza. Everyone has their ups and downs.” **Quiet patch** The year 2024 was a watershed moment for Indian chess. Gukesh became the youngest world champion in history, Arjun crossed the elusive 2800 barrier, and India won maiden gold medals in both the Open and Women’s sections at the Chess Olympiad. But since then, men’s chess has hit a quiet patch. No podium



Arjun Erigaisi has had a streak of near-misses at the big stage. EWC

finish at the home World Cup. A middling Candidates campaign for Praggnanandhaa. Gukesh failing to win a single title after his world championship triumph. Arjun, too, had

strong runs, but his streak of near-finishes continued. The jinx was finally broken by Prag, who won the Norway Chess title, beating Carlsen twice in Oslo.

Arjun tried to make sense of the contrast with 2024. He said, “2024 was a point when Gukesh was having his ups and he became world champion, I was having my ups and crossed 2800. Only Praggnanandhaa didn’t have that great of a year then, and now he’s having a good time. So overall, I think people are just having mixed ups and downs, and that was just a combination of a couple of us doing really, really well.” At the EWC, India fielded four players, Arjun, Nihal Sarin, Aravindh Chithambaram, and Pranesh M. But none of them could make their way to the semifinals. Arjun and Nihal reached the top eight, only to be stopped by Hikaru Nakamura and Carlsen respectively, as the Norwegian steamrolled the field to win his second consec-

utive EWC title. Arjun, however, is not too bothered by Carlsen’s dominance. He believes it is only a matter of time before Indians start getting better results against him. Pragg’s Norway Chess win was proof. “We are not really dominating. Magnus is still there. He is still the best. But recently, Pragg beat him at Norway Chess, and I also had pretty decent results against him, so I’m confident that if we just stay focused and do all the right things, we will be able to do well in the near future,” he said. Arjun is also confident about his own graph against Carlsen. Though he didn’t face the Norwegian at the EWC as Carlsen handpicked Nihal ahead of him, the Warangal prodigy is happy with his re-

cent performances against the world’s best. “I believe improvement is something that happens gradually. When it was one-sided, it was around 2022 where there was a clear strength difference, as well as the nervousness of playing Magnus for the first time. Gradually, in 2023-24, I was losing matches, but they were pretty close, and I wasn’t just getting crushed like earlier. Then slowly, I started winning some games as well. “I feel like gradually I improved my level. Of course, he is still world number one in all formats, so I do respect him. But in general, I am happy with my chances and confident against him.” (The writer is in Paris at the invitation of the Esports Foundation)

Arteta tells fans not to worry about Arsenal deal extension



Mikel Arteta led Arsenal to a historic PL title last year.

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 15

SEEKING TO allay Arsenal supporters' concerns, Mikel Arteta has said fans "don't have to worry about" his future with the Premier League champions as he wishes to extend his contract and the time left on his deal is "not an issue".

The Gunners head coach ended their 22-year wait to win the English top-flight in May and is into the last 12 months of his agreement. He is yet to put pen to paper regarding contract extension, with Arsenal set to meet Manchester City in the Community Shield on Sunday to commence their 2026-27 campaign. But Arteta, who joined the club in 2019 and last signed a deal in 2024, says he is relaxed about formal talks for a renewal.

"No, they (supporters) don't have to worry about any of that because I want to be here, I'm extremely happy," Arteta said. "I feel very grateful to work with the people that I work with and whenever we have the possibility we will resolve that."

Implying that Gunners' hectic transfer activity has been his priority instead of the contract, Arteta said the contract was not a matter of worry. "There is always another priority, I think! That's the way we have been treating it, I think because everybody feels comfortable that the time on the contract is not going to be an issue," he said. "I think because my will, certainly, is to be here and I am very happy here. My feeling from the club is the same one. That is why everyone is doing things in a really organic way."

Aiming to strengthen their title-winning squad, Arsenal have signed midfielder Bruno Guimaraes from Newcastle United, Greek winger Christos Tzolis from Club Brugge and converted Piero Hincapié's loan move from Bayer Leverkusen into a permanent transfer.

Rice, Saka available

He confirmed Declan Rice, Bukayo Saka and Martin Zubimendi are available for Sunday's Community Shield against Manchester City after returning to training following extended breaks after the World Cup.

The trio have linked up with the squad and could feature despite missing the pre-season programme. "They will be available; they trained with us today, they will train tomorrow, and if they are in the condition we expect them to be in, they will be involved," Arteta told reporters. Saka managed an Achilles issue late last season, while Rice revealed during the World Cup that he had been dealing with hamstring-related neural pain since December before also suffering a knee problem.



Training day

Indian shuttler Ayush Shetty (L) and five-time Worlds medallist PV Sindhu sparring ahead of the Badminton World Championships set to start on Monday. PRITISH RAJ

BWF WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS

Discourse on periods: Taboo loses stigma at Delhi Worlds

For the first time at a Badminton Worlds, female washrooms will have sanitary products available at IG Stadium

Shivani Naik

New Delhi, August 15

KIRSTY GILMOUR, the feisty jump smasher from Scotland, had once taken a set off World No 1 An Se-young, of South Korea, at the All England. "I had to run away immediately after because I was so aware I needed to use the washroom," she recalls of a panicky situation when playing during her menstrual period. She copped a court violation card for taking longer than 2 minutes to return.

At the Delhi World Championships, her 10th since her first in 2013, Gilmour has noticed that the women's washrooms in Delhi are all equipped with sanitary napkins, as the taboo topic amongst athletes is starting to lose its stigma. "You can be the most powerful female athlete on earth, but if you stain, the look that you get stays as a bad memory," she says, pleading for rules to be more considerate.

Currently, players can seek permission to hop over to the washroom in the 60-second interval at the 11-point break or the 120 seconds after every 21-point set.

Organisers of the Badminton World Championships in Delhi have initiated their own small but important measure. "Access to sanitary napkins is a basic necessity, not an added facility," says Sanjay Mishra, General Secretary, Badminton

Association of India. "At an international sporting event of this scale, ensuring access to essential menstrual hygiene products should be part of the fundamental infrastructure. BAI has therefore ensured their availability across women's washrooms at the venue, so that athletes, officials, media, volunteers and spectators have access to them whenever required," Mishra added, of the first time that this competition has seen this.

"I come from Scotland where every public washroom has sanitary products. So, it was great to see India has done this and people here speak openly and the little shame goes away," she says. "Menstrual cycles are just a part of life. The main part of our lives. So as athletes, it'll be great if there are protocols in place," she stresses.

"No woman wants to stand in front of a packed All England arena to announce, 'I'm on a period.' So it's not like anyone will cheat. It wasn't the chair umpire's fault - he was following the rules. But there is no piece of protocol in place to deal with this," she says, hoping the Badminton World Federation will rethink its rigid rule that won't be flexible. "It's just like a medical break."

Gilmour is part of the Women's Badminton Collective (WBC), which initiated the conversation on the topic, alongside fellow shuttler Mia



Kirsty Gilmour (L) showing her tattoos after practice. BAI

Blichfeldt. Ahead of the World Championships, the Danish shuttler got Chinese Huang Dong Ping, the 2021 Tokyo Olympics mixed doubles champion and thrice World Championship medallist, to speak about the tricky dynamics of mixed doubles, given the women's menstrual cycles.

"If there was one rule I

would urge the BWF to change and take the opportunity to make badminton women-friendly, it's to factor in that women have periods," the Tokyo gold medallist told WBC. "Sometimes we need to use the washroom, which becomes cumbersome because of the short break permitted. It happened to me at Sudirman Cup,"

You can be the most powerful female athlete on earth, but if you stain, the look that you get stays as a bad memory."

KIRTSY GILMOUR, REIGNING EUROPEAN CHAMPION.

she added. "It also happened to the Scottish player (Kirsty Gilmour)."

Dongping would add nuance to the argument, particularly the dichotomy of the mindset needed in mixed doubles. "As an athlete in mixed doubles, I don't distinguish between men and women on court. For what we are competing for, there's no man or woman, only winning matters. But we have to admit we are physiologically different than men. In mixed doubles, as the lady on the court, there will be situations for two of us (her and her woman opponent) that aren't same for men because sometimes we play in periods. The toilet-break rules are rigid, and need flexibility," the Chinese hard-hitter, a contemporary legend, told the WBC.

Dong Ping is top-seeded at the Delhi World Championships with partner Feng Yanzhe, in pursuit of their first gold as a pair. "Women in badminton are about strength, resilience and tenacity and we fight and compete as equals in mixed doubles. But the rules need to consider that we can be playing on periods," she told WBC.

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Crowdfunded Wales no match for India

Mihir Vasavda

Mumbai, August 15

BEFORE WALES had even pushed back at the World Cup, they were already chasing a scoreboard. Not the one inside the iconic Wagener Stadium, but the one on a crowdfunding page. Their target was £40,000. When the tournament began, they were still £1,929 short. In other words, the £38,071 they raised – approximately Rs 49.26 lakh – was roughly what India coach Craig Fulton earns in two months.

On the field, India beat Wales 3-1 in their opening Pool D match in Amstelveen, producing the sort of controlled performance that Fulton would have expected for most of the match. The defence held firm until the final few minutes, the penalty corners clicked, captain Harmanpreet Singh scored twice and Sanjay, the reserve drag-flicker, also found the net. The display was a clean sheet and a field goal away from reaching perfection. That, however, would be nitpicking – especially since this was the first match of a long tournament.

Yet, the scoreline told only a part of the story. This was also a meeting of two vastly different hockey ecosystems. One team arrived after spending months in a fully funded national camp. The other arrived after asking supporters to help finance its World Cup journey.

Wales pay to play

Months before their second appearance on this stage, Hockey Wales launched an online crowdfunding campaign.

The donations ranged from as low as £10 to £100, and players – from teenager Nicholas Morgan to veteran goalie Dan Kyriakides, midfielder Rhys Bradshaw and forward Jolyon Morgan – ran individual campaigns to fund their trips.

For a Welsh player, paying to play is not a nascent concept. According to Hockey Wales, players contribute around £1,200 a year towards travel and accommodation costs to wear the national colours. The governing body itself has acknowledged operating on a £100,000 annual budget deficit. The crowdfunding drive is only the latest reminder of the financial realities facing Welsh hockey.

If Wales needed a crowdfunding campaign to get to the World Cup, India spent nearly a year preparing for it in a centralised national camp where every facet – from accommodation to sports science and overseas exposure – was taken care of. Add the crores in gov-

Scoreline

INDIA	WALES
3	1
Sanjay 08'	Welsh 56'
Harmanpreet 11, 43'	—

The scoreline told only a part of the story. This was also a meeting of two vastly different hockey ecosystems.

ernment funding and sponsor support, and the two teams could hardly be further apart.

World Cups tend to produce fairytales, where underdogs slay Goliaths. On Saturday, however, David was not the victor. India were expected to win.

Wales are no pushovers. Four of their players routinely turn up for Great Britain in major tournaments, and a couple of them – captain Jacob Draper and Gareth Furlong – were a part of the squad that had an epic run to the quarterfinals at the Paris Olympics. Yet, for India, this was the match where pressure would have been at its comparative lowest. The only tricky bit heading into Saturday's opener was whether rustiness – or distraction, given the controversy over the saffron jersey – would give Wales an opportunity.

Those concerns were dispelled from the first minute. Fulton demanded his players display their strength in set-pieces and play with control. He should be pleased with both after this performance.

Hardik Singh and Shilanand Lakra combined to earn a penalty corner in the eighth minute. With Harmanpreet not being on the pitch, Sanjay stepped up. Highly rated for his strong flicks, he signalled his readiness with a low finish that went through the legs of goalkeeper Toby Reynolds-Cotterill.

The goal gave India an early lift. They began zipping the ball around, moving Wales from side to side and finding their way into the circle. But hastiness in the final third meant none of those entries translated into goals. India kept winning penalty corners, though. And Harmanpreet allayed concerns over his form by scoring twice. Against Wales, India did not need to be perfect to secure three points. Now, the real test begins.

PLAYING TODAY: (Women's) India vs England, 4.30 pm, Live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar



Harmanpreet Singh scored in the 11th, 43rd minutes. HOCKEY INDIA

ROLLING THE RED CARPET

Checking in at Worlds: Lower floors, ice baths & kanji on the menu for players

Shivani Naik

New Delhi, August 15

AS HOSTS to badminton's World Championships, from August 17 to 23, Delhi will let go of its staple long-grained rice. Instead, rice will be simmered with ginger, garlic and chicken broth into a hearty, starchy porridge, to cater to the East Asian palate of the shuttle stars trooping into the Indian capital. The hearty serving of kanji, called congee or zhou across Southeast Asia, is front and centre of buffets at hotels hosting the sport's biggest names from the Far East.

Dining menus aren't the only thing being adjusted. Even minute details like room lighting have been considered, and bulk orders of ice are expected to shoot up, as recovery proto-

cols like ice baths become common. With post-midnight arrivals, the best welcome is a quiet, efficient check-in and guiding players to their rooms without fuss, the hotels maintained.

"We will have a prominent noodle bar, of course," says Le Meridien director of food and beverages Vineet Wadhwa, who is hosting over 200 athletes and support staff at the CP hotel, while an equal number are camped at the Shangri-La right across, as the Worlds get underway at Indira Gandhi Stadium on Monday. "We will also serve kanji, miso soup, veggie preparations and chicken and fish prepared the Asian way of flavouring," Wadhwa added. More carbs, in the form of kanji, are a must when shuttlers are in town, he stresses.

His head chef, associate di-



A presentation shuttlecock at one of the hotels in Delhi. SHIVANI NAIK

rector Karan Mehta, though, is expecting shuttlers to give in to the irresistible butter chicken and naan eventually, even if they play it safe with spice in the early days. Moderating spice levels also means the popular masala dosa (a favourite of Malaysian former world champion Aaron Chia, who converted others to it) is prepared with less chilli in the potato masala. "Our base spice is at a standard level anyway, but we have found athletes asking over and over again for butter chicken," Mehta says.

A few more imported cheeses, and gluten-free and sourdough breads, get added with the French and Danish squads, among other Europeans, camped out there too. "They need their salamis and meat cuts," Mehta says.

Though not as popular as their boba bubble teas, Asian shuttlers have been known to get accustomed to sipping on chhaanch, lassi and nimbu paani when they are in Delhi.

5 am takeaways

Millet khichdi and quinoa upma are also getting popular, thanks to the "healthy" tag.

With early training sessions from as early as 6.30 am, and morning matches, hotels are ready with breakfast takeaways from 5 am. Shuttlers' hotel rooms are also served assorted shuttle-shaped mithai and savoury platters. A badminton-themed cocktail menu, with names such as Smash Bucket with 5 beers, 4th Serve, Court Cooler and Happy Rally, has been set up in the Meridien bar. A giant revolving shuttle-

cock installation is prominently displayed in the lobby. At the Shangri-La, where a batch of Chinese and Japanese athletes are camped, badminton stays on the big-screen TVs, tuned into the happenings at Indira Gandhi Stadium.

A lot of teams have arrived with their own ice tubs, for the recovery baths that help them go from one match to the next on back-to-back days and cure muscle soreness.

"There are bulk orders for ice and a standard rate card applied," a hotel staffer said.

At the stadium, the visuals going out to the world are of miniature India Gates in a golden hue, from where the players might make their entrance, and intricately hued elephants raising their trunks in welcome.

Expedited laundry tends to be an underrated service for athletes. Pitch-dark rooms are something athletes tend to request, since sleep is sacrosanct for them as recovery. "Some of them don't like to be on higher floors, due to fear of heights. Some want to be far away from traffic sounds, so we allot rooms keeping that in mind," says Sanath Kakkara, experiences manager. Guests are directed to Janpath for shopping queries, though the first three or four days will tend to be a stadium-to-hotel commute with little else in between. "We want to show support for India at the Worlds. It's our country's biggest event in badminton in years. It's a high-stress tournament, so the hotel should feel comforting, like home," he adds.



Hindi cinema’s cool

As *Dil Chahta Hai* completes 25 years, director Farhan Akhtar recalls the instinct and experimentation that went into creating the film

The Rewards of Slow Cooking



Power of a Shared Joke

Stand-up comedian AZEEM BANATWALLA on laughter as a social emotion, the evolution of satire and what makes for a healthy democracy



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

are not new. Nor are they the exception. The French Revolution, which essentially birthed modern politics as we know it, spread through cartoons and slogans scratched on walls. Graffiti remains the ultimate symbol of defiance. The civil rights movements of the 1970s saw the foundations of hip hop with the likes of Public Enemy and N.W.A. giving the African American youth of the United States an urban identity.

My generation — the millennials — will probably go down in history as an obedient,

in-between generation that did nothing of meaningful political consequence in India. We were born into the newly liberalised economy post the 1991 economic reforms, raised by parents hell-bent on securing our futures by any means necessary. By 2010, we were young enough to see buying a house as a realistic dream and old enough to ride the IT wave into corporate slavery. It's morbidly funny that we grew up listening to Rage Against The Machine but resigned ourselves to doing exactly what we were told to.

We were content to go to a heavy metal gig and vent our frustrations on random strangers in mosh pits — bloody noses and bruising ribs, with enthusiastic consent. It was oddly cathartic. That mosh pit is now on social media; nobody really wants to be there but it's addictive. Your discontent rests at the tip of your thumb, just waiting to type out a "ragebait" comment in reply to an absolute stranger. An AI algorithm knows exactly what triggers your dopamine, drawing you deeper and deeper into your own echo chamber. And

while distracting the youth and sending down an infinitely scrollable rabbit-hole of brainrot seems like fertile ground for authoritarianism, sometimes the algorithm does its job too well. It shows you exactly what you need to see to abandon your apolitical aloofness and lend your voice to a cause. India's voice for the last month or so, driven by a cartoon cockroach, has been satire fuelled by a cocktail of irreverence and unseriousness that is Gen-Z's signature. Watching 20-something Gen-Z activists troll the British out of India would have been a sight to behold. "Let Gandhiji cook!", they would have said, "Bro woke up and chose non-violence!"

A generation of angry teens managed to not just ridicule one powerful minister into resignation but also compelled others to pivot hastily to the role of influencers, rebranding themselves with hot-take selfie videos and khadi-based GRWM (Get Ready With Me) reels to appeal to their new young "friends". However, being funny and relatable comes from being self-aware and reading the room, a skill that differentiates comedians from politicians. If you cannot convince your audience that you are playing the fool, unfortunately you are the fool. A 'melody' selfie is not particularly endearing to desperate students standing in the crosshairs of pellet guns.

When you are the fool

As the dust settles on last month's protests at Jantar Mantar, the fallout has predictably become a stealthy, surgical crack-down on dissent. As I sit writing this, Instagram is blocking posts deemed to be problematic.

Comedians are cancelling shows due to fringe right-wing groups threatening to wreak havoc (despite permissions being in place). Recently, I was scheduled to perform at a college event that was cancelled owing to disagreements between faculty and students about whether stand-up comedy is a good idea.

I'm asked ever more frequently now about what the future holds for stand-up comedy and satirical content creators. Truthfully, I don't know. Live stand-up and content creation are huge industries that generate eye-watering amounts of revenue in 2026. Having said that, the sudden downfall of Dream11 and the online gaming industry this year has shown us that nothing is too big to be vanquished overnight. It bears reminding though, that we now live in what will go down in history as the "post-cockroach" era. And those pesky things seem to find their way through the cracks.

Healthy democracies thrive on healthy criticism, and that criticism hits the hardest through art. A well-crafted joke opens the eyes as much as it flaps the jaw. It provides dopamine and releases tension. It speaks truth you were struggling to articulate. Satirists doing their jobs ensure that politicians are compelled to do theirs. Still, it is not unusual to see stand-up comedians derided and called attention seeking clowns, trying to run down the saintly establishment to make a quick buck.

I would argue that, if anything, the clowns are doing the establishment a favour. For without us, they would be the only jokers in town.

Azeem Banatwalla is a stand-up comedian and content creator with multiple stand-up specials on Amazon Prime and YouTube. He is currently touring his 90-minute special 'Generational' across India

FREEDOM TO LAUGH AGAIN

Humour has always given dissent a voice. Political satire that has endured time from known voices



YES MINISTER

POLITICAL HUMOUR and satire have always been integral to our parliamentary tradition. Once when (freedom fighter) Mahavir Tyagi was speaking about the areas India had lost after the Chinese debacle in 1962, Jawaharlal Nehru said that not a blade of grass grew in the 17,000-ft high Aksai Chin. A bald Tyagi, removed his cap and said, "Not a strand of hair grows on my head. Does it mean that the head has no value?" There were so many such moments. Then, there was the BBC serial, *Yes Minister*, which even Opposition leaders enjoyed. Humour brings consensus, provokes introspection and punctures arrogance. If you try to crush it through the power of the state, you are the loser.

RAVISHANKAR PRASAD
MEMBER OF PARLIAMENT, LOK SABHA
AS TOLD TO VIKAS PATHAK



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

KERALA'S CHAKYAR KOOTHU

I VALUE traditional forms like Chakyar Koothu in Kerala, where the Chakyar, a commentator, has the licence to make fun of even the king. There is such a strong tradition of laughing at power, where those being critiqued are often sitting in the audience themselves and laughing loudly. That, to me, is the real power of satire.

SUMANGALA DAMODARAN
ECONOMICS PROFESSOR, MUSICIAN,
COMPOSER

BERTOLT BRECHT'S THE RESISTIBLE RISE OF ARTURO UI



BRECHT'S MOST scathing political satire was based on the rise of Adolf Hitler. I watched director Manfred Weckworth's compelling production at the Berliner Ensemble. It explored

the metaphor of the circus on multiple levels. Their painted faces exuded viciousness combined with the grotesque and comic. Set in a fictional Chicago of the 1920s, Ui/Hitler and his henchmen were costumed in a cross between Italian mafioso gangsters and circus clowns. Each sequence was treated as a circus number but choreographed to transition from the farcical to the violent. The brilliant acting ensemble of over 40 actors, combined comedy with deadpan violence, creating a disturbing, unstable fascist world fraught with senseless violence.

AMAL ALLANA
THEATRE DIRECTOR, TEACHER, WRITER

JAROSLAV HASEK'S THE GOOD SOLDIER SVEJK



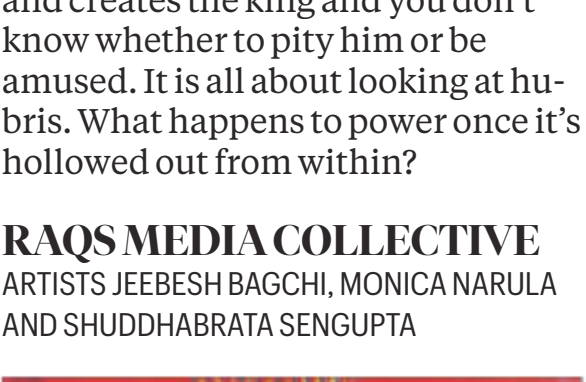
paratus of power. Czech author Jaroslav Hasek's book subverts the narratives of blind patriotism through humour and unblinking irony. The simple-minded Svejk is at some level comparable to Dostoyevsky's *The Idiot*. Svejk, who had previously been certified as an imbecile is incarcerated in prison for innocent but politically incorrect remarks — something that seems entirely resonant with our times. The disarming mask of the idiot exposes the absurdity of war and nationalistic fervour. The passive compliance of the wise fool as a survival strategy is a thumbs up to a cruel and oppressive system.

NAMITA GOKHALE
AUTHOR, CO-FOUNDER AND CO-DIRECTOR,
JAIPUR LITERATURE FESTIVAL

RABIN MONDAL'S KING SERIES

WE ARE big fans of the paintings by Rabin Mondal, especially his 'King' series (pictured *King As Manipulator*). It takes the idea of power and sort of exaggerates it. It pulls from the language of modernity that was prevalent at that time like Picasso and creates the king and you don't know whether to pity him or be amused. It is all about looking at hubris. What happens to power once it's hollowed out from within?

RAQS MEDIA COLLECTIVE
ARTISTS JEEBESH BAGCHI, MONICA NARULA
AND SHUDDHABRATA SENGUPTA



DAG



KUNDAN SHAH'S JAANE BHI DO YAARO

IT WAS kind of a theatre of the absurd set in Mumbai but it went far beyond that, across the world, into the realm of corruption, waste and incompetence. There is humour and tragedy — a dead body floating around, the tales of the Ramayana being tossed in, Akbar entering into the Ramayana. It was an oracle and a masterpiece.

SAEED MIRZA
FILMMAKER, WRITER, TRAVELLER
AS TOLD TO SHREYOSHEE PALIT

{ THE WORD THIS WEEK }

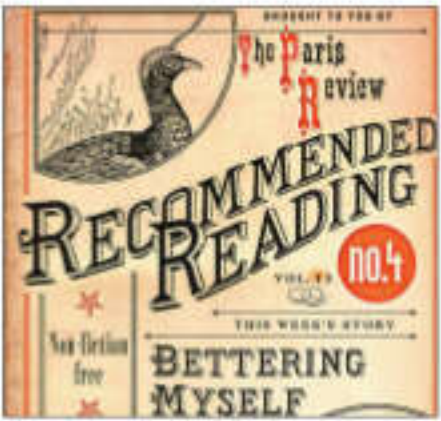
Obama to host literary podcast

FORMER US President Barack Obama is launching a new Audible podcast, *A Great Book with Barack Obama*, which will premiere on September 24. The six-episode series, produced with Higher Ground, features Obama in conversation with six yet-to-be-announced guests about novels that shaped his world view. The curated list spans American classics and spy thrillers, including James Baldwin's *The Fire Next Time*, Toni Morrison's *Song of Solomon*, Cormac McCarthy's *All the Pretty Horses*, Marilynne Robinson's *Gilead*, Robert Penn Warren's *All the King's Men*, and John Le Carré's *Tinker, Tailor, Soldier, Spy*.



Professor fired for teaching Moshfegh

AN INDIAN-ORIGIN Florida college professor is suing South Florida State College and its president Fred Hawkins after being fired for teaching a short story by Man Booker Prize shortlisted author Ottessa Moshfegh. Vinita Prabhakar was terminated in February after a student expressed "mild discomfort" about *Bettering Myself* — a story about a caustic, alcoholic teacher — to Hawkins, who acted without formal complaint or lesser discipline, bypassing procedure. Prabhakar claims First Amendment violations, with support from the free speech group FIRE.



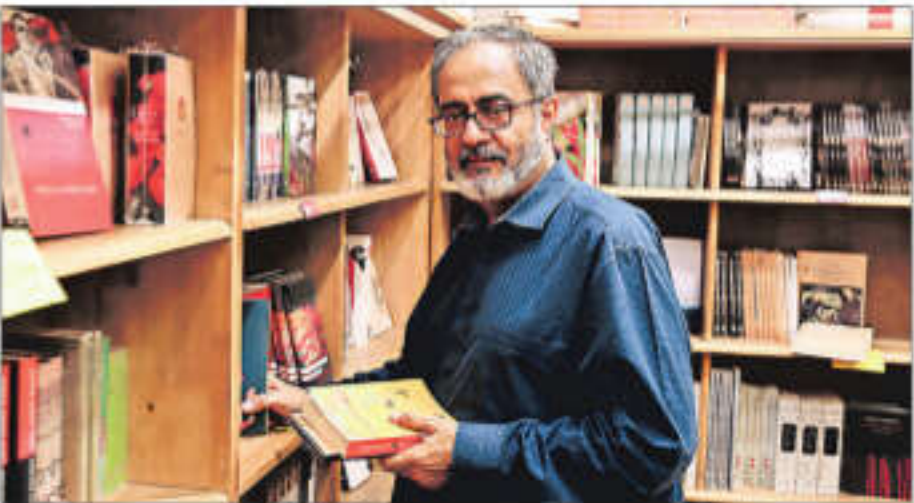
Miles Franklin prize for Omar Musa

NOVELIST, POET and rapper Omar Musa won Australia's most prestigious fiction prize, the \$60,000 (approximately ₹29.4 lakh) Miles Franklin Literary Award, for his second novel *Fierceland*. The judges praised the novel as "a tour de force" that "refashions the venerable, vernacular hikayat traditions of Malay storytelling into new Australian idioms." The family epic follows two siblings returning to Malaysian Borneo to reckon with the legacy of their late father, a palm oil baron. His win follows Malaysian-born author Siang Lu's 2025 victory.



Black author loses deal over AI

NIGERIAN-BORN author Jerry Falade lost a \$2 million USD publishing deal for his debut novel, *Call Me, I'll Hide the Body*, after his agents withdrew the manuscript. An editor flagged potential AI use during submissions, but the agency initially accepted Falade's explanation as "clear and credible" before cutting ties on July 29. The manuscript was reportedly run through the AI-detection tool Pangram. Falade insists he only used AI for research, not for writing. He has retained legal counsel and alleged racial bias, pointing to similar cases involving persons of colour, including Mia Ballard, HM Wolfe and Jamir Nazir.



INGOOD COMPANY
Naveen Kishore

Alphabet Uprising

Language rebels against its own dissolution in Naveen Kishore's *Ode to a Grieving Angel*

Aishwarya Khosla

THE LIGHTS change from crimson to steel blue and a fallen angel drags his tattered wings across the stage: A foggy barren landscape of burnt stumps and a jaundiced cardboard moon as the ghost of Hamlet's father shuffles past, Macbeth lies on a stone slab, and King Lear is silhouetted against a darkening horizon. It is this grief-stricken world of rebels, tried without a trial, expelled and subjected to water cannons, that Naveen Kishore invites us to inhabit in his poetry collection, *Ode to a Grieving Angel*. This theatre of collapse, where meaning and language have disintegrated, is carefully constructed through typography and fragmented, jagged verses punctuated by prose, stage directions and a Coda.

If the imagery hits home, Kishore has done his job as a chronicler of our age of war, censorship and state violence, where poems die on tongues, "fighting for air."

On this stage, the alphabet is a cast of fugitives, coming "unstuck/ from its even-keeled moorings", and the writer's muse rages "in a voice that has lost its memory." Everything — language, the world as we know it — is disintegrating as the poet struggles to write a eulogy, and the actor struggles to collect the words strewn over the stage. If the early sections reveal a crisis of articulation, the middle of the collection is haunted by political horror: "khaki shadows' jackboots on the march," "rivers of blood" and "an entire city in flames."

Words appear to be under duress, a lexicon that can no longer be taken at face value as the vocabulary has been co-opted by the state. In a prose passage, Kishore presents his *ars poetica*: "Rehearse the revolution.... Subversion. Has to begin at the bottom."

Later, the poet-protagonist buries letters of the alphabet in a coffin, "each letter in a patch of oilskin." Near the end, Kishore asks: "What if you woke up one day and found you had a lot to say. But no desire to say it." The poet turns his back on language, thinking "thoughts that the alphabet had yet to decipher."

In the coda, the poet-protagonist cradles a fallen angel, noticing "the first one has a vivid dream playing under the eyelids. Compelling. Grand. Evocative," while the other eye holds "a shattered dream. Raging. In fury. Destroying everything." This sums up the storm raging through the poem; the contradictions coexisting without synthesis. "Nothing to be done," Kishore writes, echoing Samuel Beckett's Vladimir. Godot never arrives; Kishore's angel has already fallen.



ODE TO A
GRIEVING ANGEL
NAVEEN KISHORE
Speaking Tiger
100 pages
₹399

BETWEEN GODS AND MEN

American Indologist and scholar Wendy Doniger on her memoir, the pleasures and perils of a life in academia

Paromita Chakrabarti

AT 85, Wendy Doniger has the enviable air of someone who has lived several lives — and remembers all the best stories. One of the foremost scholars of Hinduism, whose *The Hindus: An Alternative History* provoked both admiration and fury, now turns the scholar's gaze upon herself. In her memoir *For the Love of Stories: Confessions of An Accidental Feminist*, Doniger talks about a life lived on her own terms — her many romances (the man she did not marry, however, turned out to be Francis Ford Coppola), forging unlikely friendships in a chauvinistic academic world, learning to hold her own amid a bruising battle with Dinanath Batra, and a lifetime spent between Sanskrit texts and Hindu mythology. In this interview, she speaks of a vanishing academic world, and looking back in longing and gratitude. Edited excerpts:

Has writing this memoir changed the way you understand your story?

Yes, certainly. I began to write it at a moment when I was beginning to feel very strongly the loss of so many parts of my life as I aged — the loss of friends, of my own physical and mental powers, of important aspects of the worlds that I had loved and now had changed so violently — my own country, India, and academia. It was a time of considerable sadness. But as I wrote, I kept recalling all the wonderful people I had known and the great adventures I had had, and I stopped mourning the present and the future as I became more and more grateful for the past that had given me so much joy.

The controversy surrounding *The Hindus* brought questions of faith, free speech and scholarship into focus. Did that experience change the way you think about the limits — and responsibilities — of a scholar writing about another culture?

The controversy made me realise, as I had not realised before, that, as a scholar living outside India, I had the chance, indeed the duty, to write things that would have landed an Indian author in jail or worse. Of course, the view from outside can never capture the intimacy of reports by writers who lived there and experienced the oppression first-hand. But at the same time, an author who lived outside of India (and was willing



to give up the great pleasure of ever visiting India again) had a kind of special privilege, that could be regarded as a duty, to speak out.

In hindsight, would you have done anything differently with that book?

I would not change what I wrote about Hinduism, which was based on texts I knew well and was, I still feel, highly relevant to our understanding of what happened in India since about 1,500 BCE, when our first records appear, and also since 1947. But I wish I had called on my colleagues in the study of India during the period of the Mughals and the British Raj for more help in writing those chapters. I am not familiar with the primary sources for these times, and those chapters are rather weak.

If a student came to you today wanting to study mythology the way you did — combining rigorous philology with a willingness to provoke — what would you tell her?

I would love to have such a student! I would, of course, still insist on the philology — history is in the texts, as well as the archeological record, and it is such a pleasure to get to know the texts, and everything else follows from that. But the 'willingness to provoke' has become so much more dangerous, in both India and the United States, since I published *The Hindus* that I could not, in good conscience, advise any student to go out on the limbs I went out on in 2009.

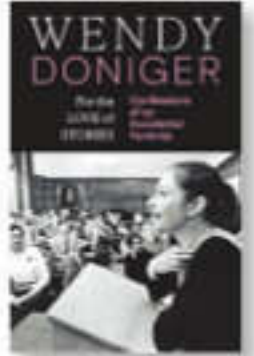
Your work speaks of the diversity of Hinduism. Do you recognise that in the Hindu nationalism that has come to characterise India's political life?

Hinduism is so much more various than any other religion I know of, that even in the narrow Hindutva ideology, there are bits and



PHOTOS: WENDY DONIGER

OUTSIDE IN
Wendy Doniger; (above left) Doniger riding a horse as a young woman



FOR THE LOVE OF STORIES: CONFESSIONS OF AN ACCIDENTAL FEMINIST
WENDY DONIGER
Speaking Tiger
384 pages
₹899

pieces that a student of Hinduism can recognise — a bit of the Gita, an image from a Krishna-Lila, instances of Hindu chauvinism, including sexism and anti-Muslim discourse. But Hindutva swallows up these historic chards in an ocean of contemporary bigotry — railing against Muslims, women, and other perceived enemies of the 'true' religion — that ignores the great diversity that is the glory of Hinduism.

You write of the pleasure of scholarship that you encountered both as a student and for the greater part of your academic career. That world of academic freedom, you write, seems no longer a possibility, not just in India, but also in America, because of the twin onslaught of politics and AI. How do you see the way forward?

I have taken refuge in what my friends and I call Ostria (my mother actually came from Austria), the land of the ostrich. When I contemplate the impact, in my country, of the politics of the rich, and the backlash against the movements that tried to fight racism and sexism, and the corruption of intellectual life by the widespread use of AI, I put my head back in the sand.

You speak of your tryst with ageing, of time stopping when you retired in 2018. Do the academic and the individual approach age differently?

As an individual, I share the experience of all humankind in coming to terms with ageing and death. But as an academic, particularly one who has devoted her life to the

study of religious texts that constantly interrogate the meaning of life and death and that have come up with some very compelling ideas about it (*karma*, rebirth, the four stages of life, to mention just the most obvious), I found myself drawing upon Hindu ideas to make sense of my own life. Even the simple idea of the Kali Yuga (the last of the four Ages, in which virtue vanishes and violence and chaos reign) explains so much of what is happening now in both the US and India.

After a lifetime of studying stories of gods, rebirth and mortality, how do you perceive death? Is there any one myth that gives you comfort?

The wisdom of the texts has seeped into me over the decades, and I find myself drawing upon the Hindu texts alongside some of my favourite passages from both the Hebrew Bible and the New Testament (and Shakespeare, my other Bible). The concept of *vairagya*, the idea of the final stage of life as a time for withdrawal from society and dedication to contemplation, suits me well. But I have also written, in the memoir, about the Mahabharata text in which Yudhishtira tries to take his dog with him into heaven; the Hindu attitude to dogs poses a problem until the dog turns out to be an incarnation of the god Dharma (who also happens to be Yudhishtira's father). The dog vanishes when he is replaced by Dharma, but in my version, he remains a dog and stays with Yudhishtira in heaven. And so I spend my *vairagya* with my beloved dog (a cavalier King Charles spaniel), and will take my chances of getting to heaven with him beside me.

In Love & In Defiance

Why Faiz Ahmad Faiz's words continue to resonate across borders and generations, as protest anthems

Rakhshanda Jalil

A SITTING judge of the Supreme Court of India. Striking factory workers. University teachers on *dharma*. Students from elite management and technical institutes building bridges of solidarity with less privileged peers from government-funded universities. Citizens across the country filling the streets in angry demonstrations against the CAA, SIR or paper leaks. Different places, people, circumstances, yet when it comes to finding a voice, they find it in the words of the Urdu poet Faiz Ahmad Faiz (1911-1984). Belonging to the much-reviled neigh-

bouring country, writing in a language viewed with mistrust, if not hostility, by certain sections of Indian society, invoking a set of symbols and images that are unabashedly drawn from an Islamic framework, relying upon a prosody and vocabulary that is exquisitely musical, though often drawn from the world as he saw it — what is the secret behind the enduring appeal of his words? That too of a man who died over 40 years ago, and had last visited India in the early 1980s when millennials, let alone Gen Z, were not even a word!

And yet, miraculously, he has remained in the public consciousness of successive generations of Indians, his words pulled out,



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

VERSES OF
DISSENT
Faiz Ahmad Faiz

like rabbits from a hat, to instantly invoke resistance, protest, solidarity. If anything, as the juggernaut of change rolls slowly but surely across India, he has had a second coming of sorts: with more transliterations than ever before in Devanagari and Roman, sharp and sassy memes and Insta-worthy posters, his face and words popping up on

mugs, coasters and tote bags. Why?

Yes, he is a fantastic poet, possibly the last of the greats who were rooted in the classical tradition, equally comfortable with the time-honoured *ghazal* as also the newer *nazm*, which he made uniquely his own. Yes, the test of good poetry, in fact any literature, is that it must rise above its time and circumstance and continue to speak to readers long years after it was first written. And, yes, in the words of Mirza Ghalib, our very own master of the Urdu *ghazal*, who famously declared: '*Goya yehi mere dil main hai ...*' (this too is hidden in my heart), Faiz touches his listener's heart in unexpected ways, making one gasp and then sigh.

But there are other great poets, both homegrown and from across the hated border: Habib Jalib, Ahmad Faraz, Jaun Elia being some who enjoy a fair amount of popularity in India. Why does Faiz rise above them like a colossus? Why is he the default option when it comes to singing songs of protest? Why are *Hum Dekhenge*, *Mujhse pehli si mohabbat mere mehbub na maang*, *Nisaar main teri galiyon pe ai watan ke jahan*, *Bol ke lab azaad hain tere...* the chosen anthems of resistance for Indians? And not just in pockets of north India where these words can be understood but in towns and cities where the words may be unfamiliar but the sentiment is not.

For, it is a truth universally acknowledged that injustice, tyranny, persecution have a universal language. When Faiz speaks of dipping his pen in his heart's blood, or creating a garden in one's heart when the outside world turns hostile, he holds out hope; when he talks of being unable to walk with one's held high or breathe under the weight of oppression, he is bearing witness for all those who have been humiliated or tortured. Or even when he invokes images from Islamic history such as removing idols from inside the holiest sanctum, Faiz speaks at a subliminal level, one that is beyond narrow sectarian differences.

Coming to his most recited poem, the solemnly sonorous, eminently singable *Hum dekhenge*, perhaps it 'speaks' across the picket fence of language and location because it contains a promise: One day the oppressed will occupy their rightful place when the tyrants will be vanquished and Truth shall prevail. Written in 1979 in response to General Zia-ul-Haq's repressive regime, it is as much a song for Faiz's country reeling under a dictator as for people anywhere in the world fighting oppression at any time. For India and Indians today, it is a prophecy.

Jalil is a Delhi-based writer, translator and literary historian

As *Dil Chahta Hai* completes 25 years, director Farhan Akhtar recalls the instinct, experimentation and attention to detail that went into creating the film

Alaka Sahani

TWENTY-FIVE YEARS after *Dil Chahta Hai* changed the way friendship, youth and urban India were represented on screen, its writer-director Farhan Akhtar looks back at the film’s enduring success. Released on August 10, 2001, the debut film is credited for bringing in a fresh cinematic style in Indian cinema with its natural conversations, carefully designed characters, impressive casting and catchy music.

Since then, Akhtar has gone on to direct *Lakshya* (2004), *Don: The Chase Begins Again* (2006) and *Don 2* (2011) as well as act in successful movies such as *Rock On!!* (2008), *Lucky by Chance* (2009), *Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara* (2011) and *120 Bahadur* (2025). In this interview, Akhtar talks about the instinct that drove his first film, why its dialogue and portrayal of friendship continue to resonate and why he launched Excel Origins, with his partner Ritesh Sidhwani, to support new voices.

How do you feel about the fresh surge of love for *Dil Chahta Hai*?

Mainly gratitude. When someone makes a film, especially their first one, you really don’t know how it would shape up. With the passing years, the love for *Dil Chahta Hai* has grown. I was lucky that when it came out, the environment was such that the film broke the kind of clutter that existed then.

What drove you to write and direct it?

I was pretty confident when I was writing and making the film that people would want to watch it. It had passed through several creative checks. Its producer Ritesh Sidhwani, the actors and members of the crew reacted positively when they first heard the script. When we did our early screenings, the reactions were really good.

However, when a film’s release draws closer, doubts creep into one’s mind. You may look at one of those Olympic diving boards that’s 30 metres up in the air and you’re like, of course, I can jump from there. But when you stand at the edge and look down, it’s a whole different experience.

How did you choose the cast?

That was a combination of instinct and having no choice. Nobody knew who I was and all they knew was whose son I was. I got a lot of rejections from people. Initially, I wanted Akshaye Khanna, Hrithik Roshan and Abhishek Bachchan as lead actors. But life had other plans. The two people who said they would do my film and stuck by it were Akshaye and Preity Zinta. So, Aamir Khan, Saif Ali Khan and Dimple Kapadia coming on board was just amazing.

***Dil Chahta Hai* has also been praised for its technical excellence. How did the crew come together?**

I had seen two films of Ravi K Chandran, *Virasat* (1997) and *Snip!* (2000). I liked the way he shot them. When I met him, he told me about Suzanne Caplan Merwanji, the production designer whom he worked with on *Snip!*. Ravi, Suzanne, Arjun Bhasin, who was then an upcoming costume designer, and I had synergy from the word go and started putting together the film’s look and feel. All of us wanted to do something that had not been done before. We were very



When Hindi cinema found its cool

particular in terms of selecting colour palettes for each character, choosing props for each character that would represent their personalities.

Now, 25 years later, has that pursuit for newness waned?

No, I don’t think so. We have enough films that tell stories differently. *Superboys of Malegaon* (2024) that Reema Kagti made, is a clutter-breaking film. But what the audiences want to watch also keeps evolving. These last couple of years, we are kind of, in this phase of alpha heroes which, I think, is peaking now. Something will come along that will feel fresh.

In 1988, when I watched *Qayamat Se Qayamat Tak* (QSQT), it felt like a fresh breeze. Before that, there were no films being made for a young, school-going crowd. A lot of vulgarity had crept into films in the ’80s — almost kind of a weird exploitation. After QSQT, movies like *Maine Pyar Kiya* (1989) and *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* (1995) followed.

What is the film’s emotional core?

At the heart of it all, it is a celebration of friendship. It’s also about growing up together. What *Dil Chahta Hai* really does is it takes the friends from a place of imma-

FINDING THAT VOICE
(Above) Farhan Akhtar; a still from *Dil Chahta Hai*

turity to a place of maturity.

Which track was easy to write and which was the most challenging?

Probably the easiest to write was Sameer’s (Saif) track because you could have a lot of fun with him. For Akash (Aamir), we had to find a balance. He’s the one who changes the most. But, the one that required the most rewrites was Sid’s character (played by Akshaye). I didn’t want him to come across as preachy. He needed to be a fun guy and not so philosophical that it starts grating on your nerves.

Some believe that the women characters did not get as much screen time as the boys did.

I agree. The film is about the three boys. But none of the female characters were written as weak. Dimple’s Tara, to me, had probably the strongest effect in terms of the relationship of the three boys. She, in a way, drives Sid and Akash away from each other.

Pooja, played by Sonali Kulkarni, is an independent woman, who instills the confidence in Sameer that one should marry the person one loves. Shalini has her own way of fighting back by doing the things that her fiancé is kind of upset about. It’s almost like a silent protest.

With this movie, you instantly stepped out of your father Javed Akhtar’s shadow. Was that ever on your mind?

It was on his mind. No one was happier than him that that had happened. I narrated the script to him only after Aamir came on board. The first thing he said was: “It’s really good. The best part of it is that it’s an original voice and it’s not an echo.”

After this, you directed *Lakshya* and *Don*. Then, you went on a different journey as an actor, singer.

I never thought about acting till *Rock On!!* came along. The film felt right to me in terms of the script and Abhishek Kapoor was convinced about my casting. I loved the experience, which is why I thought let me challenge myself. I’ve fortunately got many opportunities to do roles that have really pushed me in terms of commitment.

Singing is something that I’ve always enjoyed. I’ve enjoyed playing guitar and jamming with my friends. Never thought



of doing it professionally on stage. That changed in 2012-2013 when I really wanted to go out and interact with the youth and speak about gender equality and other things. We used music as a mode to reach out to them.

Did you carry something from *Dil Chahta Hai* when you acted in *Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara* (ZNMD)?

I didn’t but it did feel like I’m revisiting that world. On some level, my character was like that of Sameer. It was fun to do that role. Such films, when they are written well, and the team comes together, are the nicest filmmaking experiences you can have.

In one of his interviews, Saif said that you are born to direct.

That’s a sweet way of telling me: ‘Stop acting’ (laughs). I intend to direct soon. When the time is right, we will talk about it.

You play Pandit Ravi Shankar in Sam Mendes’ *The Beatles - A Four-Film Cinematic Event*.

Unfortunately, I can’t talk about it. But I’m just happy to be on that project.

Your partner at Excel Entertainment Ritesh Sidhwani and you have announced Excel Origins. What’s the idea behind it?

When we were young and looking to make our first film, it was important that we had people who believed in it. Life has been really good to us. It’s a good time to support young voices who are in that same place as we were in our early 20s.

We have incredibly talented storytellers in this country. A lot of them don’t find the right avenues to be able to show their talent. Our intention is to find projects that are not going to be echo of something that’s already out there.



BEING THE GODMA
Shabana Azmi in *Awarapan 2*

Beyond the Veil of Silence

Shabana Azmi, on her latest releases, *Batwara 1947* and *Awarapan 2*, and staying her busiest and most versatile at 75

Devansh Sharma

SHABANA AZMI is in no mood to slow down. Last month, she was seen marching alongside students to support those on hunger strike at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi as part of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) protests. After Delhi Police hurled tear bombs on the protesters, Azmi got an asthma attack. She subsequently got diagnosed with H1N1, which prevented her from participating in the Mumbai protests. Still battling bronchitis, the veteran actor could barely speak when SCREEN reached out to her for this exclusive interview. She has a busy month ahead. On August 14, she will be seen in two tentpole releases — Rajkumar Santoshi’s Partition drama *Batwara 1947* and Nitin Kakkar’s romantic action thriller *Awarapan 2*.

“To be offered such diverse parts at this stage of my career is pure luck, for which I’m grateful,” she says, recalling that the closest that comes to her films releasing on the same day was in the September-October fortnight of 1983, over 40 years ago. “*Avtaar*, *Masoom*, *Kaamyab* and *Yeh Nazdeekiyan* were shot within a fortnight of each other,” she says.

While her role is one of the primary characters in *Batwara 1947*, she has more of a “special appearance” in *Awarapan 2*. “I’ve played her almost indulgently rather than all fuming and blazing. One doesn’t need to display power. It reveals itself when it is understated and I find that more interesting,” says the actor, who will be seen going up against Emraan Hashmi’s Shivam Pandit as Nafeesa, one of the antagonists alongside Suvinder Vicky and Aniruddh Rawal, son of her *Fateh* (1991) and *Adharm* (1992) co-star Paresh Rawal.

In *Batwara 1947*, she shares screen space with Sunny Deol for the first time, just three years after she starred opposite his late father Dharmendra in Karan Johar’s 2023 hit family comedy *Rocky Aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani*. Between both the films, she also collaborated with Sunny’s cousin Abhay Deol on Faraz Arif Ansari’s slice-of-life film *Bun Tikki* (2025). “Only Bobby is left now,” she jokes.

An adaptation of Asghar Wajahat’s famous play *Jis Lahore Nai Vekhya Vo Jamya E Nai* features her as an elderly Hindu woman, who refuses to flee her ancestral *haveli* in Lahore, Pakistan, even during Partition, when a Muslim family from India is allocated her home. With this role, Azmi joins her longtime co-star Naseeruddin Shah (Imtiaz Ali’s *Main Vaapas Aaunga*) in supporting films which are revisiting traumatic cross-border events like Partition.

“The Partition and the cavalier manner in which the Radcliffe line was drawn is one of the most traumatic events in our history. For a long time, a veil of silence covered any mention of it, which in some cases made the wounds even deeper. For Partition, the historical irony may be that the veil of silence helped the first generation survive but, perhaps, made it harder for later generations to understand and metabolise what actually happened,” says Azmi. That’s why like Shah, she admitted that they owe the new generation their unequivocal alliance. Her faith in dissent and change now stands restored. “It was Nelson Mandela’s Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC, 1995) in South Africa that opened the doorway to revisiting past events, so that the stories of humanity that occurred were also recorded, along with the tragic severing of brothers from brothers.”

AZMI JOINS NASEERUDDIN SHAH IN FILMS WHICH REVISIT CROSS-BORDER EVENTS LIKE PARTITION. SHE SAYS THEY OWE THE NEW GENERATION THEIR SUPPORT

Devansh Sharma

CINEMA, MOVIES and film — all three mean the same but signify different aspects of filmmaking, said costume designer Maxima Basu. She is best known for her work in blockbuster films such as Sanjay Leela Bhansali’s period war dramas *Bajirao Mastani* (2015) and *Padmaavat* (2018), Anusha Rizvi’s 2010 black comedy satire *Peepli Live* and Payal Kapadia’s *All We Imagine As Light* (2024).

“While cinema is the social narrative and film is the technique, movie is the branding and associations. If you want to be a professional, you need to master all three,” said Basu. She was talking to Screen



Academy fellows, including students from Satyajit Ray Film & Television Institute, Kolkata, at a Masterclass for Screen Academy. This is a not-for-profit initiative launched by The Indian Express Group in collaboration with SCREEN and supported by the Lodha Foundation.

Basu distinguished costume designing from styling, describing the latter as more individual, though styling also seeps into filmmaking at times. “Stylists can also be for films, mostly big-budget films in India. For instance, if I’m doing *The Devil Wears*

‘Good costumes are those you can’t see’

If you create magic, you can survive the industry, says costume designer Maxima Basu, at the Masterclass hosted by Screen Academy in Mumbai



Prada or *The Great Gatsby*, and they want Chanel onboard, then Chanel supplies the stylists. As soon as the stylist angle comes in, branding comes in,” she explained. While that’s the movie (branding) aspect, she emphasised on film (technique). “Costume departments are often told to make

changes at the last moment, and you are expected to create magic. If you can do that, you can survive in the industry. If you can’t, it’s not for you,” said Maxima Basu.

She recalled an instance on the set of *Bajirao Mastani*, close to the filming of Deepika Padukone’s popular dance song



DRESSING THE STARS
(Left) Maxima Basu; during the interaction in Mumbai

Deewani Mastani at a palace of mirrors. “Since Deepika wore the mehendi colour, I told Bhansali back dancers can’t wear peach because they would distract from the beauty of Deepika. Also, their costume mirror work should look like the background mirror. When you work with colour, you

focus on where the eye should go,” argued Basu, adding, “Often, we don’t notice the back dancers because they are the moving environment.”

She hailed Bhansali’s genius and eye for colour during the filming of the climactic *jauhar* sequence in *Padmaavat*. “Bhansali

is a master of colours. His genius is that instead of him making a hundred soldiers chase the women, he just kept a black dot of Khilji against a sea of red so that the red the Rajput women are wearing gets even more enhanced,” she said.

Contrast that to *All We Imagine As Light*, where cinematographer Ranabir Das chose a very specific blue tone to showcase Mumbai in monsoon. “We had to try 20 different kinds of blue to arrive at the colour he wanted,” said Basu. “It was easier for me to get approvals from Bhansali than it was from Payal and Rinku (Das). Because they would just say, ‘It doesn’t look correct’. And I could sense what they meant,” she added.

As far as the cinema (art) aspect of costume design is concerned, she said that the role of a costume designer is often misinterpreted as just sprucing up the glamour of the film. But it serves a far deeper purpose. She gave the example of *Peepli Live*, in which in order to make Shalini Vatsa look like the wife of Nathadas, they had to make her wear the same costume for a month. “Also, Anusha didn’t let her wash her hair for a month,” revealed the costume designer.

Basu also told the students that in order to stay true to the rural aesthetic of the film, she would get the costumes washed in the village lake. “Costumes aren’t done justice in writing. Even if the costumes are described on paper, they are mostly for a glamorous purpose instead of a logical one. But good costumes aren’t the ones you can see, but those you can’t see. The more noticeable your costumes are, the finer job you are doing,” she said.



DOWN IN JUNGLELAND

BY RANJIT LAL

AUTHOR, ENVIRONMENTALIST
AND BIRDWATCHER



RANJIT LAL

THE CALM IN THE CHAOS
A lake at sunset as still and clear as glass

The Elixir We Take for Granted

Water sustains every form of life, yet we continue to pollute, dam and destroy the very systems that keep us alive

IDON'T quite remember how we produced the two invisible, odourless gases but I do remember the conclusion of the experiment. We opened the tall, seemingly empty beaker and put a match to it. There was a pale blue flash, and a WHUMP, which made us jump back. We approached it warily... there, on the walls of the beaker were a few drops of water, seemingly produced out of nothing. It was miraculous. Of course, the two gases involved were hydrogen and oxygen, probably mixed in a 2:1 ratio.

Here was a substance — in liquid form without which no life on earth would be possible: Water. Water makes up for 60 per cent of our bodies, over 70 per cent of our brains and hearts and 80 per cent of our blood. If we lose even 2-3 per cent of this, we are dead of dehydration. We can go without food for days and weeks; without water, not more than two-three days. We cook with it, cool with it and revel in it.

Every form of life is dependent on water, from microscopic plankton and plants to giant redwoods, bacteria, insects, reptiles, amphibians, fish and, of course, mammals. As much as 70 per cent of the planet's surface is covered with it, providing an environment in which a whole host of creatures and plants live. Though only 3 per cent of the world's water is 'fresh' (and so potable), it seems enough. Much of it remains locked up in solid ice packs, miles deep, on the poles and the high mountain ranges like the Himalayas, gradually melting into liquid form that trickles down as streams, and then broadens into rivers, spilling into lakes, before returning to the ocean. Over land, the liquid is sucked up by trees and forests, and much of it released back into the air in the form of vapour, only to cool and pour down as rain.

As it is so indispensable, the best place to observe wild-life is over a waterhole or water body in the jungle. A sudden downpour after months of dry weather will see animals and birds of all sorts flock to it: Sometimes their thirst is so great that a lion and a deer will drink their fill at the same time. Thirst can be maddening: On a restricted liquid diet (1-1.2 litres/day), I have never felt thirstier; not so much because I needed it but because I couldn't have it. If you are ever stranded in a rainforest or baking desert, the 'first order of business' is always to find a source of fresh water.

Sadly, our treatment of this magic elixir beggars belief. We pee and poop in our rivers and lakes, industries gout huge quantities of toxic chemicals into them, we dump enormous quantities of plastic into our oceans. Every major (and probably) minor river in India is nothing but an open sewer, glutinous with sludge and stinking of decay, often all neatly covered up in a toxic layer of foam. In this, we bathe, do our laundry, drink and conduct our rituals. There is certainly no joy in immersing the ashes of a loved one in a river you can smell before you see. We believe that some rivers have the power to absolve our sins, to cleanse us. No one asks, of course, if that gives us the licence to commit even more evil, which we can wash away with another dip

Teamed up with gravity, water makes a weapon of mass destruction that is virtually unmatched, and by hacking down forests, damming rivers and telling them where to flow, we have aided and abetted this deadly liaison. For, when water gets mad, it takes no prisoners.

Even under normal circumstances, angry water can be awesome. Watch monsoon rollers thunder up a beach and you can virtually sense they have evil on their minds. To whisk you away and take you under... Those same waves, during a benign winter, will sigh at your feet and expire in a delicate frill of foam and bubbles.

Water can be utterly beautiful too: a waterfall pouring down a sheer cliff face, a lake at sunset as still and clear as glass, raindrops plinking down in puddles, drops-like pearls condensing on windows or eyelashes, silver droplets splashing into underground lakes, filtered and distilled by their passage through the rocks above it.

Step out early enough and you may see leaves with their edges coroneted with tiny round pearls of water — guttation — the extra they do not need or on a dewy morning when resting dragonflies turn into pieces of jewellery.

Water's greatest talent, of course, is its ability to dissolve practically everything — everything that enables us to live. It is a medium of transport par excellence, sucked up by roots and tree trunks and surging through our circulatory system carrying blood around, and even life-giving gases like oxygen, from which it was born.

All life emerged from water billions of years ago. Some forms evolved to eventually crawl onto dry land and make a living there but remained ever-dependent on it. As for us, on a hot summer's day, there's nothing to beat a chilled bottle of beer with condensation pearly on its sides.

Hussain Shahzad on how a roadside bread omelette became his door to the culinary world and the rewards of slow cooking

Heena Khandelwal

HOW LONG does it take to fry onions and tomato for the base of a dish? For Chef Hussain Shahzad, around 45 minutes. In the *kadhai* goes ghee, fortified with *kewra* water and rosewater. Once it stops sputtering, chopped onions go in, caramelised slowly until golden brown.

We are at Hussain's home in Bandra, a stone's throw from Veronica's and Papa's. He moved to this home over two years ago, ahead of the launch of Papa's — the 12-seater tasting-menu restaurant, easily the hardest reservation in the country right now. His cosy kitchen — dark wood, patterned tiles, a wooden rendition of *The Last Supper*, playful 'Ramen' and 'Sandwichshop' signs — is spotless now, though it wasn't always this way. It changed after Gautmi Sudhakar, his partner, entered his life.

"It used to be a bar, a bachelor pad," he says. It didn't even have a mirror until a month ago. It's also where half the city's most sought-after chefs land up, after a busy Saturday night; his bond with Varun Totlani of Masque is particularly warm. "It's hard to come by, because we all work such tough years," he says, stirring onions.

Today, though, isn't about the restaurant. He is making his mother's masoor pulao — a dish he ate once a week growing up in a Bohri household in Chennai, on days the family didn't eat meat. "*Aloo* was the default meat option. Mum would put fried aloo in to entice us." He wrote the recipe down only a few years ago, putting it on The Bombay Canteen's monsoon menu in 2023, topping with crispy fried potatoes to relive his nostalgia. It returned to the menu again in 2025.

The recipe came from his paternal grandmother, passed to his mother, who made it her own. "This is a very Bombay-style version," he says, adding overnight-soaked dal to a pressure cooker for two whistles. It's built in two parts: the dal, cooked almost dry, holding its shape but turning "moussey" when pressed between the palms; and the rice, layered on top. Potatoes, soy chunks, boiled eggs or meat can go in — but in tribute to the original, he leaves it as it always was.

Back to the *kadhai*, it's time for the seasoning. "Allow spices to bloom, not burn," he says. Tomatoes go in, cooked till they break down into a thick base. Rushing is where most people go wrong, he says, adding that it's also why restaurant food tastes so different from home food. The patience he shows in caramelising onions mirrors his career — staying at it, one dish, one menu, one restaurant at a time, before the awards, the interviews, the cover stories came his way.

Cooking, for Hussain, began as a necessity long before it became his love language. "When my parents got divorced, I went to stay with my mom. She started working to



SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

CHEF AT HOME

STAYING AT IT, ONE DISH AT A TIME

support me and my younger brother Abbas," he says. With no one home after school, a 14-year-old Hussain began mimicking a roadside vendor's bread omelette. "That bread omelette outside Alsa Mall is where it all began." Cold coffee came next, then recipes lifted off Sanjeev Kapoor's *Khana Khazana*, scribbled down live off the TV.

This passion led him to culinary school in Manipal, a stint with the Oberoi Group, then Eleven Madison Park in New York, where watching chefs embrace their own heritage made him question why he hadn't embraced his. There, he met the late Chef Floyd Cardoz, co-founder and culinary director of Hunger Inc, and felt he had found someone doing something genuinely relevant with Indian food. Hussain moved to Mumbai in 2015 as a sous chef at The Bombay Canteen, unsure Indian cooking was even his lane. By the second or third menu, he knew this was it.

Eleven years on, he is executive chef across the group — The Bombay Canteen, O Pedro, Veronica's and Papa's. In 2023, the former Jude Bakery space came up — Ve-

SLOW AND STEADY
Chef Hussain Shahzad making masoor pulao in his Bandra home

ronica's below, Papa's in the attic above. "My first thought was we can't even have a lolo! But we decided to do a counter. I said it'll be a performance, a theatre," an idea he calls a collaboration of dreams shared with co-founders Sameer Seth and Yash Bhanage.

Papa's, by his own admission, was the menu that broke him the hardest — eight months to develop, the canvas completely blank. Today, it presents an elevated and adventurous take on comforting forms and flavours, putting a culture-defying stamp on Indian cuisine and dining traditions.

Back at the stove, he layers the pulao: smoked masoor dal at the base of a heavy-bottomed pan, mint and coriander leaves scattered over, then rice, finished with a generous pour of ghee. The lid goes on tight, and it sits on dum for 10-15 minutes. When he finally spoons it into a large bowl, there's something unmistakably boyish on his face — the same kid once copying recipes off the television screen, now running the most talked-about kitchen in the country, still finding joy in the one dish that never left.

MASOOR PULAO

MASOOR DAL

Ingredients: 2½ cups dried masoor dal, ¼ cup ghee, ½ tsp coriander powder, ½ tsp red chilli powder, ½ tsp turmeric powder and water as needed

Method

Heat ghee. Add powdered spices. Cook for 30 seconds. Add dal and water. Cook until just tender. Strain. Save the stock.

CARAMELISED ONION MASALA

Ingredients: 2 onions (thinly sliced), 1 tomato (sliced), 1½ tbsp garlic paste, 2 tsp ginger paste, 2 tsp green chilli paste, ½ cup ghee, ½ tsp turmeric powder, 1 tsp Kashmiri red chilli powder, 1 tsp coriander powder, ½ tsp cumin powder, ½ tsp garam masala, 1 tsp rose water, 1 tsp kewra water

Method

Heat ghee. Add rose water and kewra water. Add onions, cook slowly until caramelised. Add garlic, ginger and green chilli paste; cook until the raw smell disappears.

Cook the spices for

1-2 minutes. Add tomato. Cook until broken down into a thick masala. Add the cooked dal.

PULAO RICE

Ingredients: 2½ cups basmati rice, ¼ cup ghee, 1 onion (thinly sliced), 10-12 green cardamom pods, 2 green chillies (slit), 2-3 cloves, 1 tbsp chopped garlic, 1 tbsp chopped ginger, 5 cups reserved dal stock, chopped coriander and mint, salt to taste

Method

Heat ghee in a heavy pot. Add cardamom and cloves; cook until fragrant. Add garlic, ginger and green chillies; saute for 1 minute. Add onion and cook until golden. Add dal stock and bring to a boil. Add rice and salt. Cook until 90% done; drain excess liquid.

Spread the dal in a heavy-bottomed pot. Layer the rice over it. Drizzle with 1 tbsp ghee, cook on dum for 10-15 minutes. Rest for 5 minutes, then gently fluff. Garnish with mint and coriander and serve.

ART FUTURES

The Fibre of His Art

Kumar Misal's practice reflects the cyclical nature of his agrarian heritage, where the process is as important as the product



ANIK DUTTA



ART AND CHARLIE

Trisha Mukherjee

HIS PROFESSORS at Mumbai's JJ School of Art advised him to make larger works but Kumar Misal stuck to smaller pieces. "I just didn't have the money to buy bigger canvases or paper," says the 31-year-old artist from Kolhapur's Kumbhøj village (Maharashtra). Over a decade later, he is among the promising new voices in Indian art, most recently, receiving the Emerging Artists Award 2026 by FICA and Mrinalini Mukherjee Foundation. Addressing agrarian issues and Adivasi rights, Kumar's work is at once aesthetic, evokes empathy and serves as a socio-political tool.

Kumar was born into a family of farmers. He had an artistic bent of mind even as a child, but pursuing a career in art never occurred to him. He imagined his future in a secure government job. Like many young boys in his village, he appeared for state police exams. He cleared the written but he "couldn't pass the physical". A distraught Kumar found reassurance in his former teacher who had once advised him to think about a career in art. "I had ignored it. It did not seem realistic," he recalls. A failed attempt later, Kumar not just cracked the JJ School of Arts entrance exam but also ranked

second. That was, however, only a quarter of the battle won.

Without steady financial backing, Kumar remained a shadow occupant in the hostel. He spent the days in class and the nights painting commissioned murals across the city to make extra money. The hard work, though, only helped pay the bills. It wasn't doing much in terms of a creative breakthrough, which came only at the end of his bachelors, during a paper-making workshop in Kerala. "They used banana leaves to make paper. That made me realise I could use the

BACK TO NATURE
Kumar Misal at The Mayurbhanj Art Residency; (top left) Rawanth

vegetation at our farm to make my own paper," he says, sitting in the Belgadia palace, where he recently spent a month working with sabai grass artisans as the inaugural artist of The Mayurbhanj Art Residency.

This handmade paper, made with fibres of banana, corn and sugar extract, now gives his art its distinctive character. Not two papers are the same. In *Rawanth* (2023), the fleshy, translucent human form transforming into a banana plant printed on it. The paper's frayed edges are symbolic of the tension be-

tween man and nature. The more structured paper in *Varula* (2024) mimics the ordered form of the anthill it features. "Coming from a farming family, I prefer the process first and then its result, as in the practice of agriculture: before the grain becomes food, it needs to be sown," says Kumar, who did his Masters in Printmaking, also from JJ School of Art.

Kumar's subject of choice is topical but his practice stands out for its dynamism. Within three years, he has moved between semi-figurative, landscape, abstract and sculpture. With Kumar, you never know what's coming next. That is his biggest strength. Also, that he never leaves any medium behind. Unlike most artists, who have phases with a medium, Kumar keeps engaging with them, just in new formats.

During his residency at the Hampi Art Lab in 2025, he used the same corn and ba-

Within three years, Kumar has moved between semi-figurative, landscape, abstract and sculpture. His dynamism is his strength

nana fibres that form the base of his paper to create geometric layered sculptures resembling a microscopic view of the weave of a fabric. "I worked with Sakhi and Bunkai weaving units. Each thread comes together to make a fabric. It shows the significance of collective labour," says Kumar, whose works go upwards of Rs 50,000. He is represented by the Mumbai-based Art and Charlie.

The cyclical nature of his agrarian heritage reflects in his art and way of life. In 2021, he opened a studio with a friend in Mumbai's Ambernath. Kumar says, "It came together on its own. A senior rented it to us at a low cost, an ex-professor gave us a printmaking machine, and a friend, her books. It is for anyone who needs a space to work and doesn't have the resources. I had so much help when I was struggling. It is now my turn."